

NEW DELHI,
JULY 12, 2026LATE CITY
16+4 PAGES
₹7.00
(₹8 RAIPUR,
₹15 SRINAGAR)

The Sunday EXPRESS



EYE FOR THE LOVE OF SPORT

Himani Mor is a tennis champion in her own right. But there's more to it

SCREEN

Parvathy Thiruvothu on being a realist



DAILY FROM: AHMEDABAD, CHANDIGARH, DELHI, JAIPUR, KOLKATA, LUCKNOW, MUMBAI, NAGPUR, PATNA, PUNE, VADODARA

EXPRESS special

CHANGE DONE WITHOUT AMENDMENT OR NOTIFICATION AS REQUIRED

EC changes Form 6 for new voters, inserts section asking them about parents in SIR

E. EXPLAINED

Mandate to amend

Even as EC has introduced the SIR declaration in its on-line Form 6 portal, Section 28 of Representation of the People Act, 1950 says it is the Centre that can amend the Rules. These include any change to the forms as well — a process that has not been followed.

from electoral rolls in 10 states and three UTs in the EC's SIR
»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

A screening of the film *Satluj* at Jangpur village of Ludhiana on Thursday night. RAAKHI JAGGA

In Punjab villages, crowds at *Satluj* shows, a chorus: 'Those dark days should never return'

OTT 'ban' driving more to watch film as AAP, SGPC, Akali Dal hold screenings

Raakhi Jagga
Jangpur (Ludhiana), July 11

AT 8.30 pm on Thursday, a vacant plot next to the Guru Tegh Bahadur Sahib Gurdwara in Jangpur village of Ludhiana is packed. Women and men sit on mats, their heads covered, including with handkerchiefs, just like at a gurdwara. The elderly occupy plastic chairs, while the young are perched on the ground's boundary walls. Their eyes are glued onto an 85-inch screen playing *Satluj*.

The contested film on human rights activist Jaswant Singh Khalra that saw a brief OTT release before being blocked in India, has found a new life in Punjab, in similar mass screenings being held across the state.

Also seeing a new life are memories of "the *aukha* (dark, difficult) time" in Punjab, which those gathered at the Jangpur ground and elsewhere stress, "should not return".

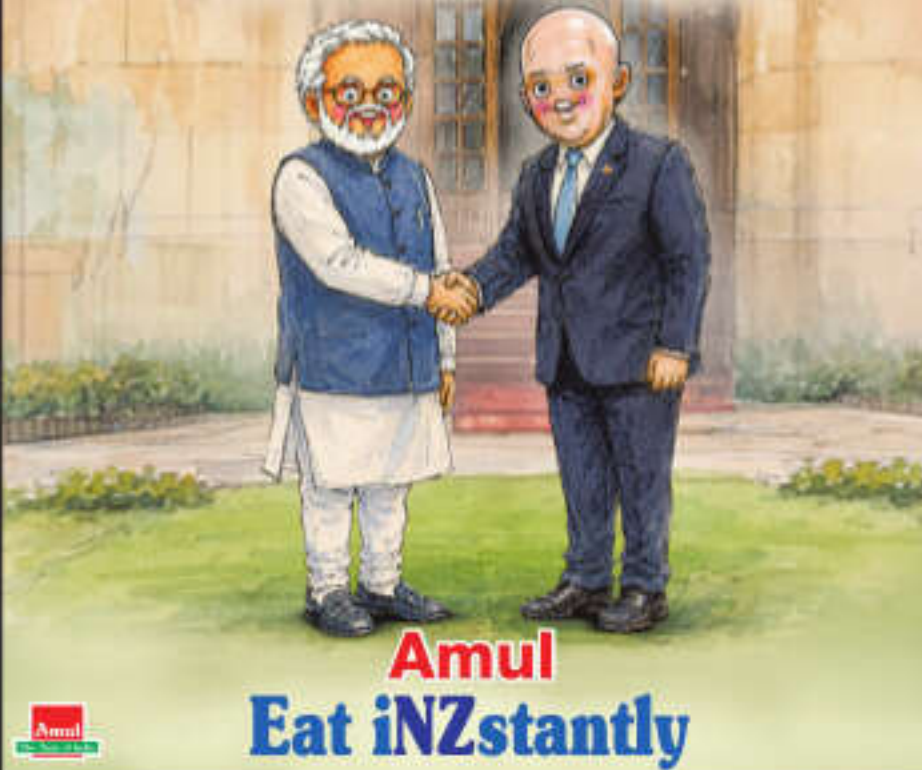
While gurdwaras and the SGPC were the first to
»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Govt panel raises UAPA spectre, 'misuse' by Pak

Apurva Vishwanath
New Delhi, July 11

IN ITS order recommending the film "*Satluj*" remain blocked from public access, the government panel has raised the spectre of the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act by observing that "Khalistan-related propaganda, foreign-based separatist mobilisation, and hostile information operations are continuing concerns, with
»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Strengthening bonds with New Zeal



Will seek extradition of Lawrence Bishnoi: US Justice Dept confirms

Divya A
New Delhi, July 11

DAYS AFTER indicting gangster Lawrence Bishnoi in a series of crimes including the killing of Canada-based Khalistan separatist Hardeep Singh Nijjar, the United States Department of Justice (DoJ) has confirmed that it will seek his extradition.

Arrested in 2014, Bishnoi is now lodged in a jail in Gujarat.

Responding to queries from *The Indian Express*, Ciaran McEvoy, Public Affairs Officer, US Attorney's Office, Central District of California, said in an



Held in 2014, Lawrence Bishnoi is lodged in a jail in Gujarat

email: "Bishnoi himself remains incarcerated in India. We intend to seek his extradition to the United States. (Extradition is a lengthy legal process and often takes years to complete.)"
»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

PM FLAGS BLUEPRINT FOR TRUST, TECH, TALENT

India and NZ pledge strategic partnership, to build on trade deal

Pacts signed on counter-terrorism, defence, sports, Antarctic research

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, July 11

INDIA AND New Zealand pledged Saturday to elevate their bilateral relationship to a "strategic partnership" with Prime Minister Narendra Modi and his counterpart, Christopher Luxon, endorsing its framework and "roadmap to 2030."

Both signed a range of pacts that included defence and maritime security, a target to double trade volume, a joint counter-terrorism panel to address pro-Khalistan concerns and a sports cooperation roadmap.

After the bilateral talks in Auckland, Modi, the first Indian Prime Minister to visit the
»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



PM Narendra Modi with New Zealand PM Christopher Luxon at an Indian community event in Auckland, Saturday. ANI

A century later, Dhyan Chand tour still unites two countries

Mihir Vasavda
Mumbai, July 11

WATCHING THE Prime Ministers of India and New Zealand reminisce about his father, hockey legend Dhyan Chand, on Saturday, Ashok Kumar's heart swelled with pride.

"I feel proud that a team of

Army men, and a humble soldier in that team, did something so remarkable that even after 100 years, the Prime Ministers are talking about it, and it still connects people from both nations," he told *The Indian Express*.

Long before he became the 'Wizard of Hockey', Dhyan
»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Happening today

● **CHIEF JUSTICE OF INDIA** Surya Kant will inaugurate the 'Tower of Justice' in Gurgaon. Touted as north India's largest judicial complex, it has 55 court-rooms with modern facilities.

TRACK THIS AND MORE ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

NATION

LEGENDARY PLAYBACK SINGER S JANAKI DIES AT 88
PAGE 9

15 Indians die in Vietnam boat capsize, were part of group on holiday organised by cellphone firm

Divya A & Nikhila Henry
New Delhi, Hyderabad, July 11

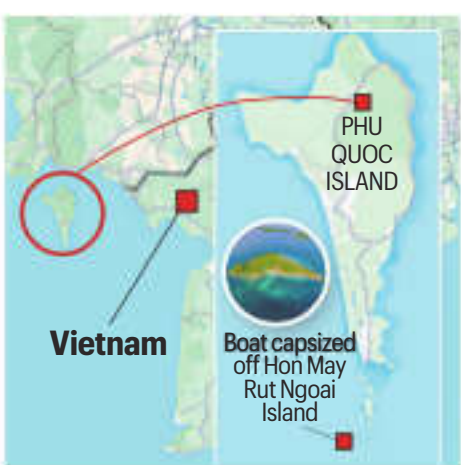
FIFTEEN INDIAN tourists lost their lives after their boat capsized near Vietnam's Phu Quoc Island on Saturday. The dead include 10 from Tamil Nadu, three from Andhra Pradesh and two from Kerala, the Indian Embassy in Hanoi said.

According to the Vietnamese news portal VN Ex-



A video grab of the incident, off Vietnam's Hon May Rut Ngoai

● Site of the incident



NATION

SURVIVOR'S TALE: 'GIANT WAVE HIT, TURNED BOAT UPSIDE DOWN'
PAGE 9

press International, the boat was carrying 32 Indian tourists and four crew members from Hon May Rut to An Thoi Port
»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

● SARVESH KUSHARE BROKE 8-YEAR-OLD NATIONAL RECORD LAST MONTH WITH A JUMP OF 2.31 METRES

31-yr-old high jumper scripts a first for India: Top 3 in Diamond League debut

Prithish Raj
New Delhi, July 11

SARVESH ANIL Kushare, 31, a father of a two-year-old daughter, has become the first Indian high jumper to finish in the top three on his Diamond League debut. At Monaco on Friday night, he was even provisionally joint first for a while, before finishing third with 2.26 metres.

Kushare beat stars like Tokyo Olympic champions

Gianmarco Tambari and Mutaz Barshim. This year's world leader, Oleh Doroshchuk of Ukraine (2.32m), finished first, while Britain's Jack Kimani (2.30m) was second.

Kushare, who held his nerve in a high-pressure competition, joined an elite list of Indian athletes who have finished in the top three at a Diamond League meet — javelin star Neeraj Chopra, long jumper Sreesankar
»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



Sarvesh Kushare, 31, is now the oldest active Indian athlete to hold a national record. AFI

NABARD

45th FOUNDATION DAY

Celebrating 45 Years of Commitment to Rural Prosperity

National Bank for Agriculture and Rural Development

www.nabard.org
[Taking Rural India >> Forward](#)
[/nabardonline](#)

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

India, NZ

country in 40 years, said: “This marks the beginning of a new chapter in our relationship. Our shared, firm belief in democratic values creates a natural comfort for India and New Zealand to move forward together.”

PM Luxon reciprocated: “It’s a truly historic event...a significant milestone in the New Zealand-India relationship.”

Recalling his first visit to India in his mid-20s, when he worked for Unilever, Luxon said: People got paid daily wages in coins in their hands. It’s interesting to me that under PM Modi’s leadership, he has lifted 250 million people out of poverty. There is now 440 million people in the middle class, about to be 750 million by the end of the decade. It is an incredible transformation.”

India and New Zealand agreed to double bilateral trade to NZ\$7 billion or Rs 35,000 crore by 2030, in the context of the Free Trade agreement signed in April this year.

Flagging the FTA signed in “record time” Modi said the trade deal “will open new doors for industries, farmers, and the youth of both nations.” Beyond trade, Modi underlined a “blue-print based on trust, technology,

and talent,” that will power bilateral ties to “double our trade volume over the next five years.”

“We also warmly welcome New Zealand’s commitment to invest 20 billion dollars in India. This will provide New Zealand companies with the opportunity to become long-term partners in India’s growth story,” he said.

The joint statement said that the Prime Ministers highlighted cooperation under Combined Task Force 150 (CTF-150) in 2025, with New Zealand in command and India as Deputy Commander, supporting efforts to deter narcotics smuggling, terrorism, and illicit maritime activity in the Middle East and the Western Indian Ocean.

According to the Ministry of External Affairs, the two sides decided to establish a maritime security dialogue to strengthen cooperation, coordination and information exchange.

The two leaders reiterated the importance of dialogue and diplomacy, and adherence to international law to achieve a peaceful and lasting solution to the West Asia conflict. Urging “all parties to exercise restraint, de-escalate tensions, and ensure protection of civilians,” they called for “full restoration of freedom of navigation and the global flow of commerce through the Strait of Hormuz,

while opposing any constraints on shipping.”

The joint statement underscored stability in the Indo-Pacific and the importance of “transparent, and resilient supply chains.” It noted how disruptions have affected Pacific Island countries, where economies are “heavily exposed” and higher oil prices are driving inflation across sectors “placing significant pressure on social well-being and fiscal sustainability.”

Both leaders condemned the Pahalgam and the Red Fort terror attacks and stressed that those responsible for the attacks should be held accountable.

“The two leaders agreed to strengthen cooperation in combating terrorism and violent extremism. The leaders welcomed...establishing a Joint Working Group on Counter-Terrorism which will provide a framework for information and knowledge sharing,” the joint statement said, in the context of concerns from pro-Khalistan elements in New Zealand. This is significant since New Zealand is a Five-Eyes intelligence partner along with the US, UK, Canada and Australia.

The two sides also signed a pact for enhanced cooperation in animal husbandry and dairying through technical collaboration, knowledge exchange, and

best practices. They also decided to launch the ‘KiwiFruit Action Plan and Establishment of two Centres of Excellence for KiwiFruit in Nagaland and Uttarakhand’.

The India-New Zealand Joint Action Plan on Sport will provide a framework for collaboration in sports. The two countries also signed a pact on collaboration in Antarctic research.

Modi, who wrapped up his three-nation trip in Auckland, also got a special Maori welcome. Luxon highlighted the deep cultural alignment and the unprecedented momentum injected into the bilateral relationship. “It is fitting that your visit coincides with Matariki, the Maori New Year, which is, of course, a time to remember, to reflect and to look ahead. The same star cluster is known in Indian tradition as Kritika. Though called by different names, we share the same stars, and we share the same hope for prosperity and renewal,” he said.

Modi said, “I extend my heartiest congratulations to all of you on the Maori New Year, Matariki. Just as the star cluster here is named ‘Matariki’, as you also mentioned, it has been known in India as the ‘Kritika’ constellation since ancient times. I am confident that this year of ‘Matariki’ will inspire our relations to shine like these stars.”

Satluj

announce these screenings, the Akali Dal and now the ruling Aam Aadmi Party are also showing the Diljit Dosanjh-starrer. One of the screenings held by the AAP on Friday — with the film played on a mobile and projected onto the side of a van — was near the house in Dugri, Ludhiana, where Dosanjh moved to study music as a boy.

The Inter-Departmental Committee set up by the Centre to review *Satluj* has recommended that the movie remain blocked from access in the country as it has the potential to threaten the security of the State.

In an interview to *The Indian Express*, Khalsa’s daughter Navkiran Kaur Khalsa said that this, however, is having the opposite effect. “Ironically, the attempt to stop the film has drawn more attention to it. People are now reading about that period, discussing it and asking questions. That, in itself, is significant... Khalsa has haunted the system for three decades because the issues he raised have never been fully addressed. Until the truth is confronted honestly, his story will continue to return.”

In Jangpur, Thursday, this seems evident. The screening is organised by supporters of Dakhla MLA Manpreet Singh Ayali, who is vice-president of the Akali Dal Waris Punjab De (WPD), a

splinter group of the Shiromani Akali Dal floated by supporters of jailed Independent MP and alleged Khalistan sympathiser Amritpal Singh.

Jasdeep Singh Jassa, who is overseeing the arrangements, says: “We contacted a DJ and he brought a downloaded copy of the movie. We are paying Rs 5,000 for one screening.” Jassa plans to hold three of those, “because everyone cannot watch it in a single evening”.

As he speaks, Gurdev Kaur, who is in her 70s, quietly walks out of the screening venue and sinks into a chair. Villagers rush to offer water, saying she has been unwell and felt uneasy.

Gurdev has another explanation. One hour into the film, she felt she couldn’t take any more. “*Oh sama dubara nahin chahida... Bhot aukha si* (We don’t want those days to return... They were extremely difficult).”

Jaswant Singh, 61, has come from around 2km away, with his wife and brother. “Had they not removed the film from OTT or created controversy, people probably would not have gathered in villages to watch it,” he says.

It’s all politics and vested interests, he adds. “With elections approaching, the timing is perfect... We know everything.”

During the height of the militancy, Jaswant had moved his entire family to West Bengal where he was posted in the Army. And so he cautions against reading too much into

people flocking to the screenings. “*Eh film nu movement na samjho* (Don’t mistake this for a movement). It’s just an attempt to revisit our painful past.”

Around 9 km away, at Gahour village, a screening at a park near a gurdwara has drawn over 1,000 people. Around 9pm, the organisers who are workers of the Sukhbir Badal-led Shiromani Akali Dal announce a short interval, serving sherbat and samosas. One of the party workers, Vicky Chaudhary, says he has coordinated screenings at Mohi, Gahour and Sawaddi villages.

There is no politics behind it, Chaudhary, 52, insists. “We simply want people to know their past... and learn lessons so that such an era never returns.”

At the screening at Dehrka village about 40 km from Ludhiana city, Akali Dal leader Chand Singh Dalla is present. While announcing another show at his native village the next day, he suddenly falls silent.

A villager explains in a whisper: “His uncle was picked up in the early 1990s and never returned.”

Later, Dalla talks about the episode. “He was a doctor and a retired Army man. Four men in civil clothes and carrying carbines arrived, forced my uncle into their vehicle and drove away. That was the last time we saw him.”

It was often hard to tell who the perpetrator was, Dalla adds. “Nearly 20 youngsters from our

village died during that period. Some in rivalries, some after being picked up by police, perhaps others at the hands of militants. God alone knows.”

A 75-year-old retired Punjab State Electricity Board employee from Mullanpur, who does not want to be identified, worries about “the politics behind the row”. “The movie shows what happened during Congress governments and later. Now different parties have their own political interests in taking the film to villages,” he says, pointing out that Congress-turned-BJP leader Ravneet Singh Bittu’s motive seems to be to defend his grandfather Beant Singh, who headed the Congress government in the state at the time of Khalsa’s killing. (Khalsa disappeared six days after Beant Singh’s assassination.)

At Jangpur, Dilip Singh, 24, says that as a youngster who did not see the period, he wants the government to know “not to fear the past”. “We watched *Satluj* because we were stopped from watching it. The government should let people realise what happened.”

At Sawaddi village, organiser Aman Sawaddi feels the film ban, the screenings may turn out to be for the best. “Were we not watching the film together, perhaps we would never have recalled those horrific times so vividly.” It is making their resolve stronger, he adds. “May those days never return.”

Dhyan Chand’s tour

Chand was a soldier in the Indian Army. “*Duniya mein faujein banti hai goliyan chalne ke liye. Lekin Indian Army wahan gayi, aur goal se duniya ko chamatkar dikhaya* (Soldiers in the world are made to fire bullets. But the Indian Army went there, and with their goals, showed the world a miracle),” he said.

In Auckland on Saturday, Prime Minister Narendra Modi and his New Zealand counterpart, Christopher Luxon, paid tribute to the landmark 1926 tour that introduced New Zealand to the genius of Dhyan Chand. “A hundred years ago, our hockey team created history by coming here,” Modi said. “It inspires our sporting partnership even today.”

Hockey India secretary-general Bhola Nath Singh called it “a matter of immense pride.”

The New Zealand Herald’s first impression of Dhyan Chand, filed after an unofficial warm-up match against a Navy side in Auckland on May 13, 1926, read: “Four of the goals came from the stick of Dhyan Chand, a slightly-built youth, who played a remarkable game at centre-forward. His stick work and control of the ball were well-nigh perfect, and although he was a great individualist he always knew when to pass the ball.”

The tour had been almost two years in the making. Discussions between the New Zealand

and Hockey Association and the Army Sports Control Board began in late 1924, culminating in a formal invitation to the Indian Army in early 1925. Following trials in Lahore, the first-ever Indian hockey team was selected.

Captain David Tennant Cowan led the 17-member squad — four British officers, one Sikh officer and 12 Indian soldiers — who sailed from then Calcutta on April 11, 1926, embarking on a month-long voyage across the Indian Ocean and the Tasman Sea, Ashok Kumar said.

Every stop became another exhibition. The team defeated sides in Sri Lanka and Australia before arriving in Auckland on May 11, where anticipation had reached fever pitch. The unofficial opener against the Navy side at Remuera only heightened it. India won 11-1, Dhyan Chand scoring four times, justifying the praise that appeared in the next morning’s papers.

Six weeks later, on June 26, 1926, India played its first official international at Lancaster Park in Christchurch before nearly 14,000 spectators, according to stick2hockey.com. India beat New Zealand 5-2. Dhyan Chand scored a hat-trick, including the first goal ever registered by an Indian team in international hockey.

Peter Miskimmin, New Zealand



Dhyan Chand (third from left, standing) during the Indian Army tour of New Zealand in 1926. THAKAR SINGH FAMILY COLLECTION & SIKHSINHOKEY.COM

and’s head of sports diplomacy, sees the centenary as a platform to deepen ties between the two countries. “Sport is a part of the free trade agreement,” he told *The Indian Express*. “There are interests from New Zealand and India to share, learn and collaborate on sport.”

For Miskimmin, the connection is personal. His grandfather, Havilah Down, referred that first international in Christchurch. “The message went around about these wizards from India who were so clever,” he said. “In the end, I think they had scheduled only two matches, and they added a third one. Mainly because there was a huge demand from the public.”

The second match in Auckland drew more than 18,000, New Zealand winning 4-3. For the third, which ended 1-1, more than 25,000 packed Eden Park. “That tour had a huge impact on New Zealand. India returned several times through the 1950s

and 1960s, and its style of short passing, pace and ball control profoundly influenced the team that eventually won Olympic gold in 1976,” Miskimmin said.

The tour turned a profit too, £300 for the NZHA. Decades later, when India returned to New Zealand in 2009, Dhyan Chand’s son, Ashok Kumar, was the team’s manager. At a stadium in Wellington, an elderly man approached him. As a boy, he had watched Dhyan Chand play during India’s 1935 tour. “He told Ashok bhai, ‘I’ll show you a hockey stick your father gifted me,’” recalled Romeo James, then India’s assistant coach.

The next day, he returned with the stick, carefully preserved. “Ashok bhai asked if he could have it,” James said. “He smiled and replied, ‘Though you may be his son, I cannot give it to you. It was given to me by one of the greatest players in the world.’”

Bishnoi

Earlier this week, the US DoJ charged 37 people in the indictment as part of its ‘Operation Hardball’ — a coordinated action by law enforcement from the US, Canada and Europe which led to the arrest of 24 people linked to three Indian crime syndicates with transnational networks. Besides Bishnoi and his aide Goldy Brar, the other gang leaders who have been named in the US indictment are Jaggu Bhagwanpuria, who is lodged in an Assam jail, and Canada-based Ravinder Singh Dhand.

Bishnoi and Brar have been charged with ordering Nijjar’s assassination. The FBI has announced a \$50,000 reward for information leading to Brar’s arrest.

Extradition between India and the US is governed by the bilateral Extradition Treaty signed in 1997 and India’s Extradition Act, 1962. However, the most significant legal consideration in Bishnoi’s case is that he is in judicial custody and faces numerous criminal prosecutions in India.

This means India could legally argue that Bishnoi must first face trial — and, if convicted, serve any sentence — in the cases pending against him before any extradition takes place.

There is no clarity on when the US DoJ will send the request for Bishnoi’s extradition. As per procedure, the request would be prepared by the US DoJ and transmitted by the US State Department to India’s Ministry of External Affairs. The MEA, in consultation with the Ministry of Home Affairs and agencies such as the CBI, would examine whether the request conforms to the treaty and Extradition Act.

High jump

Murali and discus thrower Vikas Gowda.

Kushare’s journey from Devargaon village in Nashik, where he started with makeshift landing pits made of corn husks and sacks, to the world stage is a story in itself.

Speaking to *The Indian Express* from Devargaon, Kushare’s father, Anil, said his WhatsApp has been flooded with videos of his son’s jump. “Everybody in the village is putting his jump videos as their WhatsApp status. When he started high jump, I thought he would just improve our family’s fortune. But he has affected the entire village because children have started taking up high jump,” said the proud father.

Vietnam

when it capsized about 400 metres off Hon May Rut Ngaoi.

Most people on the boat were employees and distributors of Lava Mobiles, a company representative told *The Indian Express*. They were there as part of an annual outing.

According to officials, their return flight was on Sunday morning, and the boat ride was among the last leisure activities they had planned. The group numbered around 100 and took three boats, including the one that capsized. “We are in constant touch with the Embassy of India in Vietnam and the local authorities, and are closely monitoring the situation,” a spokesperson for Lava Mobiles, which manufactures smartphones, tablets, laptops, com-

puter hardware, and other consumer electronics, said.

Among those on the boat were a couple from Kerala, A C Thomas, 57, and his wife Loveny Thomas, 56, from Kollam district. Thomas was the managing director of Kottarakkara-based firm Victory Group, which distributes pharmaceutical and surgical goods, as well as the South Kerala distributor for Lava Mobiles, which had sponsored the trip. A family source said they left for Vietnam on Tuesday.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi, who concluded a three-nation visit on Saturday afternoon, said, “Extremely saddened to learn about the tragic news of a boat accident involving Indian nationals near Phu Quoc, Vietnam.”

He said the Indian Embassy and Consulate are providing all possible assistance.

boys picked up the sport. All of them changed the fortunes of their families by securing a job,” Jadhav said.

On Friday, when Kushare was jumping in Monaco, his current coach Jithin Thomas watched with anxiety, about 1,700 kilometres away in Spala, Poland, where Indian athletes are at a training camp for the Commonwealth Games.

“I had asked him to make history once, but this boy keeps on making a name for himself,” he said.

“It is a big moment for the Indian high jump scene. Before this, no Indian high jumper had participated in a Diamond League. Sarvesh showed that Indian jumpers are made for big leagues,” Thomas, who is a former high jumper and Asian Championships medallist, said.

Govt panel

multiple pro-Khalistan organisations listed as terrorist organisations under the UAPA framework.”

The film is based on human rights activist Jaswant Singh Khalsa and shows his death in police custody following his campaign to probe disappearances during militancy years in Punjab. It was pulled from OTT platform ZEE5 in India two days after its release on July 3.

The government’s Inter-Departmental Committee (IDC) rested its national security case on two grounds: pro-Khalistan organisations listed under UAPA, and the film’s “misuse” by Pakistan. Its July 9 order records that it “observed that the current security context of Punjab poses an immediate risk of the film be-

Form 6

that began last year, raising questions about the potential impact on their children. In the case of West Bengal, which saw an unprecedented process payout, over 27 lakh electors were deleted during adjudication and were unable to vote in the April elections while their appeals remain pending before tribunals.

The EC’s ECINET portal, as accessed Saturday, showed an un-lettered “declaration form” part inserted in between part “J” and “K” of Form 6 that asks for details of the applicant or their parents in the last SIR. But the copy of the Form 6 available for download on the same portal, ostensibly for filling and submitting physically, does not include this new declaration part.

This part of the form was visible for applicants from all states and UTs where the SIR has concluded in 2025-2026 or is currently ongoing, except for Bihar, which was the first state to have the SIR in June last year, and Assam, where the EC has decided not to hold the SIR.

While the new part has not been marked mandatory, the user cannot move forward to ward the submission before completing it.

It asks the applicant to pick from three options: “my name exists in Electoral Roll of last SIR; my parents name (Father, Mother, Grandfather, Grandmother) exists in the electoral roll of last SIR; neither my name nor my parents name exists in the electoral roll of last SIR.”

Upon selecting the first two options, the applicant is then required to provide the Assembly constituency, booth number and serial number of their or their parents’ name in the last SIR, which was held in the early 2000s or earlier this year for 12 states/UTs. In case the applicant cannot find the details, the only option is to select the third one. But the portal does not say what will happen if the applicant selects the last option.

CORRECTION

PAGE 17, 11.07.26

● In a photo caption on the ‘Express Adda’ page, former Indian Ambassador to Myanmar and South Africa, Rajiv Bhatia, was wrongly identified as K P Fabian. The error is regretted.

State, and such misuse by Pakistan has already begun with Pakistan-based actors using the film as evidence of Indian State brutality and oppression of Sikhs with the intent to spread separatist ideology in India.

It referred to Sikhs For Justice, a pro-Khalistan group declared unlawful under UAPA.

The committee also observed that the film’s “one-sidedness aligns with the structure of pro-Khalistan propaganda claiming that Sikhs have been collectively targeted, the State suppressed truth, international intervention is needed, violence against State figures has a moral context and is justified, and that Punjab’s relationship with India is under question.” It also underlined that the film “need not explicitly call for secession if it supplies the emotional and evidentiary building blocks of secessionist propaganda.”

FOUR KILLED IN GURGAON SHOOTOUT

SUV of accused changed hands thrice in 4 years before it was rented out to Nandal gang: Cops

A shooter rented SUV from current owner, say police

Alok Singh
New Delhi, July 11

INVESTIGATORS PROBING Thursday night's encounter outside businessman Vishal Beri's Gurgaon residence have found that the SUV allegedly used by the five accused changed hands three times in four years before it was rented out to the suspected members of the Deepak Nandal gang.

The five accused allegedly arrived in the Haryana-registered black SUV to extort Rs 10 crore from the businessman.

The five accused had allegedly arrived at Beri's residence in Sushant Lok Phase 1 to extort Rs 10 crore. Gurgaon Police Crime Branch personnel, who were in the area acting on a tip-off, intercepted them, leading to an exchange of fire in which four of the accused were killed. The



The SUV used by the accused in the attack. EXPRESS

fifth sustained injuries and is undergoing treatment.

"Three of the five alleged shooters are from Rohtak. One among them had rented the SUV from its current owner," an officer said.

According to the police, the Haryana-registered SUV (HR26FU5708) was first purchased by a Gurgaon resident from a showroom in 2022. He sold it to a used-car dealer in 2023, who later sold it to a buyer

in Rohtak. About a year later, the buyer sold the SUV to another person in Rohtak in 2025, from whom it was allegedly rented by one of the accused.

Speaking to *The Indian Express*, the first owner of the SUV said that although he had completed the ownership transfer and the vehicle's registration number had been changed, his mobile number continued to remain linked to the SUV. "Don't know how the mobile number

was never updated," the buyer said.

"I don't know why this happened, but I kept receiving chalan messages related to the vehicle until this month. The Haryana Police questioned me, and I have told them the same thing," he said.

Officers said they have also questioned the subsequent owners of the SUV and the used-car dealer.

An officer said that a Bahadurgarh resident, identified as Sandeep, may have been involved in providing logistical support, including the SUV and weapons, to the five accused. A team from Gurgaon Police on Friday conducted raids in Bahadurgarh and at several other locations across Haryana in search of him.

According to the police, Sandeep, a close associate of Deepak Nandal, was known to Nitin—one of the four men killed in the encounter. "Sandeep was allegedly involved in an attempt to murder case in Rohtak last year along with Nitin. Both were later granted bail," an officer said.

Mumbai Police gets hoax threat to 'blow' up Red Fort, security strengthened

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 11

Over 9 months after a blast near the Red Fort killed 11 people, a bomb threat targeting the iconic monument was received by Mumbai Police on Saturday morning. The Mumbai Police dialled up Delhi Police, following which security was stepped up at Red Fort and Chandini Chowk. The call later turned out to be a hoax, Delhi Police said.

According to the police, the call came during the early hours of Saturday to Mumbai Police control room, informing the officers that the Red Fort will be "blown" up.

"The Mumbai Police called saying that they have received a call regarding a possible bomb threat at the Red Fort. The information was shared with the North Delhi Police soon after," said a source. Police said security was immediately strengthened in the area, with police and bomb disposal squad



Security checks being conducted outside the Red Fort on Saturday. AMIT MEHRA

personnel conducting an extensive search. Efforts are underway to identify the caller and ascertain the motive behind issuing the fake threat, they added.

According to officers, within a month of the blast at a Metro station near the Red Fort last November, various steps have been taken to improve security around the area.

"The number of CCTV cameras installed in the area has gone up to 120 from 630. The cameras have an integrated data system of stolen vehicles, and can automatically detect number plates," an officer said.

"Also, facial recognition systems, containing integrated data of criminal records, have been mounted atop a minibus that patrols the whole area, con-

stantly monitoring faces in the crowd," the officer added.

Further, the officers said, personnel deployed at the Red Fort police post has been doubled from 17 to 35, while better lighting has been requested for at least 10 dark spots. Illegal occupation in the area has also been clamped down upon with over 500 FIRs registered against those who do not comply.

Reject 'flawed' SIT chargesheet: Parents to court in Gurgaon sexual assault case

Abhimanyu Hazarika
Gurgaon, July 11

MONTHS AFTER the Supreme Court transferred the probe in the alleged sexual assault of a three-year-old in Gurgaon to a Special Investigation Team (SIT), the father of the child has moved a local court and has claimed lapses in the investigation. Urging the court to reject the chargesheet filed by SIT in May and direct further investigation, the child's father in his petition filed on July 9 accused the SIT of running a "one-sided, incomplete and unreliable investigation".

The SIT, as per the petition, "inexplicably exonerated" three key suspects, including the domestic help who was working at the Gurgaon flat where the family lives, despite the toddler repeatedly identifying them. The former domestic help's brother-in-law was named as the prime accused in the case, and another domestic help, who worked at the upscale apartment complex, is the third suspect in the case.

This is not the first time that the family has approached a court for intervening in the matter.

The investigation in the sexual assault case had drawn Supreme Court's ire earlier this year after the parents of the child had claimed laxity by the local police.

The Indian Express had reported in March that the first investigating officer in the case allegedly delayed filing an FIR in the case by over a month before eventually getting arrested in an unrelated corruption case. On March 24, former Gurugram Police chief Vikas Arora had filed an affidavit in the top court, explaining the delay in lodging an FIR in the matter.

The child's father has now claimed that the chargesheet filed by the SIT on May 16 is "fundamentally flawed." It is "highly unlikely," the petition submitted in the top court

underlines, for a child of this age to fabricate such a traumatic incident. The SIT chargesheet itself "neither records that the child was unreliable, tutored or mistaken, nor assigns any reason whatsoever for discarding her repeated and consistent disclosures," it says.

When contacted, an SIT member said they did not have any response to give at this point of time, but would get back in the coming days.

Objections raised

■ On the chargesheet claiming that there was "no direct or indirect evidence" against the two domestic helps involved in the incident, including the one earlier employed by the family, and the third suspect initially arrested, the protest petition argues that the agency ignored evidence and vital admissions. "The SIT did identify a primary male accused based on digital footprints. However, the petition details how this accused, during custodial interrogation on April 15, explicitly disclosed the involvement of [Maid A] in the commission of the offence," it states.

■ Reiterating the claim that one of the domestic help's brother-in-law allegedly sexually assaulted the child, the father's petition questions how a stranger could have gained access to the child or synchronised his presence without the facilitation of the person holding exclusive custody of the toddler.

The petition also questions the SIT for over-reliance on a digital gate-management application and call detail records (CDRs) while ignoring basic forensic work. The SIT used "the gate-management app to absolve the suspects, a move the petition calls fundamentally flawed," it says. The app retains data for a limited period, and the SIT made "no effort to secure or retrieve historical server data," the petition notes. The case has been listed for hearing on July 16.

Govt plans to expand ladies special bus service

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 11

ALL-WOMEN staff, marshalls, CCTV cameras, and panic buttons; these are expected to be among the key highlights as the Delhi government plans to expand its ladies special service by adding around 50 buses with an aim to make public transport safer for women in the Capital, officials said on Saturday.

At present, the Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC) runs only a few such buses on two routes, according to officials. "This ladies special bus service was started when Congress was in power... later, these were run on 1-2 routes on special request. But DTC is now planning to im-

plement the scheme in a structured way by adding more buses and more features for increasing safety and security for women passengers," said a senior DTC official.

The government is planning to expand this service to 20-25 busy routes like Central Delhi and ITO and areas where prominent colleges and offices are located. These buses will also be deployed on routes that do not have extensive Metro connectivity.

"On such routes, women and college-going students will get to have better last mile connectivity with safety measures in place," said a government official, adding that these buses will run from 5 am to 11-12 pm.



Aadhaar ka App-grade

Update Existing Mobile Number Using Aadhaar App



CBC 54103/13/0037/2627

Aadhaar ka App-grade

From Line to Online



Scan to Download Aadhaar App, Now!



VIVEKANANDA INSTITUTE OF PROFESSIONAL STUDIES – TECHNICAL CAMPUS

Affiliated to GGSIP University

Grade "A++" Accredited for NAAC & NBA Accredited for MCA Programme

Recognized under section 2 (f) by UGC, Approved by BCI & AICTE

AU Block, Outer Ring Road, Pitampura, Delhi- 110034, Website: - www.vips.edu

Admission Notice for Management Quota (2026 – 2027)

Applications are invited from eligible candidates for admission under the Management Quota Seats (10% of the sanctioned intake as approved by GGSIP University) for following programmes:-

BALLB (H), BALLB (H), LL.B (3-Year), LL.M (CL), LL.M (ADR), B.Tech CSE, AI&ML, AI&DS, IIOT, Electronics Engg. (VLSI Design & Technology), CSE (Cyber Security), Computer Science & Applied Mathematics, B.Tech(LE), BBA(G)- 1st & 2nd shift, BBA-MBA (5-year integrated), B.Com(H)- 1st & 2nd shift, BA(JMC)- 1st & 2nd shift, MA(MC), BA Economics (H) - 1st & 2nd shift, MA(Economics), BA English (H), MA(English), BCA - 1st & 2nd shift & MCA.

Criteria for admission and reservations shall be followed as per the GGSIP University guidelines. Candidates aspiring for admission through Management Quota can apply online on the institute's portal or download the form from the institute's website www.vips.edu and deposit the same by paying Registration Fee of Rs. 2,500/- (Non-Refundable) against receipt issued by the institute between 11:00 A.M. to 02:00 P.M. w.e.f. 13.07.2026. Last date of submission of application form is 31.07.2026 up to 2:00 PM.

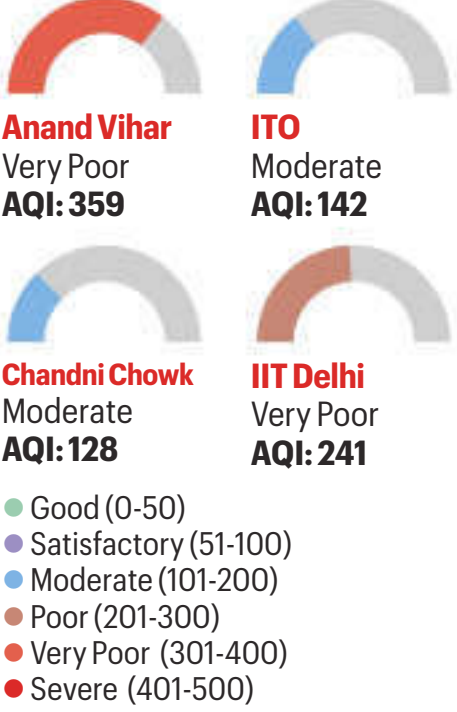
For detailed admission process and schedule of counselling, candidates shall visit institute's website (<https://www.vips.edu>) regularly.

Principal VIPS-TC

• Skywatch


Forecast: July 12, 2026
Partly cloudy sky
MAX: 37-39
3.5°C above normal
MIN: 26-28
1.7°C below normal

• AQI Tracker



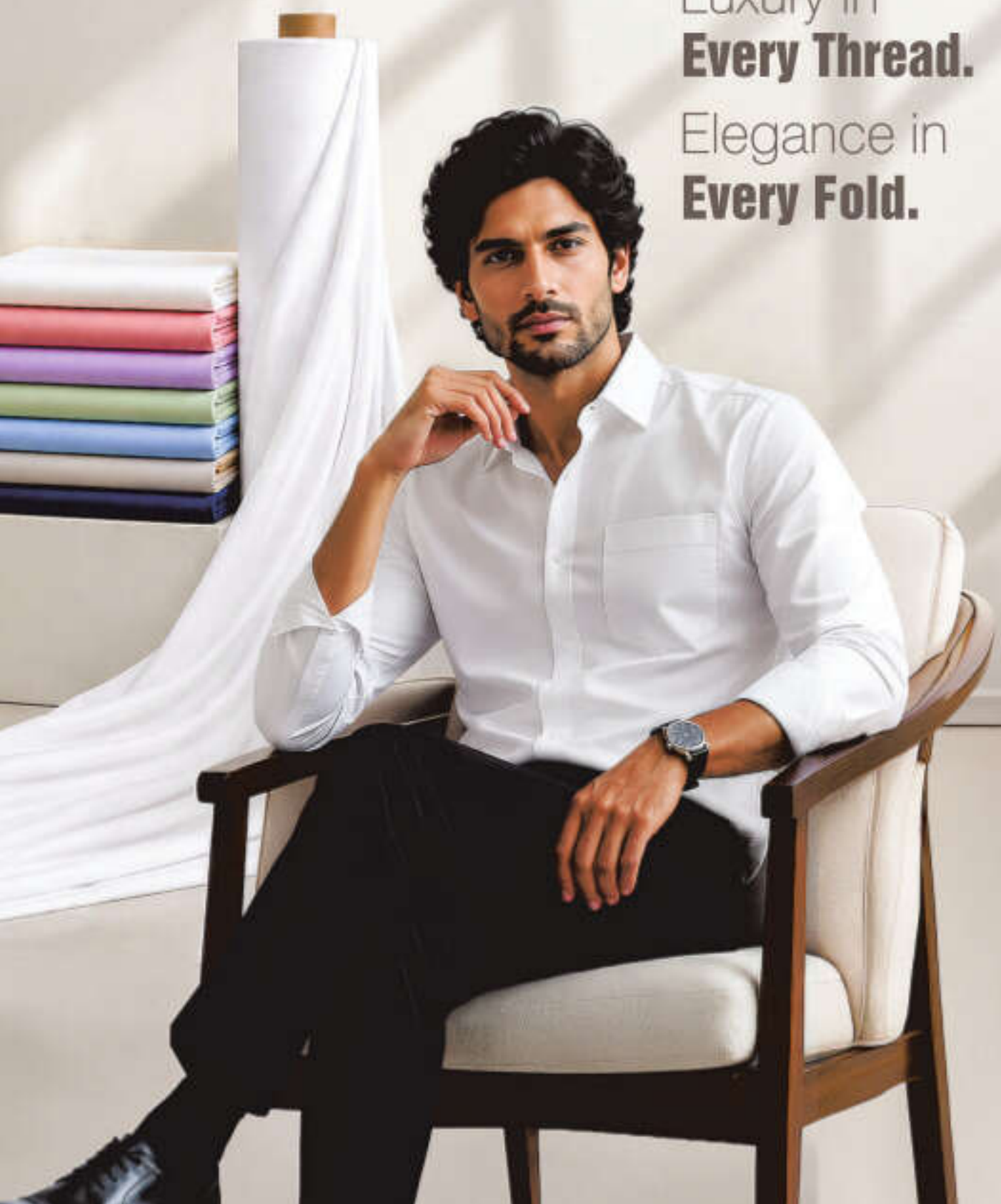
Ugandan woman held with drugs worth Rs 70 lakh

New Delhi: Delhi Police has arrested a 26-year-old Ugandan woman in the Mohan Garden area with 117 gm of amphetamine, a potent stimulant estimated to be worth Rs 70 lakh in the international market, officers said on Saturday.

Jackline Namulondo was allegedly supplying the synthetic drug to college students in the national capital, they said. Acting on a tip-off, police raided Jackline's rented accommodation in Mohan Garden on Thursday, and recovered a commercial quantity of fine-grade amphetamine from her possession, officers said. PTI



SHIRTINGS & SUITINGS



Luxury in Every Thread.
Elegance in Every Fold.

Distributors

Khaneja Traders, Fatehpuri. Ph : 84481 97497, 99680 62760
Anand Synthetics, Delhi. Ph : 98734 09199, 85955 20445

Available at all leading textile shops | Shop online at www.ramrajcotton.in



DELHI POLICE
SHANTI SEWA NYAYA

Protect Childhood Prevent Crime



Child Trafficking
Stranger danger is real-stay alert, stay together, stay safe.



Online Gaming Scams
Think before you click-fake rewards can lead to real losses.



Online Grooming & Exploitation
Not every online friend is a friend-protect your privacy.



Prevention of Missing Children
A aware child is a protected child, know who to call and where to go.



Emergency Response & Safety Measures
In danger, act fast-move to safety and dial **112/1098.**



STAY ALERT



STAY SAFE



STAY TOGETHER



STAY PROTECTED



SPEAK UP



CHILD SECURE

★ Together, Let's Build a Safer World for Every Child ★

Email to CP, Delhi at: cpdelhi@delhipolice.gov.in | Write to CP, Delhi at: P.O. Box No. 171, GPO, New Delhi

@DelhiPoliceOfficial @DelhiPolice @delhi.police_official @DelhiPoliceofficial delhipolice.gov.in

FOR IMMEDIATE POLICE HELP CALL 112 & PRESS 8 TO SHARE INFORMATION WITH POLICE CALL 14547

epaper.indianexpress.com



Inside Jayaprakash Narayan Public Library in New Delhi. DRISHTI JAIN

35,000 books, 1 cr e-books: Capital gets a tech-enabled public library

Drishhti Jain
New Delhi, July 11

FROM SHELVES spread over two floors lined with 35,000 books, quiet study corners and digital access to nearly one crore e-books — the Jayaprakash Narayan Public Library, inaugurated on Saturday on Udyan Marg in Delhi under NDMC — brings together the charm of traditional libraries and the convenience of modern technology under one roof.

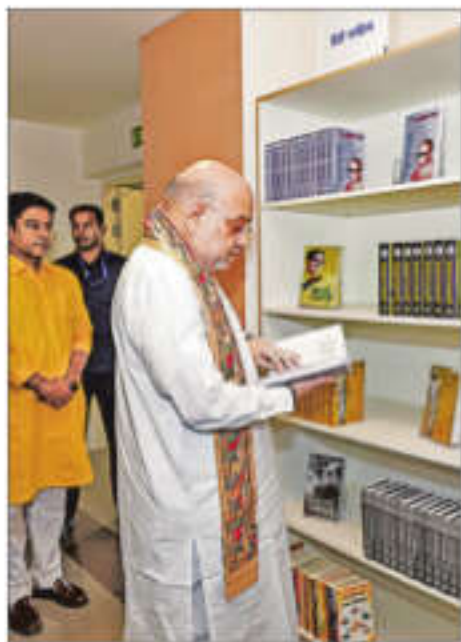
The library, inaugurated by Union Home Minister Amit Shah, is home to books on science, mathematics, Indian history, Hindi literature, geography, agriculture and competitive examinations.

With blue-coloured cushioned chairs and glass screens that act as a divide between two readers, one can seat on either of the floors and read. It also features a children's zone, research rooms, a contemporary reading area and an e-library equipped with computer terminals.

Inaugurating the library, Shah said, "While one should always think before speaking, one must first read in order to know what to think — and such understanding can only be gained through a library."

Referring to a similar initiative undertaken in his Lok Sabha constituency of Gandhinagar, he said that nearly every village there has a library with 3,000-4,000 books connected to a central library housing more than 1.25 lakh books.

Maintaining that reading enables people to develop informed opinions, he urged the Delhi government to prepare a



Union Home Minister Amit Shah browses books in the library. ANI

plan to interconnect libraries and link them with schools.

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, who was present at the inauguration, said the library would serve as a valuable resource for the youth and students. "Aspirants preparing for the UPSC and other competitive examinations will benefit from its conducive academic environment and state-of-the-art study facilities... this would inspire and empower Delhi's youth," she added.

NDMC Director of Welfare department, Anjum Siddiqui, said the library requires minimal manual intervention. "This is a public library and anyone can come here. Visitors can register for membership and issue books using facial recognition. RFID-tagged books can be self-issued by tapping them at a kiosk," she said.

Membership costs Rs 500 annually. A lifetime security deposit of Rs 1,000 is charged for NDMC residents and Rs 2,000 for non-residents.

MAN ARRESTED, JUVENILE DETAINED FOR CRIME IN GHAZIABAD

7-yr-old gangraped, killed; falls through shaft from 3rd floor to basement of upcoming mall

She was playing outside; family started looking for her when she didn't return home

Drishhti Jain
Ghaziabad, July 11

A SEVEN-YEAR-OLD girl was allegedly gangraped by two persons and hit with an iron rod on the head in Ghaziabad late Friday, before she fell through the shaft from the third floor of an under-construction mall into the basement. Her body was recovered from the basement around 1 am on Saturday.

Later in the day, a man was arrested and a juvenile detained in connection to the incident, said ACP (Officiating), Nandgram, Priyashi Pal.

DCP (City and Trans Hindon) Dhawal Jaiswal said the two were identified through CCTV camera footage, which captured them leading the girl away to the under-construction building.

"She was raped on the third floor of the building, after which the accused hit her on the head with an iron rod. She then fell through the shaft into



the basement, as there was nothing to hold onto," he added.

Pal said that based on a complaint filed by the victim's family, the accused were booked under sections of rape, kidnapping and murder of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita as well as under sections of the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act.

Police said the girl was assaulted inside a small, dark and

damp corner close to a shaft on the third floor.

When *The Indian Express* visited the spot, the crime scene — marked with white chalk by the police — had bloodstains amid construction debris and discarded plastic bottles.

"Around 1 am, Nandgram police received information about the recovery of the body. It was taken into custody and a post-mortem examination conducted. A Forensic Science

Laboratory team also collected evidence from the crime scene," Pal said.

She added the victim's family members, originally from Bihar, work as labourers at the under-construction building and reside in nearby jhuggis.

Both accused resided in the same jhuggi cluster, said another officer.

Speaking to *The Indian Express*, the girl's father said he began searching for her around



The last rites of the girl being conducted on Saturday; (above) at the scene of the crime. GAJENDRA YADAV

7 pm on Friday when she failed to return home and was not found playing outside.

"She was playing outside with her brothers, and I had gone out. But when it grew dark and she did not return, I went to other jhuggis to ask if she had gone there to play with other children."

He added that after a four-hour search, in which his neighbours also participated, around midnight, other labourers arrived to punch in for the night shift at the mall. Noticing his distress, they also joined the search effort.

"Around 40 of us started searching, when a painter who was passing by told us that he

saw a girl along with two persons going towards the building. We then spoke to the mall's security guard. He told us that he had heard a girl screaming 'mummy,' but when he called after the voice, nobody answered. So, he came back to his post," a neighbour said.

He added that in the meantime, police were informed, which later found the girl in the basement of the under-construction building.

At the cremation ground, the girl's mother was heard repeatedly saying — "She was my only girl, and now she is gone."

"Please take me with you as well," she said while calling for her dead daughter.

EXPRESS special

Inside a cybercrime trail: 96 'mule accounts' in one Delhi bank branch, hunt on for facilitator

Alok Singh
New Delhi, July 11

THE FIRST clue that something was unusual was not a cyber fraud complaint, but a private bank branch in North-east Delhi.

During Delhi Police's Cyber Hawk operation in April, investigators identified 96 suspected mule accounts linked to the private bank branch — one of the biggest concentrations of suspected money-laundering accounts uncovered during the crackdown on organised cybercrime.

Every cyber fraud needs somewhere for the money to go. Before it reaches overseas operators or cryptocurrency wallets, it usually passes through several "mule accounts" belonging to ordinary people who have either rented out their accounts for a commission or surrendered control of them without understanding how they would be used.

This Northeast Delhi branch became one such concentration point. And one of those 96 accounts belonged to a 30-year-old unemployed local resident.

In March, while visiting his uncle undergoing treatment at GTB Hospital, the man was approached by a man in his 40s

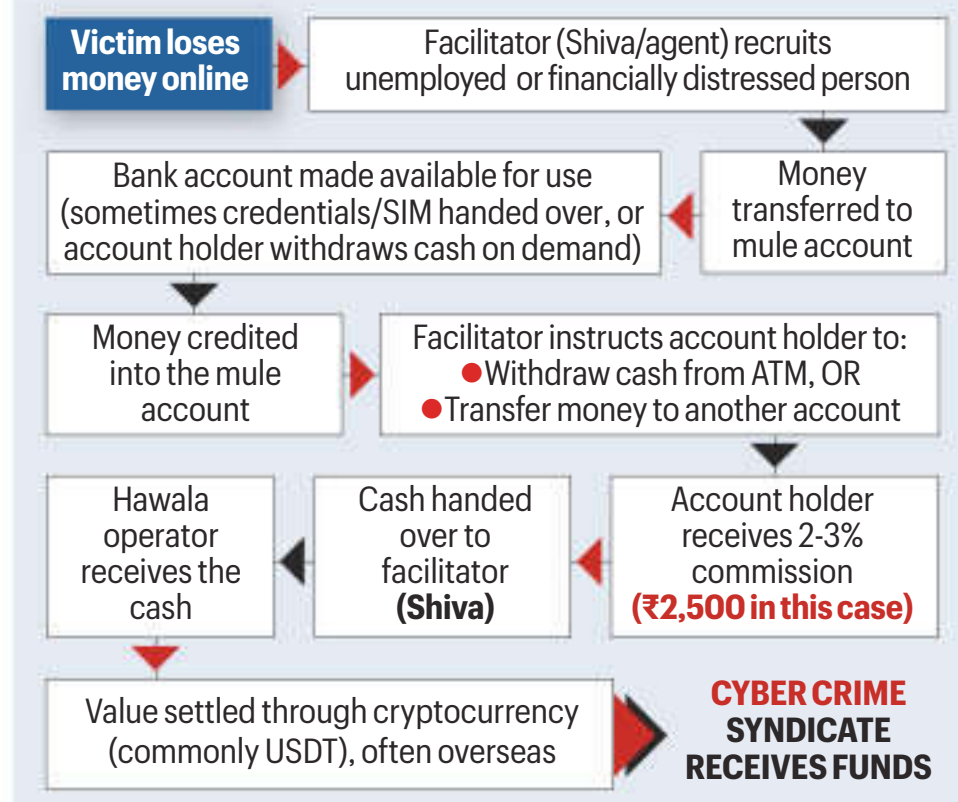
who introduced himself as 'Shiva'. Claiming that his mother was ill and that he urgently needed cash but could not withdraw money from his own account, the man requested help.

Trusting him, the 30-year-old allowed around Rs 30,000 to be transferred into his account. He withdrew Rs 25,000 from a nearby ATM and added another Rs 5,000 from his own pocket. Two days later, Shiva contacted him again, saying another Rs 24,000 had been transferred to his account "by mistake". The man initially refused to return it if such transfers continued, but later met Shiva again at GTB Hospital and handed over the money.

Weeks later, his account was frozen and the man was detained after police said he was linked to two cyber fraud complaints from outside Delhi involving Rs 30,000 and Rs 24,000. Police said the man later admitted he had accepted Rs 2,500 as commission for allowing the transactions, although he maintained he did not know the money was linked to cyber fraud. He was bound down and released.

The man, who lives with his wife and two-and-a-half-year-old son, has studied till Class 10. He earlier sold mobile phone

● CYBER FRAUD MONEY FLOW



chargers before losing his livelihood during the Covid-19 pandemic and now survives on occasional daily-wage work.

Investigators said his experience matches a pattern.

Police said cyber financial fraud typically operates in two parts — one that cheats victims and another that manages and launders the stolen money.

Facilitators — several of them are unemployed — often recruited through Telegram, Signal and Instagram, arrange bank accounts for cybercriminals and move the proceeds through hawala channels before they are ultimately through cryptocurrency transactions, particularly using USDT.

To set up mule accounts, facilitators identify unemployed youth, daily-wage labourers and financially distressed people and persuade them to let their bank accounts be used. Some knowingly rent out their accounts for a commission of 2-3% of the money routed through them. They hand over their SIM cards, banking credentials and account access, allowing the accounts to be operated remotely.

In this case, police said the facilitator Shiva allegedly paid the 30-year-old Rs 2,500 for allowing Rs 54,000 of suspected fraud proceeds to pass

through his account.

DCP (Northeast) Rahool Alwal constituted a special team led by inspectors Rahul Kumar and Satyawan Lathwal, leading investigators to identify

96 suspected mule accounts linked to the bank branch.

The probe found that digital credentials used to access the 30-year-old's account originated from Tamil Nadu. Teams sent there found linked bank accounts that had allegedly been opened using fake Aadhaar cards.

Investigators also found several accounts opened using forged documents. A case was registered under BNS.

The concentration of suspected mule accounts in a single branch prompted investigators to examine whether insiders knowingly facilitated account openings, whether the online onboarding process had weakened customer verification, or whether fake Know Your Customer documents had bypassed checks. However, no evidence has yet emerged establishing the involvement of any bank official, police said.

Police have so far been unable to trace Shiva. "The mobile number used was obtained using fake documents. The name could also be fake," an officer said.

● AT 'COMEDY IN CHAOS', PATIENTS RECOUNT 'TRYST WITH CANCER'

A light-hearted take on cancer: 11 'warriors' share experiences and a laugh

Reva Thakkar
New Delhi, July 11

"WHAT'S MORE dangerous than cancer?" Ruchi Chadha asked the audience that had gathered to watch 'Comedy in Chaos' on Saturday. As she received confused glances in response, she quipped, "People... kuch toh log toh kahenge, logo ka kaam hai kehna..." (People... they will say something or the other... it's just their job to talk aimlessly.)"

Chadha, who was the presenter at the show, shared with the crowd how she had lost her mother to breast cancer and the suffering that came along.

Among the 11 "cancer warriors" — residents of Delhi aged between 32 and 62 — who performed at the show at the India

International Centre was Rohini Khuller (62), who conceptualised the event. Their experiences, emotions, moments of weakness, and stories of people who gave them the strength that they needed in the fight against cancer were weaved into jokes, anecdotes and conversations shared during the event — all while making the audience laugh.

"I want to normalise conversations around cancer," Khuller told *The Indian Express* after the show, which, she said, had been in the making for nearly five years. Diagnosed with breast cancer in

2020, Khuller has been serving as the director of a consultancy, Turning Point Learning Pvt Ltd, since 2011 after serving as a sales and marketing professional for



The 'cancer warriors' who performed at the show; (right) audience cheering for the performers. EXPRESS & REVA THAKKAR

nearly 15 years.

Dressed in a grey kurta, glasses perched upon her nose, she said emphatically, "I hate the word survivor". Introducing her fellow performers during the show, she said, "These are the folks who've had a tryst with cancer..."

"The show actively started taking root in April after I had

put up a message on our group that I wanted to organise a stand-up comedy event. Suddenly, I was flooded with messages with people saying 'count me in'," she recounted.

Saturday's event was divided in three segments, opening with a talk show where "warriors" Nandita Thakur (59), Jenu Pannu Kohli (45)

and Ujala Makhija (46) spoke of "people who tell you to be positive all the time". "Mai toh triple positive thi yaar (I was three times positive...)," said Kohli in jest, referring to her diagnosis of three types of breast cancer in 2003. In 2025, she was diagnosed with an advanced stage of brain cancer. She is currently undergoing treatment.

In a play, the second segment of the event, that she had written, "warrior" Manisha Kapur (56) played the lead, donning the role of Manu Punjabi — "a woman from Punjab who just got diagnosed with breast cancer".

The play was centered on a patient's emotions and experiences following diagnosis. "I

started writing with 20-21 medical terms, and then wove them into the story... Manu misunderstands them in her own way," said Kapur.

With hairfall being a common side effect of chemotherapy, the third segment was called, "Bal bal bach gaye, but bal nahi bache." (It was a close shave... yet lost hair).

The "warriors" shared their first-hand experiences of undergoing chemotherapy. Thakur recalled shaving her head, "They called me baldlocks," she said, referring to the name inspired from the protagonist of a fairytale.

During the segment moderated by Rajneesh Singh (62), the only man in the group of 11 and a colon cancer patient, Khuller, Shruti Dhruva (56) and the youngest in the group — Astha Funda (32) — spoke of how their uncles and aunts, who "graduated from the Whatsapp

university", started advising them that if they drank *haldi doodh* (turmeric milk) all would be okay.

"When the idea came up of a light-hearted take on cancer, I thought it could be a great way of normalising conversations about cancer. But at the same time, I was worried whether it could be done in a sensitive manner. It's great to see this group narrate a humorous yet empathetic take on their experiences," said Dr Aditi Chaturvedi, Breast Oncoplastic Surgeon at Apollo Hospital, Delhi.

The evening ended with a band, Dirty Class, performing a song written by Kapur — "Sab Kuch Changa Hai Ji (all is well) — and all the "cancer warriors" dancing, singing and rejoicing.

More than 100 people in the audience — including friends, family and doctors of the "warriors" — cheered along.



विकसित भारत - समृद्ध बिहार

श्री सम्राट चौधरी

माननीय मुख्यमंत्री, बिहार



के कर-कमलों द्वारा

मुख्यमंत्री समग्र शहरी विकास योजना | स्टॉर्म वाटर ड्रेनेज | मुजफ्फरपुर स्मार्ट सिटी योजना

अन्तर्गत

₹1047.09 करोड़ की कुल 982 योजनाओं का शिलान्यास एवं उद्घाटन

विशिष्ट अतिथि

श्री विजय कुमार चौधरी

माननीय उपमुख्यमंत्री, बिहार

श्री बिजेन्द्र प्रसाद यादव

माननीय उपमुख्यमंत्री, बिहार

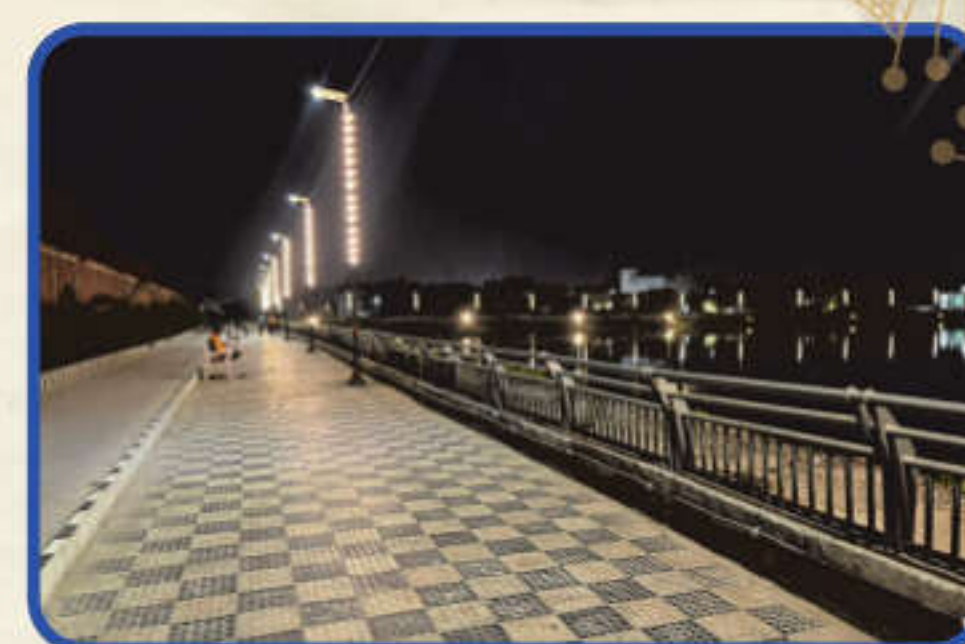
गरिमामयी उपस्थिति

जिले के माननीय सांसद, माननीय सदस्य, बिहार विधान मंडल एवं अन्य सम्मानित जनप्रतिनिधिगण

अध्यक्षता

श्री नीतीश मिश्रा

माननीय मंत्री, नगर विकास एवं आवास विभाग



दिनांक- 12 जुलाई 2026



समय- 10:30 बजे पूर्वाह्न



स्थान- मुजफ्फरपुर

नगर विकास एवं आवास विभाग

NC TO HOLD STATEHOOD PROTEST AT JANTAR MANTAR ON JULY 20

Why hold polls if J&K run from Raj Bhawan: Omar slams Centre

Alleges NC MLA offered Rs 20-30 cr, ministry to switch

Naveed Iqbal & Arun Sharma
Srinagar, Jammu, July 11

J&K CM Omar Abdullah alleged on Saturday that attempts were made to engineer defections within the NC, accusing the Opposition BJP of trying to bribe one of his MLAs to defect. Addressing party workers in Srinagar, Omar said the BJP should not consider the NC weak: “They are designated to the back seats and that’s where they will remain.” The remarks come ahead of the NC’s statehood protests at Jantar Mantar on July 20 —the first day of the Parliament’s Monsoon Session — with Omar adopting an increasingly confrontational tone



J&K Chief Minister Omar Abdullah and NC president Farooq Abdullah in Srinagar on Saturday. ANI

towards the Centre.

Referring to a conversation with one of the party MLAs from Jammu, he said, “An MLA from Jammu came and told me that a Supreme Court lawyer affiliated with the BJP offered him between Rs 20 to 30 crore, a ministry and statehood. No one sitting here will leave the party for Rs 20 crore or 100 crore.”

Omar also lashed out at the Centre over the delay in restor-

ing statehood to J&K while incentivising Ladakh despite widespread protests there.

The NC has invited several INDIA bloc leaders, including CPP chairperson Sonia Gandhi, Congress chief Mallikarjun Kharge, LoP Rahul Gandhi, DMK chief M K Stalin, SP chief Akhilesh Yadav, TMC leader Mamata Banerjee and Tamil Nadu CM C Joseph Vijay, among others. Omar said that since assuming

office, he “put my political future at risk, trying to resolve this issue through dialogue with the Centre. I wanted to give them the opportunity to keep their word.”

He added: “Our success in the last election is being used to punish the people of J&K.” Questioning why the Centre held elections while not allowing the elected government to function, he said, “What’s the point? Then you should not have held elections. If they wanted to run J&K through the Raj Bhawan, then they should not have conducted elections. Why bring us forth with our hands tied behind our backs? And that we will give you officers who will not execute your decisions.”

“We see ourselves and compare it to Ladakh. We are forced to ask ourselves the question that the way the Centre is engaging with Ladakh, why not with us,” he said. Omar also pointed out that while being told one country should have one way of

governance, for Ladakh “they are ready to extend protections under Article 371”.

He said the J&K government should at least have the freedom to appoint the officers it has to work with. “But Ladakh is being allowed concessions in this regard because they chose the path of protest.”

BJP termed Omar’s statements “unfortunate” and “misleading”. “On the one hand, Omar Abdullah says the Centre, PM Narendra Modi and Home Minister Amit Shah have released funds for development of J&K. On the other hand, he accuses BJP of trying to topple his government,” ex-J&K BJP chief Ravinder Raina said.

BJP national general secretary Tarun Chugh said it was “deeply unfortunate that certain political leaders continue to ignore the reality of Pakistan-sponsored terrorism and instead amplify narratives that suit Islamabad.”

Direct land purchase policy in Bengal: Don’t want another Singur, Nandigram, says CM

Atri Mitra
Kolkata, July 11

“WE DO not want another Nandigram or Singur,” West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari said on Saturday as he announced the government’s decision to rely on direct purchase of land, rather than acquisition, for industrial needs.

He also said that his government would introduce a single-window clearance mechanism for investment proposals of Rs 100 crore and above, asserting that land availability would no longer be a constraint for industries in the state.

Speaking at the foundation stone-laying ceremony of a Rs 600-crore facility of Lux Industry Ltd in Dankuni in Hooghly district, Adhikari said, “We do not want another Singur or Nandigram. If investors require land, the government will procure it under the Direct Land Purchase Policy and hand it over. Under this policy,



CM Suwendu Adhikari & Bengal BJP chief Samik Bhattacharya in Hooghly on Saturday. PTI

we have given land to the BSF, the Railways, bought land for the National Highway, and new airport. Similarly, for private industrialists, land will not be a problem. We will completely change the land procurement policy.”

In the government’s bid to stop corruption, create a business-friendly environment, and attract fresh investments, Adhikari said, “There will be a single-window clearance system for in-

vestment proposals worth Rs 100 crore and above. Such investments will not have to obtain approvals from panchayats, municipalities, municipal corporations or zilla parishads. Instead, clearances relating to land and environment, among others, will be processed through a single-window mechanism involving the WBIDC and the state departments concerned.”

Adhikari alleged that the state’s debt had increased from around Rs 2 lakh crore during the Left Front regime to nearly Rs 8 lakh crore under the previous TMC government, maintaining that attracting investments was key to augmenting the state’s own revenue.

In a message to the industrialists, he said, “I can assure you you will reap the benefits of the double-engine government. In over 20 states, where NDA or BJP is in power, you are seeing a surge in development, investment, and jobs. We have come a long way in tackling law & order.”

Channi sharpens ‘oust Warring’ pitch at key meet as Punjab Cong crisis deepens

Man Aman Singh Chhina
Chandigarh, July 11

AMID A raging leadership tussle in the Punjab Congress, the AICC’s general secretary in charge of the state, Bhupesh Baghel, on Saturday held a meeting with party leaders, including several affiliated to Jalandhar MP and ex-CM Charanjit Singh Channi, in a bid to defuse the crisis, but the impasse continues.

The meeting turned into a show of strength by state Congress leaders seeking the ouster of Punjab PCC chief Amrinder Singh Raja Warring in the run-up to Punjab elections slated for February 2027. Warring was not present at the meeting.

The weeklong visit of Baghel to Chandigarh to resolve deepening differences between the Channi and Warring camps culminated in the 80-minute Saturday meeting at Kapurthala MLA Rana Gurjit Singh’s house, which was attended by over 80 party leaders, including many candidates who contested the 2022 Assembly polls.

According to several leaders who attended the meeting, Channi asked all of them to raise their hands if they wanted Raja Warring to be removed as the PPCC chief, claiming that they “complied with it”.

Addressing the gathering in Baghel’s presence, Channi alleged that Warring was doing his “character assassination” by spreading rumours that he was in touch with BJP, sources said. “I have cases against me by the BJP-led Centre as well as the AAP-led Punjab government, and I am not afraid of them,” he said, claiming he had never sought any post and that he had only demanded Warring’s replacement as the PPCC chief.

Gurdaspur MLA Barindermeet Singh Pahra said he



Cong leaders Charanjit Singh Channi and Bhupesh Baghel in Chandigarh on Saturday. ANI

would not contest polls if Warring continues in his position.

According to sources, Bal-kaur Singh Sidhu alleged that Warring was “promoting” his rivals in his Mansa belt. He said he was not interested in fighting elections but he did not want the Congress to lose there.

Later, Baghel told reporters, “Rana Gurjit invited us... I met with all party colleagues. They shared their views, and no one has any objection to the party high command’s decision.”

“No one should feel disadvantaged just because they lack the backing of a major leader. If a candidate is capable of winning, they will get the ticket... The colleagues raised certain issues, which I will convey to the high command... No one is upset,” Baghel claimed.

When asked about the pitch for replacing Warring, he said, “There were no such talks.”

However, Randhawa and Channi appeared before reporters, where Randhawa called for a leadership change in the state party unit. “Our demand to the leadership is clear. We want a Congress government in Punjab. To achieve this, we need unity within the party... We don’t need compromised leaders,” said Randhawa.

EXPRESS special

In Ayodhya, BJP leaders distance themselves from row but bank on ‘Yogiji’: ‘Theek kar denge’

Maulshree Seth
Ayodhya, July 11

BUNDLES OF a special edition of Sandesh, a quarterly magazine published by the Information Department of the Uttar Pradesh government on the Ram Temple flag-hoisting ceremony, lie stacked at the BJP’s new office in Ayodhya’s Saadatganj area awaiting distribution.

But unlike these magazines — an older October-December 2025 edition celebrating one of the recent milestones in the construction of the Ram Temple — BJP leaders in Ayodhya have distanced themselves from the on-going controversy surrounding alleged irregularities in temple donations, calling it a matter between the “Ram Temple and the Trust” and maintaining that neither institution has any BJP face associated with it.

However, when confronted with questions on the issue, party workers and leaders offer a common response: “Yogi ji ne kaha hai, aap dekhiyega, action hoga aur sara system durust ho jayega (Yogiji has said that action will be taken and the entire system will be streamlined).”

“Our core voter knows that those who stayed away from visiting the temple, fearing the impact on their vote bank, are simply doing politics over the issue,” said Manoj Verma, former general secretary of the BJP’s Ayodhya district unit and the lone office-bearer present at the BJP’s Mahanagar office.

Claiming that the issue would have little electoral impact because action would be taken and that public anger was directed against those guilty of theft, Verma said, “*Har koi chahta hai ki karyawahi ho aur dhang ki karyawahi ho, taki koi is tarah ki harkat na kar*



Trustee Dinendra Das Maharaj with devotees at Ram temple in Ayodhya on Saturday. ANI

sake... Par main nahi manta ki election mein mandir koi mudda ban payega... Chaan been hogi, Yogi ji chhorne wale nahi hai (Everyone wants action and proper action so that nobody can indulge in such acts again. But I do not believe the temple issue will become an election issue. There will be an investigation and Yogi ji will not spare the culprits).”

A few kilometres away, at the BJP’s old office in Civil Lines, party functionaries from gram pradhans to current and former office-bearers were present. They said they had been instructed not to speak officially or post on social media about the matter. Yet, the issue clearly weighed on their minds and many said they were waiting for “action” before responding to the Opposition.

“This is not our issue. The Ram Temple authorities and the Trust should explain what went wrong and where. Is there any BJP face there?” asked a veteran party functionary.

He added that he had been associated with the Ram Temple movement since the early 1990s, when activists car-

I do not believe the temple issue will become an election issue. There will be an investigation and Yogi ji will not spare the culprits.”

MANOJ VERMA, FORMER GENERAL SECRETARY, BJP’S AYODHYA DISTRICT UNIT

ried bricks to villages, organised pujas and collected consecrated shilas from different blocks as part of the movement while working with the ABVP. He claimed to have been present when the disputed structure was demolished.

While many BJP workers continue to identify strongly with the Ram Temple movement, several senior leaders do not associate themselves as closely with the current institutional structure. One such worker remarked, “*Bahut kuch badal gaya hai*” (A lot has changed). Younger functionaries, however, recalled going

door-to-door to collect donations for the temple’s construction.

“In villages, if you tell even an addict that you are carrying money meant for the temple, he will not dare snatch it from you. But in this case, they took Ram ka paisa (Lord Ram’s money),” said a young mandal-level functionary.

“We are not saying anything yet. Let the action take place and then we will respond appropriately,” he added.

“First, we got the blot of losing Ayodhya and now this. But trust me, mistakes will not be repeated in 2027.”

He said party workers were avoiding defending anyone over the issue in public discussions or at tea stalls because they feared it could backfire at present and were instead limiting themselves to saying, “Yogi ji, Modi ji *theek kar denge*” (Yogi ji and Modi ji will fix it).

“People remain connected to the belief that Yogi ji and Modi ji will set things right,” said Rajesh Singh, a local BJP leader.

Supporting him, Vipin Singh, general secretary of the BJP’s Ayodhya unit, said, “People are saddened, but there has been no decline in faith. Everyone remains confident.”

While BJP’s public representatives in the district avoided commenting on the issue, district president Radhye Shyam Tyagi, who said he was attending a local event in Gosaiganj area, said: “It is true that an incident has taken place, but prompt action was initiated and an SIT was formed as soon as the information came to light. Once the SIT report is submitted, all those found guilty will be punished.” “*Koi bhi bakhsha nahi jayega* (No one will be spared),” he added.

‘A disgrace, we all feel diminished, small’: Nripendra Misra on temple donation ‘theft’

Express News Service
Lucknow, July 11

RAM JANMBHOOMI Temple Construction Committee chairman Nripendra Misra said on Saturday that the alleged theft and misappropriation of donations at Ram temple in Ayodhya was a “disgrace” and “we all feel diminished and very small” because of it.

Misra, who was in Ayodhya on the second day of the construction committee meeting, said he was hopeful of things returning to normal and of an improvement in the temple management.

He told reporters, “As you know, our treasurer Swami Govind Dev Giri ji also spoke and explained that this is a stigma. The fact that this incident occurred in the Ram Temple is something we all regret. Not only do we regret it, but in a way, we all feel diminished because of it.”

He added, “This is a question of management. I am sure there will be improvement in the system. I have full faith. Such incidents will not be repeated.”

Whether the Trust has formed a committee to select a CEO for temple management as suggested or recommended by him, Misra said, “It was not my recommendation. A judge (retired) is heading the committee to select the CEO.”

Misra had earlier said a detailed probe was required to nail the culprits and suggested that a retired bureaucrat should be appointed as a CEO to manage the activities at the temple.

He arrived in Ayodhya on Friday to chair the meeting of the construction committee which is held every month to review the ongoing work. The agencies associated with the construction of structures in and around the temple include L&T, Rajkiya Nirman Nigam



Ram Janmbhoomi Temple Construction Committee chairman Nripendra Misra in Ayodhya on Saturday. ANI

(UP government-run construction department), Tata Consultancy Services and Engineer India Ltd.

Mainly two main construction works are still to be completed, he said, adding, “One, the old temple (makeshift Ram Lalla temple), a memorial, has to be completed. There, the arrangement for the flame that would remain lit round the clock is still pending.”

Also, there is another memorial, which will be completed by the end of July, he further informed.

The temple construction work will be completed by July 30, he claimed.

The two works that will continue include the boundary wall, which is four km long. That work will continue. And the other one is work on the auditorium outside the temple complex will continue until around November–December.

“Besides these, there is the Ram Katha Museum which has 20 galleries. The storyline of all the galleries has been prepared and a final decision will be taken regarding what kind of technology-based videos will be used. We will work on that in today’s and tomorrow’s meeting,” he said.

UN Special Rapporteurs flag ‘discrimination’ in SIR exercise, seek govt’s response

Damini Nath
New Delhi, July 11

THREE UNITED Nations-appointed experts have written to the Centre expressing concerns over alleged discrimination towards minorities during the Election Commission’s Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, particularly in West Bengal, and seeking information on the steps taken to ensure the process aligns with India’s obligations under international human rights law.

The UN’s Special Rapporteurs on minority issues, on promotion and protection of the right to freedom of opinion and expression, and on freedom of religion or belief — Nicolas Levrat, Irene Khan and Nazila Ghanea respectively —

wrote to the government on May 1. They sought the government’s comments on allegations that Bengali and Muslim electors were targeted during the SIR and asked for details of steps taken to ensure that eligible voters were not prevented from participating in the 2026 Assembly polls.

The SIR exercise was upheld by the Supreme Court in May this year. Dismissing the petitions challenging the legality of SIR, the court ruled that the EC had the power to conduct the exercise.

“We are particularly concerned by the way in which the SIR process has been conducted, notably the reported removal of millions of voters’ names from electoral rolls, potentially affecting a great number of Muslims



In West Bengal, 27 lakh electors were unable to cast their votes in the April 2026 polls even as their appeals are pending with tribunals. FILE

and persons of Bengali descent, as well as other minorities, who may be wrongfully excluded from the updated electoral rolls because of their historical and

continuing treatment as foreigners and illegal immigrants, notably in West Bengal,” the letter states.

Emails sent to the spokes-

person for the MEA and the EC did not elicit a response.

The letter comes after a group of academics, the Independent Panel for Monitoring Indian Elections, submitted complaints regarding the SIR exercise to the Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights in August 2025 and April 2026. The panel comprises Prof Neera Chandhoke, a Distinguished Honorary Fellow at the Centre for Equity Studies, Dr Thomas Daffern, a historian and director of the International Institute of Peace Studies and Global Philosophy and Dr Harish Karnick, a former IIT-Kanpur professor.

The coordinator of the independent panel, retired IAS officer MG Devasahayam, said the

group recently received a copy of the letter, which was made public by the Special Rapporteurs after 60 days, as per their practice.

“Affected individuals of the second phase [of SIR] report being wrongfully excluded despite having provided valid identification. Muslim voters were reportedly disproportionately impacted by the SIR process... Minor spelling inconsistencies in documents — reportedly common across India due to administrative challenges — are allegedly used as a pretext for the deletion of voter names,” the letter states.

On the SIR in Bihar, the letter says it reportedly caused alarm over potential large-scale disenfranchisement and denationalisation, particularly of

Muslims and other minorities. “Further concerns have been raised by the alleged use of an AI-driven system that flagged ‘irregularities’ in voter data, raising concerns about transparency, errors, and potential bias,” the letter states.

It also flags concerns over statements made by political and government officials in the context of the SIR.

“In the context of the SIR process, statements were reportedly made by politicians and senior public figures of the Government, which appear to reflect and reinforce a pattern of discriminatory rhetoric directed at Muslim, Bengali, and other minority communities. Senior Government officials, including the Union Home Minister, have reportedly pub-

licly framed the deletion of voter names as targeting “illegal Bangladeshi immigrants” — rhetoric that conflates legitimate Indian Muslim citizens with foreign nationals.”

“It is also reported that, before Parliament, the Home Minister framed the State-administered electoral process in terms of the removal of a religious community, expressed through the policy formula ‘Detect, Delete and Deport,’” the letter states.

The EC started the SIR in Bihar in June last year and then followed it up in 10 states and three UTs, including West Bengal, from October 2025. In West Bengal, 27 lakh electors were unable to cast their votes in the April 2026 polls even as their appeals are pending with tribunals.

From Housing to Healthcare

A Decade of Welfare Progress in Uttar Pradesh

Over the Past nine years, Uttar Pradesh has become one of the top states in India for implementing major Central Government welfare schemes. Under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, the state has worked to ensure that government benefits reach poor and needy families through digital systems, Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT), and strong outreach at the village level. Significant progress has been made in providing houses, healthcare, food security, sanitation facilities, and clean drinking water, making Uttar Pradesh one of the states with the highest number of beneficiaries in the country.



Ayushman Bharat PM-JAY

- More than 5.76 crore Ayushman Cards issued in Uttar Pradesh.
- Reduced out-of-pocket healthcare expenditure for poor families.



Pradhan Mantri Garib Kalyan Anna Yojana (PMGKAY)

- Around 15 crore beneficiaries received free ration in Uttar Pradesh.
- Ensured food security for vulnerable families during and after the pandemic.



Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana (PMAY)

- 62 lakh houses provided to the families in Uttar Pradesh (Urban + Rural).
- One of the highest PMAY beneficiary states in India.
- Majority of these newly constructed houses have been registered in the names of women.



Jal Jeevan Mission

- Around 2.5 crore rural families provided tap-water connections in Uttar Pradesh.



PM Vishwakarma Yojana

- Provides skill training, toolkit incentives and concessional credit.
- Supports traditional artisans and craftsmen.



Saubhagya Yojana

- Nearly 2.86 crore households have been electrified in Uttar Pradesh.



PM SVANidhi

- Provides collateral-free working capital loans and supports livelihood recovery and financial inclusion.
- Nearly 15 lakh street vendors benefited.



Pradhan Mantri Kaushal Vikas Yojana (PMKVY)

- 14+ lakh youth trained under the initiative.
- More than 6 lakh trained individuals to successfully transition into the workforce.



PM Kisan Samman Nidhi

- 3.12 crore farmers in Uttar Pradesh received the latest instalment.
- Rs. 1,03,391.24 crore transferred directly to farmers in the state.



Ujjwala Yojana

- More than 1.86 crore LPG connections in Uttar Pradesh.
- Two Free Gas Cylinder on Diwali and Holi



Pradhan Mantri Matru Vandana Yojana

- Around 60 lakh mother beneficiaries in Uttar Pradesh.
- Financial assistance provided during pregnancy and childbirth.



Pradhan Mantri Fasal Bima Yojana

- From the financial year 2017-18 to 2025-26, a total of 353.14 lakh insured farmers have benefitted under the scheme.
- A total compensation amount of ₹5,660.33 crore has been successfully paid out to these insured farmers.



PM Surya Ghar Muft Bijli Yojana

- 6.2 lakh rooftop solar installations, generating nearly 2000 MW electricity, making it one of India's leading states in residential rooftop solar adoption.



Pradhan Mantri Krishi Sinchayi Yojana

- A total of 13,14,282 shallow tube wells, 12,954 deep bore wells, and 33,600 medium bore wells have been successfully constructed under PM Krishi and CM Krishi Sinchayi Yojana.



Swachh Bharat Mission

- Entire rural population covered through ODF and ODF Plus initiatives.
- All villages declared ODF Plus.



Startup India

- More than 21,000 startups are actively operated in UP.
- Uttar Pradesh ranks among India's leading startup ecosystems.



PM Mudra Yojana

- Loans worth over Rs. 3.14 lakh Cr. have been disbursed under the scheme since its inception.

KAAM DAMDAAR - DOUBLE ENGINE SARKAR

Shekhar Suman aide under ED scanner was caught with 7.4-kg gold at Heathrow

Deeptiman Tiwary
New Delhi, July 11

THE PROMOTER of Mumbai-based jewellery exporter Kalanee Impex Pvt Ltd, Dharmesh Sangani, whose premises were searched by the Enforcement Directorate (ED) on Thursday, was earlier intercepted by the UK Border Force at Heathrow Airport with 7.412 kg of undeclared gold jewellery concealed on his person and in his wife's handbag, according to a statutory order of a London tribunal that upheld the seizure.

The fresh ED action has uncovered alleged undisclosed foreign companies, overseas bank accounts and suspected violations of the Foreign Exchange

Management Act (FEMA). Sangani is also a film producer associated with actor and TV host Shekhar Suman. He is the co-founder of Shekhar Suman Film Academy. Suman currently hosts a talk show that is widely seen as critical of the Narendra Modi government.

During Thursday's searches, the ED said it found evidence of an undisclosed Canadian company KGN Ventures Canada Inc., a Dubai-based firm Hiramandi Events & Mgmt LLC, and a suspected US entity GBM Ventures LLC, besides recovering foreign credit and debit cards and other documents relating to overseas assets. It also alleged that Sangani attempted to destroy digital evidence by throwing his mobile

phone from the 13th floor during the searches. The phone was later retrieved and seized.

The ED also disclosed that customs authorities in both the US and the UK are investigating certain transactions involving Sangani. It said documents recovered during the searches related to the seizure by the US Customs and Border Protection of a jewellery consignment worth about \$3.05 million in June 2025 on allegations involving smuggled merchandise and suspected counterfeit trademark goods. The agency said it is examining whether that consignment is linked to exports from Kalanee Impex.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Future wars will still be won by soldiers, not just AI: Rajnath

Press Trust of India
Visakhapatnam, July 11

FUTURE WARS may be fought with Artificial Intelligence, but they will still be won by national resolve, trained soldiers and robust military power, Defence Minister Rajanath Singh said on Saturday.

Speaking at the commissioning ceremony of INS Mahendragiri, Singh also said Andhra Pradesh has emerged as a new powerhouse of India's defence and aerospace manufacturing.

Highlighting the government's balanced approach towards defence modernisation, Singh said India is investing in next-generation tech while simultaneously strengthening conventional military capabilities.

He cited Operation Sindoor as an example of the effective integration of conventional and modern capabilities to



INS Mahendragiri during its commissioning ceremony in Visakhapatnam on Saturday. PTI

safeguard national security.

"Future wars may be fought with Artificial Intelligence, but they will still be won by national resolve, trained soldiers and the capable military power. So, I would say that new technologies and conventional platforms are not opposed to each other, but supplement each other, complete each other. Without conventional platforms, new technologies are incomplete in themselves," he

said.

According to Singh, it is certain that new technologies have reshaped warfare, but they have not diminished the role of conventional warfare means.

The strong conventional capability still necessary for the fulfilment of basic principles of war is as important as it was before. Referring to the Indian Navy's role during the recent West Asia conflict, Singh said under Operation Urja Suraksha, the Navy safely escorted 18 merchant vessels carrying essential cargo valued at more than Rs 9,000 crore.

Describing INS Mahendragiri as a "blue-water warship", Singh said it can effectively counter threats from the air, enemy vessels on the surface and submarines hidden beneath the sea, and can protect India's maritime interests not only near the coastline but also in distant and deep oceans during prolonged deployments.

Food regulator pulls up Instamart over spoilt, contaminated food

Anonna Dutt
New Delhi, July 11

AFTER COMPLAINTS by consumers against quick commerce app Swiggy Instamart, the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) has served nine notices to the company. The complaints were regarding the supply of expired, spoilt, rotten or contaminated food products.

No action was taken by the company even on escalation of complaints by the consumers.

The company was also found to list products on its platform that carried names other than what was mentioned on FSSAI licence of the food operator.

The food regulator said: "Complainants alleged delivery of contaminated eggs and milk, along with damaged packaged food items through Instamart. Some complainants alleged that no satisfactory response, grievance redressal or corrective action was taken despite the complaints being escalated, while one complainant stated that only a refund was offered without addressing the reported food safety concerns."

According to details provided by the FSSAI, consumers complained that 'Healthify 100% Whey Protein 1kg' and 'Noice Homestyle Madras Mixture with Peanuts' were supplied after their expiry date. 'Akshayakalpa Organic Eggs' were not only expired, but consumers said they found it to be emitting foul odour. In this case, when the consumers escalated their complaint, no corrective action was taken by Swiggy Instamart.

Another product, 'Kakke da Paratha', was found spoilt and emitting foul odour but the company did not take any action on the complaint. Consumers complained that the infant food formula they received was in an unsafe condition, showing signs of improper storage and handling. The consumers said the platform allegedly re-supplied defective product after they returned it.

FSSAI also found that the platform marketed 'Noice Eggs' under a brand name not covered by the existing licence. It has asked the company not to market products unless it was covered by a valid licence.

Employees' Provident Fund Organisation (Ministry of Labour & Employment, Govt. of INDIA) Regional Office, Gurugram (East): Plot No.43 , Sector -44, Gurugram - 122003 (Haryana)						
PUBLIC NOTICE						
Whereas, NOTICE IS HEREBY GIVEN TO PUBLIC AT LARGE that the following establishments covered under the Employees' Provident Fund & Miscellaneous Provisions Act, 1952 has failed to remit the contribution payable under the Act in respect of employees engaged by the establishment for the period mentioned therein and inquiry under the provisions of Section 14B(Damages) & 7Q (Interest) of the EPF & MP Act, 1952 is in progress for determination of dues.						
Sl. No	Establishment No Code	Name of Establishment	Period of enquiry From to	E-Proceedings Case No.	Initiated u/s	Next date of hearing
1	GNGGN0031459000	M/s. Asiaya Engineering Project P Ltd	14.05.2017 13.06.2024	312/2024	14B & 7Q	21.07.2026
2	GNGGN0030661000	M/s. Alchemist Hospitals Ltd.	01.12.2009 07.06.2024	218/2024	14B & 7Q	21.07.2026
3	GNGGN1618220000	M/s. AMB Infaventures Private Limited	01.04.2017 13.05.2024	288/2024	14B & 7Q	21.07.2026
4	GNGGN1014219000	M/s. Avalon Infrastructures Private Limited	28.10.2017 16.01.2024	142/2024	14B & 7Q	21.07.2026
5	GNGGN0032321000	M/s. Camier Media India Private Ltd.	13.08.2023 13.06.2024	364/2024	14B & 7Q	21.07.2026
6	GNGGN2195807000	M/s. Cashbee Technology India Private Limited	24.08.2020 13.06.2024	407/2024	14B & 7Q	21.07.2026
7	GNGGN1483752000	M/s. Kinsh Realtech Private Limited	01.09.2014 22.12.2023	25/2024	14B & 7Q	21.07.2026
8	GNGGN0031283000	M/s. M Sahai Technocrfts Pvt Ltd	15.10.2014 13.06.2024	331/2024	14B & 7Q	21.07.2026
9	GNGGN2074719000	M/s. Moofarm Private Limited	01.10.2019 13.06.2024	423/2024	14B & 7Q	21.07.2026
10	GNGGN0008757000	M/s. Multinational Services	01.04.1996 02.11.2023	256/2023	14B & 7Q	21.07.2026
11	GNGGN0028406000	M/s. OASIS Electro Mech Pvt Ltd	29.03.2019 13.06.2024	18/2025	14B & 7Q	21.07.2026
12	GNGGN1283074000	M/s. OASIS Associates	01.01.2015 13.06.2024	345/2024	14B & 7Q	21.07.2026
13	GNGGN0029915000	M/s. OM Sharil Travels	23.02.2019 13.06.2024	305/2024	14B & 7Q	21.07.2026
14	GNGGN0026861000	M/s. Predominant Engg.- Contractors (p) Ltd.	15.02.2025 04.01.2024	31/2024	14B & 7Q	21.07.2026
15	GNGGN0031299000	M/s. Qurbu Auto Pvt Ltd.	06.04.2011 08.05.2024	171/2024	14B & 7Q	21.07.2026
16	GNGGN0031182000	M/s. Sheel Real Estate & Facility Mgmt. Co.	27.06.2016 04.12.2023	262/2023	14B & 7Q	21.07.2026
17	GNGGN1606899000	M/s. Sterna India Oil & Gas Private Limited	01.05.2017 04.01.2024	149/2024	14B & 7Q	21.07.2026
18	GNGGN2400448000	M/s. The Earth Saviours Foundation	01.04.2021 16.10.2023	175/2023	14B & 7Q	21.07.2026
19	GNGGN1365602000	M/s. Vignamangement Services Pvt Ltd	10.09.2022 04.01.2024	28/2024	14B & 7Q	21.07.2026
20	GNGGN1425569000	M/s. Xangbo Trading India Private Limited	01.12.2015 13.05.2024	192/2024	14B & 7Q	21.07.2026

Nobody has been appearing in the inquiry since long even after ample opportunities have been given. It is informed to all that:

1. Any person who has information about the employer / establishment and has any information about the whereabouts of employer / establishment, he should provide the same either by appearing in the processing or by post or through email on ro.gurgaon@epfindia.gov.in. Any person can visit the office in relation to above in person or on any day before the next date of hearing and submit the written information to the Penal damage/ Compliance Account officer / Section Supervisor or the concerned Social Security assistant.

2. The employer / IAR of the establishment is given a final opportunity to attend the proceedings on next date of hearing to represent the case.

In case of non appearance of establishment / stake holders / employees or non-receipt of any information from any stakeholders, further proceedings will be carried out presuming that there is no complaint against the establishment and the establishment has nothing to submit to defend the case and the case / matter shall be decided ex-parte on the basis of available records / information / deposition.

Sd/-
(Sunil Kumar-I)
Regional PF Commissioner-II
Assessing Officer
Regional office, Gurugram (East)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr.PC)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Arjun S/o Pappu R/o 233/1, Gali No. 5, Tahirpur Village, GTB Enclave, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No.266/2020, u/s 380/411 IPC, P.S. GTB Enclave, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Arjun** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Arjun** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Arjun of FIR No.266/2020, u/s 380/411 IPC, P.S. GTB Enclave, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **18.08.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Sanghmitra
Judicial Magistrate First Class-01, Room No.54
Second Floor, Shahdara District
Karkardooma Courts, Delhi

DP/9477/SHD/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr. P.C./84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused **(1) Manohar S/o Gopal Ram, (2) Sachin @Vishnu S/o Manohar R/o 6487, 3rd Floor Gali Hanuman Mandir, Nabi Karim, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 237/2026 U/s 100(3)(5) Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, PS Nabi Karim, Delhi** and it has been returned to warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said accused **(1) Manohar, (2) Sachin @ Vishnu** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **(1) Manohar, (2) Sachin @Vishnu** has absconded (or is concealing themselves to avoid the service of said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that **(1) Manohar, (2) Sachin @Vishnu** in **FIR No. 237/2026 U/s 100(3)(5) Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, PS Nabi Karim, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **12.08.2026**.

By order
Ms. Nidhi Bala
Judicial Magistrate First Class-05
Central, Court Room 241
Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

DP/9488/CD/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Fadi Mosa, Proprietor of United Blue Stars, At Tis Hazari Court Complex, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 79/2013, U/s 420/406/467/468 IPC, P.S. Sadar Bazar, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Fadi Mosa** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Fadi Mosa** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Fadi Mosa** accused of **FIR No. 79/2013, U/s 420/406/467/468 IPC, P.S. Sadar Bazar, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **13.08.2026**.

By Order - Sh. Kartik Taparia
Judicial Magistrate First Class-06, Central
Room No. 247, Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

DP/9540/ON/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused person **Deepraj Kumar Gupta S/o Rajender Gupta R/o A-773 Gautampuri Phase-1 Badapur New Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 165/2023 U/s 25 Arms Act PS: Safdarjung Enclave, New Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Deepraj Kumar Gupta** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Deepraj Kumar Gupta** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Deepraj Kumar Gupta** accused of **FIR No. 165/2023 U/s 25 Arms Act PS: Safdarjung Enclave, New Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **19.08.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Devanshi Janmeja
JMFC-03, Room No. 212
Saket Court, Delhi

DP/9293/SW/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED

(See Section 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Amzad @ Kale S/o Jamil Khan R/o Jhuggi No 810 Basantdada Patel Nagar Bhalswa Dairy, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 28674/2020 U/s 379/411 IPC at PS: SHAHBAD DAIRY, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Amzad @ Kale** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Amzad @ Kale** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Amzad @ Kale** of **FIR No. 28674/2020 U/s 379/411 IPC at PS: Shahbad Dairy, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **19.08.2026**.

By order
Bharti Beniwal
Judicial Magistrate First Class-05
North, Room No.114, First Floor,
Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/9469/ON/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr. P.C./84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused **Saurav Bali R/o H. No. E-92, Sector-41, Noida, UP** also at J-7/15, 3rd Floor, Rajouri Garden, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 717/2015 U/s 420/406/120B/34 IPC, PS Jagatpuri, Delhi** and it has been returned to warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said accused **Saurav Bali** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Saurav Bali** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that **Saurav Bali** in **FIR No. 717/2015 U/s 420/406/120B/34 IPC, PS Jagatpuri, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **12.08.2026**.

By order
Ms. Anushtha Srivastava
Judicial Magistrate First Class -05
Room No. 7, Second Floor, Shahdara Distt.
Karkardooma Courts, Delhi

DP/9502/SHD/2026

Ambala car blast: NIA chargesheets eight including Pak terrorist Bhatti

Express News Service
Panchkula, July 11

THE NATIONAL Investigation Agency (NIA) on Saturday filed a chargesheet against eight accused, including Pakistan-based gangster-turned-terrorist Shehzad Bhatti, in connection with the IED blast in a car in parking rea of Baldev Nagar police station in Haryana's Ambala this January.

The other seven accused are Indian nationals. The chargesheet filed before the Special NIA Court in Panchkula identifies them as Karamjit Singh alias Tony, Akash, Soureb alias Sobi alias Sourab, Raman Kumar, Satyam, Sukhdev Singh, Amarjeet Singh.

In the chargesheet, the agency has "detailed the roles of the accused and the conspiracy orchestrated by Bhatti to attack Baldev Nagar police station with the aim to spread terror among the people by targeting police establishments."

The NIA said Bhatti, wanted in other terrorist cases too, had "established operational modules here.

In Kashmir, scrutiny of academic material moves from schools to colleges

Bashaarat Masood
Srinagar, July 11

AFTER ORDERING the screening of books in school libraries, the J&K government has asked for a "comprehensive academic and content audit" of academic material in colleges, universities and public libraries across the UT. The scope of the "audit" has also been broadened, with the circular covering not just books but also journals, research publications, academic theses and dissertations, and digital repositories of academic institutions.

"The circulars provide that no publication or academic material containing factually inaccurate, misleading, distorted, inflammatory, unlawful or otherwise objectionable content, including material that directly or indirectly promotes, glorifies, legitimises or justifies terrorism, violent ex-

treimism, secessionism, radicalisation or any activity prejudicial to the sovereignty, unity, integrity and security of the Nation, shall be procured, prescribed, recommended, retained, circulated, published, hosted or otherwise made available in educational institutions," said a government release issued Friday. The initiative, it said, is intended to reinforce "academic standards, strengthen institutional accountability, preserve the integrity of the educational ecosystem and establish a transparent, objective and uniform framework for the periodic academic and content review of educational resources across schools, colleges and universities in the Union Territory".

A principal of a government higher secondary school said while they have been informed about the order, there are no specific

guidelines for its implementation so far. He claimed he had been verbally told that any book or material "on the pattern" of the 25 books banned by the government last year constitutes objectionable material.

"By and large, we have been left to make these decisions on our own," he said. "Since the responsibility ultimately rests with the heads of the institutions, we may be compelled to remove all academic books on Kashmir just to be on the safe side."

A college principal said that while they have read about the circular, no official communication has reached them yet. "Research is about engaging with multiple viewpoints and arriving at informed conclusions. This order will deal a blow to genuine research and scholarship in J&K," said a professor of History.

Man accused of stalking minor kills her, five others including his wife, 2 sons

Nikhila Henry
Hyderabad, July 11

A 35-YEAR-OLD man accused of stalking a 16-year-old girl in Telangana's Ranga Reddy district allegedly murdered six people on Friday night, including the girl, her mother, and her grandmother, before killing his own wife and two sons. The man was granted anticipatory bail and released on personal bond last month.

The incident occurred in a town and the man's native village, both of which are just kilometres away from Hyderabad, on Friday night. A manhunt is underway to locate him, the police said.

According to Telangana Police, the man drove 6 km from his village to the town at around 10.45 pm. He went to the home of the girl whose family had filed a Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (Pocso) case against him for stalking her and knocked on the door, the police said. When the victim's mother opened the door, he allegedly attacked her with a knife, killing her on the spot. He then entered

the house and allegedly killed the girl's 60-year-old grandmother, who was asleep.

Police said he forced the teenager into his car and drove to a lake in his village. There, he allegedly stabbed the girl to death and left her body near the lake bund. The only person he left unharmed was the victim's mentally challenged sister.

The man then headed to his own home. Around 11.20 pm, he allegedly slit the throats of his 31-year-old wife and their two sons, aged four and 18 months.

After the killings, he called his father and allegedly confessed to the crime. He then fled the village in his car, the police said. The police reached the spot and sent the bodies for post-mortem examination.

The Telangana Police said that after the Pocso case was registered in May, the man went into hiding and later applied for anticipatory bail in June at a local court. He was granted anticipatory bail and was released on personal bond by the police because the offence carried a maximum sentence of less than seven years. The motive of the crime is not known, police said.

Summons for Settlement of Issues.
(Order V, Rules 1 and 5)
In the Court of Commercial Court No. 2, at Agra.
Case No. 11/2026
Bank of Baroda, Kamla Nagar, Branch, Agra
Through its Chief Manager & POA Holder.
-----Plaintiff.
Versus.
Mr. Vikas Mehra S/o Sh. Atul Singh Mehra Proprietor of
M/s. V.J. Mobile r/o 33/18 A, near ITI, Lohiya Nagar,
Balkeshwar, Agra-282004, Mobile No. 79061 79094
-----Defendant.
To,
Whereas the plaintiff has instituted a suit against you for Rs. 13,85,754-49 P. you are hereby summoned to appear in this Court in person, or by a pleader duly instructed, and able to answer all material questions relating to the suit, or who shall be accompanied by some person able to answer all such questions, on the 28 day of July 2026 at 10.30 'O' Clock morning , to answer the claim, and further you are hereby directed to file on that day a written statement of your defence and to produce on the said day all documents in your possession upon you base your defence or claim for set off or counter claim, and where you rely on any other document whether in your possession or power or not, as evidence in your support of your defence or claim for set off or counter claim, you shall enter such documents in a list to be annexed to the written statement.
Take notice that in default of your appearance on the day before mentioned, the suit will be heard and determined in your absence.
Given under my hand and the seal of the Court, this 07 day of July, 2026
**Presiding Officer/Judge
Commercial Court No. 2 Agra**

POSTGRADUATE INSTITUTE OF MEDICAL EDUCATION & RESEARCH, CHANDIGARH
Corrigendum

Subject Corrigendum regarding Terms and Conditions - Point No. 8. In partial modification of the tender no tender No -PGI/Medical Gases/2022/ProcD&D000470 Dated: 17.06.2026 due on 17.07.2026. It is hereby notified that the following provision has been incorporated under **Point No. 8** of the Terms and Conditions of the tender.

Sl. no.	The following provision has been incorporated under point no-8 of the terms and conditions of the tender (Page no-14)
Terms and conditions point no -8 (Page no -14)	The Contractor shall deploy qualified serviceman / Technician in each shifts (three shifts) for each of the four designated zones, namely APC, ACC Hospital buildings, AEC/NOPD Hospital buildings, Nehru Hospital building and ATC Hospital building, to attend day to day complaints and carry out maintenance works throughout the contract period

Term and conditions of tender document will remain same. **Officer In-charge (HPD)**

GOVERNMENT OF ODISHA
OFFICE OF THE CHIEF CONSTRUCTION ENGINEER
RURAL WORKS CIRCLE, ANGUL
E-Mail - sencerwangul@yahoo.co.in
25001/704/2627
No. 2368
Dt. 06/07/26
NOTICE INVITING TENDER FOR ROAD WORKS IN ODISHA
Bid Identification No. Road Online AGL- 15/2025-26

1. Name of the work : Road works
2. Total No. of work : 3 Nos.
3. Estimated cost : Rs.166.00 to Rs. 494.69 Lakhs (Approx.)
4. Class of Contractor : As per annexure.
5. Period of completion : As per annexure.
6. Other details.

Procurement Officer	Bid Identification No.	Availability of Tender on-line for bidding		Last Date & Time of seeking tender clarification	Date & Time of opening of tender	
		From	To		Technical Bid	Financial Bid
1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Chief Construction Engineer, Rural Works Circle, Angul	Road Online-AGL-15/2026-27	13.07.26 at 10.00 A.M	28.07.26 upto 5.00 P.M	27.07.26 1.00 P.M	29.07.26 at 10.00 A.M	Will be intimated later on

For detailed Notice inviting Tenders, Please visit to the website www.tendersorissa.gov.in

OIPR- 25001/25182/1/26-27/0054 Sd/- Chief Construction Engineer, Rural Works Circle, Angul.

Classifieds

TOUR & TRAVELS

NZ ROAD TOURS

Specialist in small group tours. Meet and greet service at Auckland Airport with option for express customs and immigration clearance at Auckland Airport.

Contact us on :
info@nzroadtours.co.nz

Two CMs and their *revdi* secrets



OFF THE RECORD
BY P VAIDYANATHAN IYER

TWO SECRETS shared with this writer by two Chief Ministers, one from the Bharatiya Janata Party and the other from the Congress, give a sense of the dilemmas they face, and the political tightrope they walk. While the identity of the CMs and the states they represent is not pertinent, the message these secret anecdotes deliver is important. It shows just how serious a problem the two CMs face — on the political and fiscal front.

A macro-economic risk that worries those closely following India's federal polity is the worsening financial health of states — slowing revenues, rising expenditure, and an increasing debt to fund the revenue-expenditure gap. Some states such as Telangana, Bihar and Himachal Pradesh struggle to pay salaries to their employees, while some others like Punjab and West Bengal do not have enough to spend on

roads and bridges, or infrastructure, that will help their economy grow.

Yet, come state Assembly elections, leaders of big political parties including the BJP and the Congress do not shy away from announcing new schemes with cash handouts, trying to please different sections of voters — women, the unemployed, and many more.

Secret 1 of a state Chief Minister has its origins in this battleground of competitive populism. This Chief Minister, from a BJP-ruled state, finds himself in a piquant situation during elections in other states. His state does not have any scheme which makes large monthly cash transfers of the kind most other states indulge in. So, when he is called to campaign for his party during elections in other states, he is in a fix — torn between the party's demand to amplify the benefits of a new cash dole-out scheme and his own state's record of prudence in spending. He has been resolute so far. "If you listen to my campaign speeches during elections in other states, I never talk up such cash benefit schemes. I focus on everything else," the CM says.

But why would the CM upset his party colleagues in other states by not talking up the benefits of cash transfers? He is candid. "My people are shrewd. The day I laud, praise and advertise such schemes

A senior bureaucrat, who has worked closely with the Prime Minister says his instinct is to call out his own Cabinet colleagues during meetings when they pitch populist schemes

—even if announced by my own party — in other states, my people will demand the same. I cannot afford to go down that path. So I avoid promoting such promises made in the manifesto," he says. His state is among those with a reasonably good financial health.

But the other Chief Minister's state is not in such good shape. In fact, no sooner did this CM take charge, he realised what he inherited. Being in a party in the Opposition INDIA bloc, he did not expect the BJP-ruled Central government to bail him out for the excesses of a political party in power before him. So exasperated was he with the finances of his state that in an informal meeting with the Prime Minister, one of the first things he told him in private was to do something about these cash handouts. The Prime Minister had kicked off a big political storm when he referred to such sops as "*revdi*" while inaugurating an expressway in Uttar Pradesh in July 2022.

This newly elected CM, most likely, got a patient hearing from the Prime Minister. "I told Prime Minister Modi that the only way to stop political parties from this race to the bottom is to bring a Constitutional amendment and fix a cap on such expenditures," the Chief Minister said.

This, from a CM who belongs to the Congress, a party that more than matches the BJP in announcing cash transfers,

comes across as a leap of faith. But then, the nearly decade-long rule of his predecessor had led to an almost tripling of the state's outstanding debt. More and more debt means higher interest payments. Together with salary and pension, such committed expenditure puts enormous strain on the state's ability to spend money elsewhere — be it for schools and hospitals or highways and development work.

But realpolitik hasn't spared even the Prime Minister, who has a reputation of being tightfisted. A senior bureaucrat, who has worked closely with the Prime Minister says his instinct is to call out his own Cabinet colleagues during meetings when they pitch populist schemes. A telling example was how he finally allowed for a completely free rice and wheat scheme under the Pradhan Mantri Garib Kalyan Yojana. "Once you make it free, there is no way you can even charge 10 paise per kg of rice or wheat," this aide said.

But can free rice or wheat be called a *revdi*? Defining a dole is always a slippery slope. One party's empowerment scheme can be a *revdi* for the rival party. This debate remains unresolved, but poses one of the biggest challenges today.

The writer is Managing Editor, The Indian Express. Off the Record is a fortnightly column

Delusions and distractions



FIFTH COLUMN
BY TAVLEEN SINGH

EVERY TIME I return from a sojourn in some foreign city, I think how lucky our political leaders are that so few Indians can afford to go abroad. Less than 2% of our vast populace ever gets to see a foreign country, so they are unable to ask the questions that they must ask. Questions they cannot ask because they do not know that the more horrific, shameful and depraved aspects of Indian life do not exist in more civilised countries. In countries with less ambition to become the 'Vishvaguru', people do not live in filthy, degraded conditions that become filthier and more degraded when the monsoon comes. The media in those countries do not treat as normal that a thirteen-year-old girl was raped so brutally in Rajasthan by thirty-two men that she died from her internal injuries.

Last week I returned from a few days in London, where I went to catch up with my exiled son. And this child's story was the first I saw on social media after returning home. It shamed me and made me very angry. This young schoolgirl was coming home in an autorickshaw when the driver abducted and then sold her to a hotel owner. He colluded with other hotel owners to arrange for her to be gang raped for five days. She was moved from hotel to hotel, and somehow nobody found out. How? By the time she escaped from the clutches of these evil pervers, her body was too broken to be saved. But if the double-engine chief minister of Rajasthan has shown any empathy, he has done so invisibly.

Invisible also have been those self-appointed guardians of Hindu culture or as they like to put it 'bhartiya sabhyata'. An estimated hundred girls in India, half of them children, are raped every day. Those are the registered cases, the actual figure could be much higher, and never do we see the outrage from those defenders of Indian culture that there should be. They are eloquent about crimes against women in Islamic countries but rarely speak up when little Indian girls are abducted, brutalised and killed. Why?

Still recovering from the horror in Rajasthan, and while switching channels for more uplifting news, I came upon the Chief Minister of Uttar Pradesh speaking about the loot that has gone on in the Ram Temple in Ayodhya on his watch. He railed against those raising their voice against the looting of the temple, on the flimsy grounds that they had no right to speak since they had allowed Muslims to pray on the steps of the Hanumangarhi temple. "Can you imagine the Hanuman Chalisa being recited in a mosque...who are these people to speak when they could not do anything for Ayodhya? It is only when a double-engine government was elected in Uttar Pradesh that the grand temple to Ram could be built."

Chief ministers of 'double-engine' governments say almost nothing without reminding us of that double engine, but the truth is that double-engine governments have done little to improve abysmal living conditions in their states. This is because what they seem to concentrate on is creating double distractions from real issues like the total collapse of infrastructure when the rains come. The monsoon comes every year, even if belatedly because of El Niño and every year, we see flooded homes, broken roads and children dying because of the diseases that the rains bring.

In Mumbai this year, whole sections of the city drowned, and instead of explaining why, the government of Maharashtra spent its time worrying about how to close dance bars and how to bring a uniform civil code. Other double-engine chief ministers distract from their glaring failures of governance by trying to concentrate the attention of gullible voters on statues and temples.

It is no surprise, then, that last week the Global Liveability Index put Delhi and Mumbai at 120 and 121, out of 173 cities. We do not need an international index to tell us that our cities are unlivable. All we need to do is walk down a street or go shopping in a bazaar to stumble over rotting garbage, rats and filth.

Such conditions exist mostly because the average Indian has no idea that there are clean and beautiful cities in other lands. Or because of being lulled into a sense of false pride and nationalism by politicians who tell him that he should not bother about material comforts when he has leaders who build grand temples and statues taller than any other in the world. It is not just ordinary people who get distracted from real issues; we in the media do as well.

Last week, our major TV channels concentrated on showing us pictures of the Prime Minister speaking to the diaspora in different cities on his latest foreign tour and, in Indonesia, how he wandered around one of the grandest Hindu temples, Prambanan, with the Indonesian president in tow.

Speaking of Indonesia and the speech he made there, did you understand at all what he meant when he went on about the number eight? If any of you did, I would sincerely appreciate your thoughts on the significance of this number. During the Covid lockdown, was it not the number nine that he seemed to hold in mystic awe? As someone deeply interested in India becoming better, I hope he finds time one day for real problems.

The writer is a Senior Assistant Editor



INSIDE TRACK | BY COOMI KAPOOR

RETURN TO RAJ RELICS?

Being the original capital of the British Empire, Kolkata boasts some of India's oldest and grandest government residences. But unlike their counterparts in the rest of the country, West Bengal's ministers have not enjoyed the luxury of living in these palatial bungalows in Alipore and Baliganj for over half a century. What should normally be ministerial residences are occupied by senior bureaucrats. The city does not even have an earmarked chief ministerial house. When the Communists came to power in 1977, Marxist ministers pointedly did not live in these relics of the Raj. And Mamata Banerjee, who wanted to emphasise her humble origins, continued this practice. BJP CM Suwendu Adhikari has to decide whether to reclaim the accommodations of colonial glory for politicians or settle for humbler abodes. He himself is likely to move into an irrigation department bungalow in Alipore.

Adhikari has, however, indicated that he will transfer the secretariat back to the iconic Writers' Building, renamed Mahakaran, once the seat of West Bengal's state administration. In 2013, Banerjee abandoned the sprawling three-storey red-stone complex with exquisite Minton tile flooring, originally the central office of the East India Company and later the headquarters of the British government in India. The building is adorned with classical statues and ornate fixtures. Extensive repair work on the 250-year-old structure is required before the new government can move in.

HE IS ONE OF US

Champat Rai, the former general secretary of the Ram Janmabhoomi trust, received barely a slap on the wrist, though he was responsible for overseeing donations to the Ram temple. The Ram trust agreed to accept his resignation only after recording, first, appreciation for his sacrifice for the Ram Temple movement while blaming the State Bank of India for oversight. Those puzzled by a lack of accountability are unfamiliar with the opaque operating style of RSS, where there is no clear-cut corporate chain of command. In the Sangh tradition, a pracharak's age, loyalty and long years of service are much valued. Once an individual is well entrenched in the RSS, it is not easy to distance him from the organisation. A case in point is the VHP's Pravin Togadia, whose erratic, irresponsible behaviour had infuriated even Narendra Modi as Gujarat CM. Despite being an embarrassment to the BJP, Togadia continued as the vice president of VHP International for many years and was in charge virtually after VHP president Ashok Singhal fell ill, even though Modi was by then PM. Togadia was removed only in 2018 after he was pressured into holding an election, which he lost. He quit the RSS and started his own organisation.

Champat Rai, 79, a chemistry lecturer in a UP college, was jailed during the Emergency and later became an RSS pracharak. He was associated with the Ramjanmabhoomi movement in the 1990s, with Singhal as his mentor, and was respected for his legal knowledge of the case and for keeping meticulous records. Some feel that red flags should have been raised earlier. In 2021, the Opposition charged that the trust bought plots in Ayodhya for Rs18.5 crore, though days earlier, an intermediary had purchased the very same land for Rs2 crore. Visitors from Delhi who requested VIP *darshan* at the Ram temple were often put off by Rai's arrogant, cranky behaviour.

TRUMPING A GREY ZONE?

Vivek Aggarwal, IAS officer and ex director of the Financial Intelligence Unit, was appointed Vice President of the 40-member Financial Action Task Force (FATF) this month. India is preparing the ground for petitioning to put Pakistan back on the international FATF grey list alert for money laundering and for financing terrorism. Pakistan's trade, investment and banking were impacted after India succeeded in getting the country listed on a financial alert from February 2012 to February 2015, and again from June 2018 to October 2022, compelling it to go through the motions of prosecuting terrorists from the Lashkar-e-Taiba and Jaish-e-Mohammed for fear of being fully black listed. This week, the NIA filed a detailed charge sheet against LeT chief Hafiz Saeed, establishing Pakistan's role in the Pahalgam terror attack. Data retrieved from the terrorists' phones is said to have established that LeT was providing the coordinates of the Baisaran meadow to the attackers. A rattled Pakistan, which is not a member of FATF, is fully relying on support from the USA, China and Saudi Arabia to block a potential Indian move.

SPLITS, MERGERS AND ACQUISITIONS

A new political trend could emerge in Maharashtra. In both warring factions of the NCP, a section of the party wants to simply merge with the BJP. In the NCP (AP), Praful Patel and Sunil Tatkare are unhappy with Ajit Pawar's immature son Parth attempting to take full charge of the party. In the NCP (SP), Supriya Sule and her father lean towards joining the Congress, while other party MPs prefer the BJP option.

Akashvani: A voice from the sky, and a name that stuck



HISTORY HEADLINE
BY SUANSHU KHURANA

AS AKASHVANI, the official radio broadcasting wing of Prasar Bharati under the Ministry of Information and Broadcasting, celebrates its 90 years, it should not be forgotten that it was born under a different name: All India Radio.

Akashvani (meaning voice from the sky), the delightful term adapted from Rabindranath Tagore's eponymous poem, entered the official vocabulary only two decades later, in 1956, and then coexisted with All India Radio. Until 2023. When an internal order severed ties with the original name and made it mandatory for the institution to be called only by the new official name, Akashvani. In a satellite message, a section of the Prasar Bharati Act, 1990 (which came into force in 1997), was enforced, defining Akashvani as "the offices, stations and other establishments by whatever name called, which immediately before the appointed day formed part of or were under the Director General, All India Radio of the Union Ministry of Information and Broadcasting." It was described as implementing an existing statutory position rather than introducing a new policy. However, the execution strangely occurred more than two decades later.

Celebrating 90 years of Akashvani, then, is technically inaccurate.

The institution may have been called only Akashvani since 2023, but what has turned 90 is what generations of Indians have known as All India Radio.

The distinction between the two names is more than just linguistic. It, perhaps, has little to do with affection for the poetry of Tagore, the Nobel laureate who was extremely critical of the extreme nationalism that later became the core philosophy of the RSS, the ideological mentor of the BJP. The change in nomenclature likely reflects the Union government's Hindi-first approach, which has often mistaken some people's linguistic preferences for national identity. In a multilingual nation. There is also reliance on explaining the term All India Radio as colonial baggage, similar to the justification used for



promoting 'Bharat' instead of India.

The 2023 change puzzled many because, for the nation, both names coexisted. While Akashvani was widely used in Indian-language broadcasts, in English bulletins and shows, one always heard, "This is All India Radio". AIR has also been the institution's global identity.

Not happy with the change, Tamil Nadu MP T R Balu had also written to the Centre, calling the name change "unwarranted" and stating that Tamil Nadu always used the term 'Vaanoli' instead of Akashvani.

One individual instrumental in bringing the name AIR and its identity to the fore was Lionel Fielden, the BBC producer recruited in 1935 as undivided India's first Controller of Broadcasting, and who had the difficult task of coordinating broadcasting development in India. Unhappy with the long and clunky Indian State Broadcasting Service (ISBS), he wanted something simpler. For the change, he had to get past the then Viceroy, Lord Linlithgow. Fielden wrote in his book, *The Natural Bent* (1960), that he cornered Linlithgow after a State dinner, asking for his advice — an opening the man could not ignore. Complaining that the Indian State Broadcasting Service "was a clumsy title" and that "broadcasting" was difficult for many Indians to pronounce, "Fielden requested the Viceroy's help in suggesting a better alternative. "Indian State", I said, was a term which, as he well knew, hardly fitted into the 1935 Act. It should be something general. He rose beautifully to the bait. 'All India'? I expressed my astonishment and admiration... After some thought, he suggested 'Radio'? Splendid, I said — and what beautiful

The beautiful and the damned



ON THE LOOSE
BY LEHER KALA

prepared that the fallout could be potentially disastrous. Indeed, it's imperative to make space for the fact that fickle, thy name is youth. Saying one thing, doing the opposite (while even, perhaps, believing you're doing what you originally claimed) is not necessarily wilful manipulation — rather, at the ripe old age of 22, it's a classic case of keeping all options open, otherwise known as two-timing. As Shakespeare rued about deceivers, one foot in the sea and one on shore, romantic inconstancy is as old as mankind itself. It is one of life's jokes. Either the people we like don't like us back, and when they do, our perverse minds choose another. One can't blame a 20-something for mistakenly believing we can have it all, but only somebody entirely devoid of empathy will commit murder to achieve their end. Normal people stringing two lovers along will cop out midway.

It's also a fact that in the digital era, it's a lot easier to superficially nurture several romantic relationships, all at once. Be-

tween WhatsApp, dating apps, hook-up apps and Instagram, the paradox of choice pops up in exactly the same way it does in a coffee shop. There are tens of options to pick from, like between a latte and a cappuccino, with skimmed or dairy-free milk. On the surface, the profusion of options seems like it's fantastic; there's something for everyone. But it's precisely this surfeit of choices that has turned us all into maximizers, constantly calculating hypothetical trade-offs, while chasing the best possible outcome. While learning to choose is hard, the opposite, not having the choice to begin with, is harder. It does appear that Siya was denied her generation's outlook of enjoying the experience of unlimited possibilities, even if those freedoms carry their own angst. Disregarding the psychological complexities of our adult children to suit convention is robbing them of their journey to becoming who they were meant to be.

The writer is director, Hutkay Films

FINANCIAL STRESS, MISSELLING COULD BE AMONG REASONS LEADING TO PREMATURE EXITS

Premature life policy surrenders soar, overtake maturity payouts

‘Some purchase policies expecting FD-like returns, but discontinue them after seeing long lock-in periods & penalties’

George Mathew
Mumbai, July 11

BLAME IT on financial stress or mis-selling by insurers, surrenders and withdrawals of life insurance policies before maturity have been rising over the past five years. Payouts for surrenders and withdrawals increased from around 30% of total benefits paid to policyholders in FY22 to 38.3% in FY26, suggesting that a growing number of policyholders are exiting their policies before maturity.

In contrast, maturity benefits, or policyholders who completed the full policy term, declined from about 48% in 2021-22 to 36.9% in 2025-26, according to data obtained from insurance regulator IRDAI (Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority).

This means the number of policyholders exiting mid-way through the policy tenure is rising faster than those who completed the policy tenure.

“This could be due to mis-selling by insurers or financial constraints or stress of policyholders. This is not an ideal situation as policyholders don’t get the full benefit when they exit mid-way. They could even

make losses,” said an insurance official. In 2025-26, life insurers paid total benefits of Rs 7.3 lakh crore to policyholders, according to IRDAI data. As much as 38.3% of this is surrender/withdrawal, leading to premature payout of Rs 2.8 lakh crore during the financial year.

When compared to this, the maturity benefit paid by insurers after completing the full term is Rs 2.69 lakh crore.

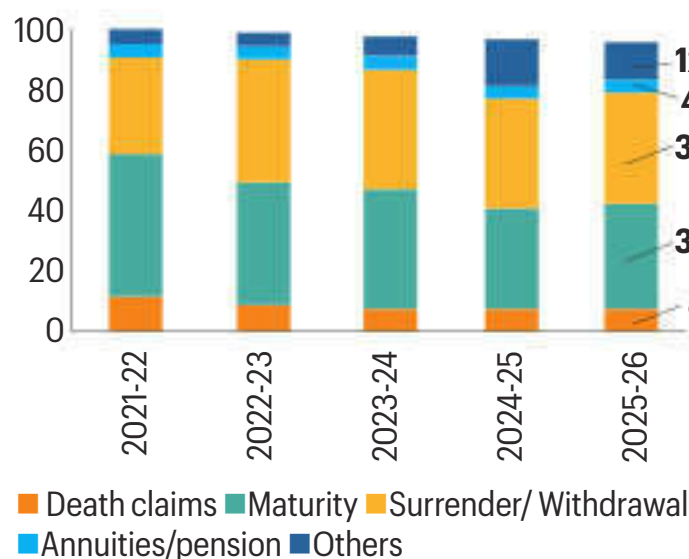
What’s leading to premature exits?

According to insurance experts, many families have surrendered traditional life insurance policies to meet immediate cash needs due to inflation, rising living costs and higher loan repayments in recent years. Some customers purchase policies expecting short-term investment or FD-like returns, but discontinue them after realising later about the long lock-in period and surrender penalties. Further, higher interest rates on bank FDs, stock market and mutual fund investments have become more attractive, prompting many customers to move away from insurance policies that offered comparatively lower returns, they say.

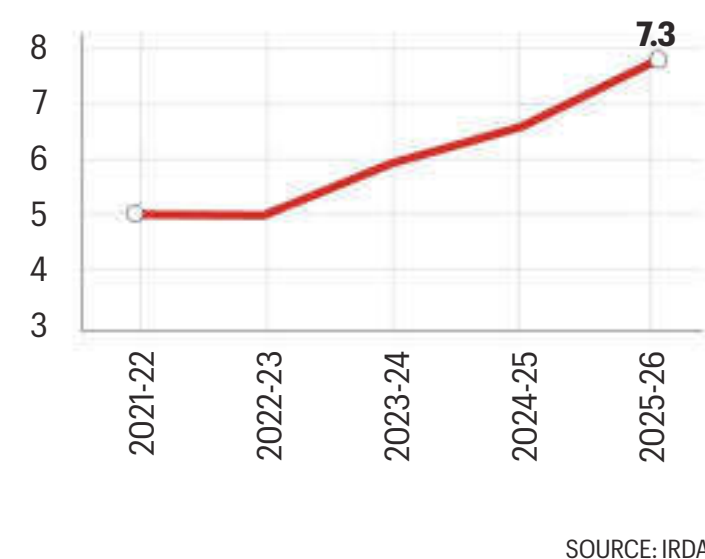
“The near parity between

• CONCERNING TREND

Breakup of benefits paid by life insurers (in %)



Total benefits paid by life insurers (in Rs lakh cr)



surrenders and maturity payouts indicates that policyholders are increasingly exiting policies prematurely. This shift has direct implications for asset-liability management (ALM), as early exits disrupt the long-duration assumptions underpinning life insurance investment strategies and can force asset liquidation ahead of schedule,” the RBI’s Financial Stability Report (FSR) says. Persistently elevated surrender rates also signal policyholder dissatisfaction, product mis-selling, or competitive pressure from alternative financial instruments, it says.

RBI and IRDAI had repeatedly warned against mis-selling by banks and NBFCs.

While the insurance sector remains broadly resilient, several underlying structural pressures exist from a financial stability perspective. Sustained

premium expansion has strengthened the sector’s ability to absorb shocks. However, elevated surrender behaviour in life insurance points to weaker policy persistence introduces uncertainty in asset-liability management, RBI’s FSR says.

Net incurred claims increase

Net incurred claims in the general insurance segment rose from Rs 1.4 lakh crore in 2021-22 to Rs 2.1 lakh crore in 2025-26, an increase of nearly 50% over five years, according to the IRDAI data.

Net claims paid is the amount paid to policyholders after accounting for any recoveries such as reinsurance.

This reflects rising frequency and severity of loss events, particularly in health and motor lines, which together constitute

95.3% of net incurred claims in 2025-26, IRDAI data shows.

Health insurance claims have grown to 55% of total net incurred claims, driven by medical inflation, rising hospitalisation rates and expanding coverage. Motor claims account for 40.3%.

The concentration of claims in these two segments creates correlated and structurally growing loss exposure that may strain reserving adequacy and underwriting margins, if not continuously recalibrated.

PSU general insurers continued to post the largest underwriting losses throughout the last five-year period, widening to Rs 31,000 crore in 2025-26 as against Rs 10,000 crore in the case of private insurers, IRDAI data shows.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

India seeks review of US’ forced labour investigation

Ravi Dutta Mishra
New Delhi, July 11

INDIA HAS sought the review of proposed US tariffs of 12.5% citing inconsistencies in its Section 301 investigation into forced labour concerns, as the deadline for fresh US tariffs scheduled to be imposed by July 24 nears.

The US has currently imposed 10% global tariffs.

Joint Secretary in the Department of Commerce Brij Mohan Mishra, during a public hearing, said that India takes the elimination of forced labour seriously as a Constitutional obligation, and as a matter of international law and principle.

“India would like to highlight its concerns with the USTR’s report and findings against India,” he said.

The USTR has not satisfied the relevant legal standards under Section 301(d) of the Trade Act. A mere absence of a forced labour import prohibition without evidentiary basis of other statutory requirements cannot be construed as unreasonable under Section 301, he added.

The USTR determination does not provide a rationale for countrywide tariffs and impermissibly clubs 46 economies (including India) into a single category, according to the written transcript of the hearing, held on July 8 and published on the USTR website.

The report, he said, relies on broad data and it presupposes that an economy’s imports flagged for this stuff involving imports made with forced labour are exported to the US without providing any sector- or country-specific evidence and actual linkages with forced labour. In relation to India, there is inadequate and insufficient evidence that a lack of a forced labour import ban causes an unfair competitive advantage to the detriment of



The 12.5% US tariff could come into effect starting July 24. REUTERS

the American industry, he said.

“In conclusion, it is submitted that the USTR reconsider the imposition of tariffs in light of the identified inconsistencies in the report in the Federal Register notice. We ask that any trade problems be addressed within the framework of the India-US bilateral trade negotiation, not through unilateral measures such as this investigation,” he added.

Arguing on behalf of Indian industry, Anil Rajvanshi, President of Reliance Industries Limited (RIL), said that their petrochemical intermediates use crude oil and ethane sourced from low-risk origins, including the United States, and are far removed from sectors like agriculture where state-imposed forced labour is typically documented.

Furthermore, they do not subcontract to third-party factories and maintain a strict code of conduct subject to ESG audits. RIL pointed out that the US already imposes significant duties on Indian products like PSF and PET resin, with rates already in the mid-tens to high twenties. Adding a 12.5% Section 301 duty would stack tariffs to between 30 and 40%, which would increase costs and risk production cuts for US downstream users while having little impact on forced labour incentives, Rajvanshi said.

Rajvanshi warned that levying these tariffs would “kill the remaining small portion of the

textile industry that exists in the US” because the downstream industry requires a full value chain of raw materials at competitive prices to flourish.

Making submissions on behalf of Agricultural and Processed Food Products Export Development Authority (APEDA), Shreyans Gupta, First Secretary in the Embassy of India in Washington, DC, said that the export promotion body objects to the USTR’s observations on the import of rice allegedly made with forced labour into India and the alleged impact on such imports in distorting the competitive conditions for the export and domestic sale of rice produced in the US.

Gupta said that the overall value of rice imported into India in relation to the value of rice exported from India to the US is not even 3%.

He added that there are regulatory checks in place that prevent exports of imported rice from India that have been produced with forced labour.

Export of rice from India to the US is allowed only from the rice mills and processing units registered with the agriculture ministry.

“For these reasons, the present investigation against India may be rescinded without prejudice,” Gupta said, requesting exemption for Indian rice from the proposed duty if the proceedings continue.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Gaming industry winning despite a real money ban

Kunal Doley
New Delhi, July 11

REAL-MONEY gaming (RMG) may have been banned, but India’s gaming industry has not lost the game.

From in-app purchases to premium passes, cosmetic spending to subscriptions and advertising-led monetisation, the industry is rapidly expanding its revenue streams to sustain growth momentum since the ban that became effective from May 1 this year.

Long dependent on RMG as the primary driver of growth, the shift marks a significant milestone in the history of the industry as Indian gaming revenue breached the \$1-billion barrier for the first time last year, as per the latest Asia & MENA Games Market Model Report released by Niko Partners, a market research firm covering games, e-sports, and streaming in Asia.

The report further forecasts that the total revenue will grow 14% by the end of this year to nearly \$1.2 billion, and reach \$1.77 billion by 2030 at a 5-year CAGR of 11.2%. As per the firm, India is the fastest growing market in gaming in Asia and MENA region.

As per Niko Partners, there were nearly 511 million players

in India in 2025, and it expects the number to reach nearly 707 million by 2030, growing at a CAGR of 6.7% during the forecast period.

“India became the world’s largest market for game downloads a few years ago, which showed just how many people were playing games. What’s exciting now is that the market is evolving beyond downloads. People are spending more time playing, exploring a wider variety of games, and increasingly paying for experiences they enjoy,” said Sidharth Kedia, chief strategy and investments officer at NODWIN Gaming, a company focused on e-sports, gaming and youth entertainment. “We remain focused on building innovative technology that empowers people everywhere.” The lawsuit sets up a battle over who will control future AI devices that may not use traditional apps or operating systems — devices which, if successful, would direct consumer attention away from Apple’s iPhone.

Analysts say OpenAI is working on a phone or other device of its own. Tensions between the two tech companies have risen as the race to develop AI products has intensified competition for talent and proprietary technology.

Apple sues OpenAI for theft of trade secrets

Reuters
Washington, July 11

APPLE ON Friday sued OpenAI and two former employees, alleging misappropriation of its trade secrets to benefit the ChatGPT-owner’s foray into consumer hardware, a dramatic escalation of already simmering tension between the two companies.

The complaint accuses OpenAI of orchestrating a broad effort to systematically acquire and exploit Apple’s confidential information through former employees, recruiting practices and supplier relationships to accelerate its push into the consumer hardware business.

“We have no interest in other companies’ trade secrets,” OpenAI said in a statement. “We remain focused on building innovative technology that empowers people everywhere.” The lawsuit sets up a battle over who will control future AI devices that may not use traditional apps or operating systems — devices which, if successful, would direct consumer attention away from Apple’s iPhone.

Analysts say OpenAI is working on a phone or other device of its own. Tensions between the two tech companies have risen as the race to develop AI products has intensified competition for talent and proprietary technology.

HDFC’s PART-TIME CHAIR ATANU’S EXIT Mistry defends HDFC’s governance standards



Atanu Chakraborty’s resignation had triggered speculation around the bank’s governance standards. PHOTO: EXPRESS ARCHIVE

George Mathew
Mumbai, July 11

HDFC BANK’s Part-time Chairman Keki Mistry has mounted a full-scale defence of its corporate governance after the dramatic exit of former Chairman Atanu Chakraborty triggered speculation on the bank’s governance standards.

Mistry assured shareholders that the bank remains committed to the “highest standards of transparency, accountability and oversight”, saying any matter warranting review or attention “will continue to receive careful consideration through established processes” and in the long-term interests of shareholders and other stakeholders.

“In my capacity as the interim Part-time Chairman of HDFC Bank, I, together with the board of the bank, would

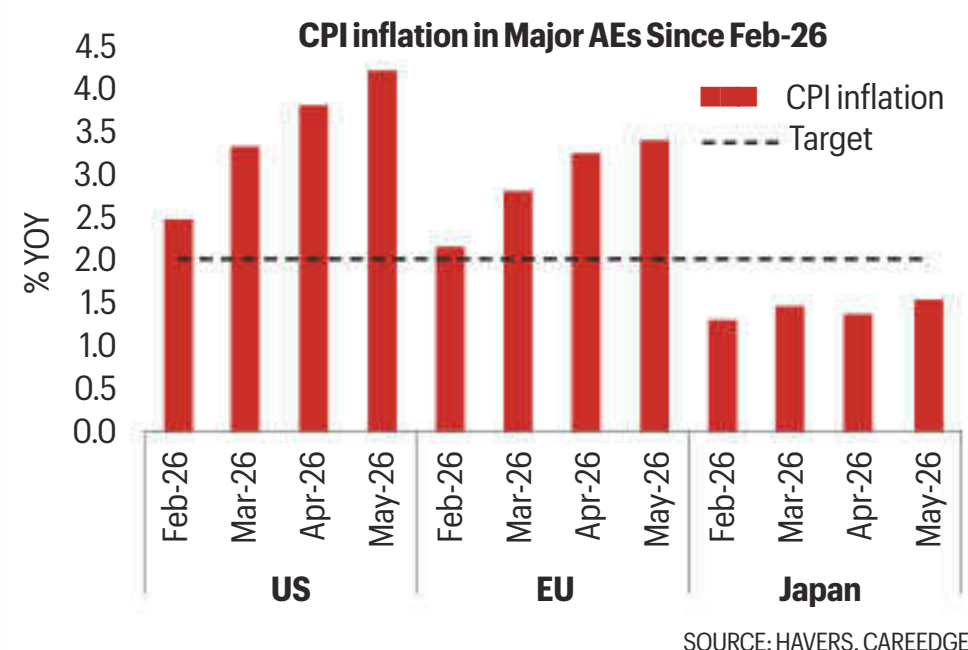
like to assure you that the bank remains strongly rooted in strong corporate governance principles and values,” Mistry said in the bank’s annual Report. He said resignation of Chakraborty as the Part-time Chairman of the bank on March 18, 2026 “led to speculation on the bank’s governance standards”.

After Chakraborty’s exit, the bank acted swiftly to announce the appointment of an interim Part-time Chairman on March 18 with the approval of the Reserve Bank of India, he said.

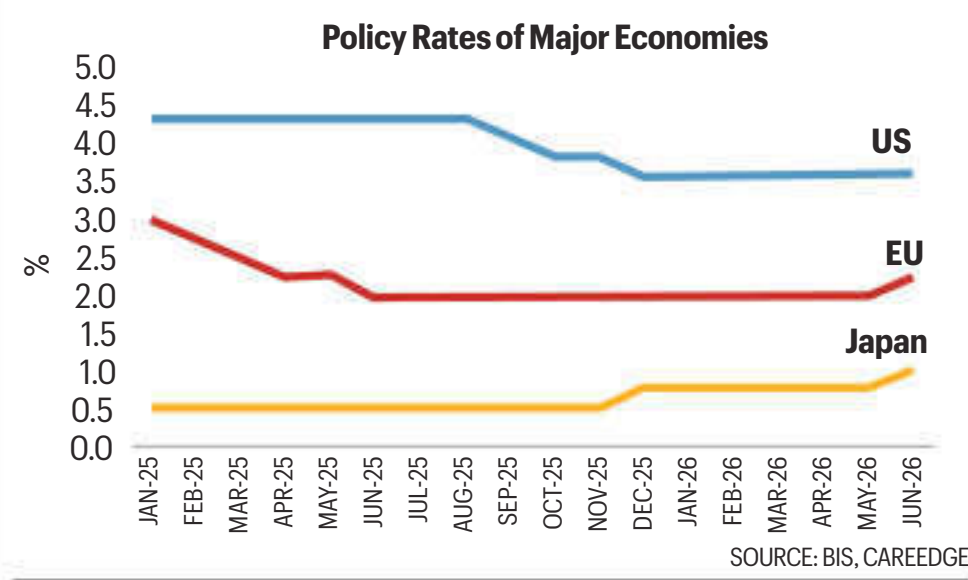
On June 26, HDFC Bank said external law firms, which conducted a “thorough and objective review” of its former Chairman Chakraborty’s statement about “certain practices and happenings” in the bank, reported that Chakraborty’s statement and its implications were “not substantiated”.

• Global economies face rising inflationary pressures

The US Consumer Price Index (CPI) data for the month of June will be out on July 14. The war in West Asia, which took a brief pause and has resumed again, has been slowly fuelling inflation with elevated energy prices. In its July 1 report, CareEdge says that the rising inflation is making central banks a bit hawkish.



SOURCE: HAWERS, CAREEDGE



SOURCE: BIS, CAREEDGE

FSSAI seeks reply from Swiggy Instamart after complaints

New Delhi: Food regulator FSSAI on Saturday said it has issued 9 notices to quick-commerce platform Swiggy Instamart following several consumer complaints, including of alleged supply of rotten and expired food products, against the platform.

In a social media post on X, Food Safety Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) said it has “issued 9 notices to Swiggy Instamart following multiple consumer complaints alleging violations under the FSS Act 2006.” The FSSAI informed that the consumer complaints “alleged the supply of expired, spoiled, rotten, contaminated and otherwise unsafe food products through Swiggy Instamart”. The regulator has directed the platform to submit a detailed explanation and compliance report. Meanwhile, an Instamart spokesperson said: “We are reviewing the flagged listings by FSSAI and are in touch with the authorities to resolve the same.” PTI

• IT IS ONE OF THE WORLD’S LONGEST AND MOST POWERFUL (2,400 KILOWATT) HYDROGEN TRAINSETS

PM to flag off India’s first hydrogen train: Why the technology is so challenging

Dheeraj Mishra
New Delhi, July 11

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi will flag off India’s first hydrogen-powered train in Jind, Haryana on July 17. This will mark a major milestone for the Indian Railways in a green technology where few countries have ventured so far.

According to the Railways, this is one of the world’s longest (eight passenger cars and two driving power cars) and most powerful (2400 kilowatt) hydrogen trainsets.

The train can carry at least 682 passengers on the 89-km Jind-Sonapat railway section at a maximum operational speed of 75 km/h. It will make two round trips a day, covering 356 km and consuming an estimated 300 kg of hydrogen.

Hydrogen is highly flammable and needs to be transported at very high pressure. How will the Railways do this? And how will the train work? We explain.

HYDROGEN TRAINS ELSEWHERE

French rolling stock giant Alstom presented the technology for the first time at a 2016 exhibition in Berlin. Its two-car trainset, the Coradia iLint, was launched in Germany two years later, becoming the world’s first hydrogen-powered passenger train.

Later, countries such as Japan, China and the US also launched their own hydrogen-powered trains.

The technology, however, is still evolving to cater to the mass transportation of passengers and freight. That is why few countries have hydrogen train services, and those that do

use them mostly for relatively short trips.

HOW THESE TRAINS WORK

Normal electrical locomotives require overhead wires to draw the alternating current that powers their movement. Hydrogen trains don’t. They run on the simple formula of combining hydrogen with oxygen to produce the tractive electricity.

In the Indian hydrogen train’s case, each of the two driving power cars will have four sets of integrated power packs, comprising hydrogen fuel cells and a lithium ferro phosphate battery. The hydrogen fuel cell will draw in the hydrogen stored on board (440 kg) at high pressure and oxygen from the outside air, then combine them to release electrical energy. One power



The technology, however, is evolving. A handful of countries use them mostly for short trips. PHOTO: NORTHERN RAILWAYS

pack will release 300 kW of energy — 115 kW from the fuel cell and 185 kW from the lithium ferro phosphate battery. The four power packs will provide 1200 kW of power.

Since the train has two power cars, the total power gen-

erated doubles to 2400 kW (3200 hp). This is comparable to the horsepower generated by normal ‘electric multiple unit’ or ‘diesel-electric multiple unit’ trains that cover similar, short-haul distances.

A senior Northern Railway

official said that the train was essentially created by replacing the diesel engines on old ‘diesel electric multiple unit’ rakes with a zero-emission hydrogen-electric propulsion system. The official explained the working of the power pack of the hydrogen cell and battery. “The fuel cell provides a constant power output, meaning it does not fluctuate with the train’s changing power demand. When the train starts moving, it initially draws the power from the fuel cell, and since the train’s power requirement at that stage is lower, the surplus electricity from the fuel cell goes into charging the onboard battery. As the train reaches higher speed and its power demand increases, the battery kicks in

to provide power in addition to the fuel cell,” he said.

“Later, when the train’s power requirement goes down, especially when the train is nearing the station, the battery power cuts off and the excess energy of the fuel cell starts charging the battery. Thus, after covering a complete circuit, the battery is almost 80% charged at the end of the journey,” said the official.

The main part of the system — the fuel cell — has been imported from the Canadian company Ballard, which specialises in its production.

STORING AND SUPPLYING HYDROGEN

Normal atmospheric pressure is measured as one “bar”. Hydrogen, however, has to be

stored at 200-500 bar. This is the biggest challenge in using hydrogen as a clean fuel in trains. There are other issues too. Hydrogen production levels are low and transporting is difficult. To ensure the continuous supply of hydrogen for the trains, the railways has set up a 3000-kg-capacity fueling facility at Jind. A chiller plant has also been developed to keep the hydrogen at minus 15 degrees Celsius during dispensing — the low temperature will transform it into a liquid state and, thus, ensure its easy dispensing. The Railways, however, has not yet announced any other hydrogen train project. The official quoted above said that the future of the project would depend on how the first train works. FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

US lawmaker Khanna says armed Israeli settlers detained him during West Bank visit

Rami Ayyub
Turmus Ayya, July 11

US DEMOCRATIC lawmaker Ro Khanna said he was detained by Israeli settlers armed with US-made rifles during a West Bank visit this week that he cast as an unfiltered look at the human toll of Israeli occupation as he weighs a 2028 presidential run.

Speaking with Reuters on Thursday in a Palestinian village, Khanna said his group's van was surrounded by settlers wielding M4 rifles a day earlier while touring a part of the southern West Bank where residents face frequent settler attacks.

"We were at a village that Israeli settlers had destroyed, they had destroyed the school, they had destroyed that village, and we were just looking at it," said Khanna, a progressive lawmaker from California in the US House of Representatives.

"And these hoodlums come in with machine guns – M4, an American-made machine gun – and they detain us. They block off the road. And then they call the IDF and the IDF is on their side, not on the side of



Ro Khanna speaks with a Palestinian resident of Turmus Ayya, near Ramallah. REUTERS

the Americans," Khanna said.

An aide to Khanna who was in the group, Cameron Kasky, said they were held for more than an hour and made appeals to the US Embassy in Jerusalem for help. A group of officers who appeared to be police eventually intervened, leading to their release, Kasky said.

The Israeli military said troops and police officers intervened after receiving a report of settlers blocking vehicles near Khirbet Zanuta, a small Palestinian hamlet whose residents were forcibly displaced by violent settler raids.

Israel's police did not immediately respond to a request for comment, nor did the US Embassy in Jerusalem. REUTERS

IRAN THREATENS TO AVENGE SUPREME LEADER'S KILLING

US seeks Iranian pledge to free up Strait of Hormuz

Parisa Hafezi
& Steve Holland
Dubai, Washington, July 11

IRAN'S FOREIGN Minister Abbas Araqchi arrived in Oman on Saturday to discuss arrangements for the safe passage of ships through the Strait of Hormuz, with Washington seeking a public pledge of free, secure transit.

US President Donald Trump said on Friday the US and Iran had agreed to continue talks despite an escalation of hostilities this week, while also declaring an end to the ceasefire reached between the two sides.

No attacks were reported on Friday or early Saturday, however, and a senior Iranian source told *Reuters* a call between Iran, the US, Qatar, and Pakistan had been agreed and mediators were trying to arrange it for Saturday while Araqchi is in Oman.

Oman is helping to mediate an end to a war that has spread insecurity in the Gulf and raised prices around the world since the US and Israel launched airstrikes on Iran on February 28.



Supporters of Iran's Supreme Leader Mojtaba Khamenei. REUTERS

CBS News and its UK partner the BBC both reported that US Vice President JD Vance, Secretary of State Marco Rubio, special envoy Steve Witkoff and Trump's son-in-law Jared Kushner were expected to lead negotiations on Saturday with Araqchi. Iran's Fars news agency later cited a source saying no negotiations would take place until the U.S. retreated from its positions.

Three Qatari and Saudi commercial tankers came

under fire earlier in the week, prompting the US to hit Iranian sites, and Iran to respond with strikes on U.S. military sites in Gulf states. Araqchi accused the US of violating the ceasefire agreement; the U.S. revoked the license authorizing the sale of Iranian crude on Tuesday after the vessels were hit.

"There can only be mutual compliance," he wrote on X.

Meanwhile, a written statement from Iran's new supreme leader, Ayatollah Mojtaba

Khamenei, on Saturday threatened vengeance for the death of his predecessor and father, who was killed on February 28.

Released to mark funeral ceremonies for former leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, which the new leader did not attend, it said the vengeance would take place whatever happened to Iran. "We pledge to avenge the blood of the martyred leader and all the martyrs," the message said.

Trump had posted on Friday that he had ordered the U.S. military to be prepared to launch thousands of missiles against Iran if Tehran attempted to assassinate him.

The Wall Street Journal and other U.S. media reported this week that Israel had shared intelligence with Washington that Iran had recently devised a plan to assassinate Trump. There was no immediate comment from Iran on Trump's latest remarks. At the funeral ceremonies on Thursday, a huge crowd of mourners packed a courtyard, some bearing banners reading, "We Will Kill Trump." REUTERS

6 dead, dozens wounded as Russia strikes Ukraine with missiles, drones

Max Hunder
Kyiv, July 11

RUSSIA LAUNCHED missile and drone attacks on Ukraine on Saturday, killing six people and wounding dozens more, officials said, as Kyiv awaited supplies of air defence munitions amid a shortage that has left it exposed to Russian attacks.

Four people were killed and 17 wounded when two glide bombs hit a crowded area in the northern city of Sumy, authorities said. One of the bombs hit a bus stop, and pictures showed a destroyed yellow bus with one of its sides ripped off.

Two more people were killed and another was wounded earlier in the day by a missile strike on the southern port city of Odesa, while a drone hit a civilian enterprise in the eastern city of Kharkiv, wounding seven.

Eleven people, meanwhile, had been wounded in the capital Kyiv during an overnight attack that used ballistic and cruise missiles as well as drones.

"Civilian infrastructure was hit even before the air raid alert was issued," President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said, referring to the attacks on Kyiv. "Our defenders managed to shoot down most of the targets, but not the ballistic ones."

He reiterated a call for Ukraine's allies to quickly deliver the support packages of air defences agreed at the NATO summit this week.

Russia launched six ballistic missiles, another six cruise missiles and 121 drones in the overnight attacks including against Kyiv, Ukraine's air force said on Saturday morning, before the strikes on Odesa, Kharkiv and Sumy took place. REUTERS

Several NYT journalists subpoenaed as Trump ups pressure on media

Michael M. Grynbau
July 11

THE TRUMP administration issued subpoenas Friday to several journalists for *The New York Times*, after the news outlet reported this week on security concerns involving President Donald Trump's new Qatari-donated Air Force One.

The subpoenas — which seek to force the reporters to testify before a federal grand jury in New York on Wednesday — were an extraordinary escalation in Trump's efforts to threaten and intimidate independent news organizations.

In some cases, the subpoenas were delivered by federal agents who showed up at reporters' homes. "The appearance of federal law enforcement agents on the doorstep of news reporters should shock the conscience of any American who believes in the Constitution and the press freedom it protects," David McCraw, the *Times*' top newsroom lawyer, said in a statement Friday evening.

"Our journalists report the facts and advance the American

public's right to know how their government is operating and their taxpayer dollars are being used," McCraw wrote. "This brazen act should be seen as nothing more than an attempt to prevent the public from knowing what is happening in their country by intimidating journalists from doing their jobs."

Representatives for the White House and the U.S. attorney in Manhattan did not immediately respond to inquiries Friday evening.

The journalists who received subpoenas included Julian E Barnes, Eric Lipton, Tyler Pager and Eric Schmitt, who reported Wednesday that Trump had departed Turkey on the old Air Force One as a security precaution at the urging of the Secret Service.

On Thursday, the *Times* reported that the new Air Force One, a Qatari-donated Boeing 747-8, lacked some of the security features of the older aircraft, including anti-missile capabilities. Both articles cited sources who spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss sensitive security issues. NYT

North Korea slams NATO summit, says denuclearisation should start with US allies

Reuters
Seoul, July 11

NORTH KOREA condemned the United States and its allies on Saturday for what it called strengthening military blocs and accelerating arms buildups after a NATO summit this week.

Pyeongyang accused NATO leaders of portraying North Korea's exercise of its legitimate

sovereign rights as a threat, the foreign ministry said in a statement carried on state media KCNA.

The alliance demonstrated a stronger commitment to bloc-to-bloc confrontation through increased arms spending and closer military cooperation with allies in the Asia-Pacific region, the ministry said.



Typhoon Bavi makes landfall in China

Rain clouds cover downtown before the arrival of Typhoon Bavi in Wenzhou, Zhejiang province, China, on Saturday. More than 1.8 million people were evacuated from several cities including Beijing as emergency response measures have been stepped up, authorities said. REUTERS

Meta appeals verdict that blamed it for social media addiction among youth

Kaitlyn Huamani
July 11

META, THE parent company of Instagram and Facebook, has appealed the verdict of a landmark social media addiction lawsuit in Los Angeles, challenging the jury's determination that the company designed its platforms to hook young users without concern for their well-being.

Lawyers representing Meta filed a notice of appeal Tuesday in Los Angeles County Superior Court. The lawyers will provide their arguments related to the appeal in subsequent court filings. The case centered on a 20-year-old woman who said she became addicted to social media as a child and that it wor-



Meta CEO Mark Zuckerberg

sened her mental health struggles. The jury found that negligence by both Meta and Google-owned YouTube, which was also a defendant in the case, was a substantial factor in causing harm to the young woman, identified in court only by her initials, KGM, and her first name, Kaley.

The jury awarded her \$3 million in damages and recom-

mended an additional \$3 million in punitive damages. Her lead attorney, Mark Lanier, said in a statement Friday that the legal team is expecting the appellate court to "continue the careful application of the law to this case, affirming the verdict of the trial court."

A notice of appeal starts what can be a lengthy process. A Meta spokesperson provided a statement Friday that they also gave when the jury returned the verdict in March, saying that teen mental health is "profoundly complex and cannot be linked to a single app." José Castañeda, a spokesperson for Google, said in a statement Friday that YouTube plans to appeal and that "these are standard motions for this case to move forward." AP

• BRIEFLY

UNITED KINGDOM

King Charles hosts Prince Harry in a bid to repair family rift



Prince Harry moved to America with his wife six years ago. REUTERS

whether he would meet with his father. Harry's visit also coincided with him losing his final lawsuit in his quest to tame the British tabloids. REUTERS

KING CHARLES III hosted Prince Harry and met with his family for the first time in years Friday as they try to repair a rift that has persisted since his youngest son and wife quit royal life and moved to America six years ago. Harry, Meghan and their two children, Prince Archie and Princess Lilibet, met with the king and Queen Camilla at Highgrove House, a country estate west of London, Buckingham Palace confirmed. The Duke of Sussex had arrived Monday in his homeland for a number of charity events that were overshadowed by speculation of

BAHAMAS

10 killed after small plane crashes, probe on

A SMALL plane crashed in the Bahamas on Friday, killing 10 people and prompting the government to temporarily ground Flamingo Air flights. The deadly incident happened in North Andros, located in waters just west of Nassau, the archipelago's capital. Bahamian PM Philip Brave Davis had initially said that one person survived, but he later confirmed in a press conference that the person died from their injuries. The victims have not been identified. AP

CONGO

US humanitarian worker tests positive for Ebola

A US citizen working for a humanitarian organization in Congo has tested positive for the Ebola virus, the US Centres for Disease Control and Prevention said on Friday, as the Central African country struggles to contain the swelling outbreak. The CDC said it was working with the person's employer, US agencies, the public health authorities and Congolese partners to prevent further transmission and identify close contacts. REUTERS

• NEIGHBOURHOOD WATCH

PAKISTAN

5 people shot dead in KPK over old feud

AT LEAST five people, including a woman, were shot dead on Saturday in an alleged incident of longstanding enmity in Pakistan's restive Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province, police said. According to police, the shooting took place in the Lakki Marwat district of the province. Initial investigations suggest the attack was motivated by an old personal feud, although authorities said the exact circumstances behind the incident are still being investigated. PTI

SRI LANKA

Indian envoy meets visiting business group

INDIAN HIGH Commissioner to Sri Lanka Santosh Jha met a visiting business delegation from India and discussed ways to expand economic partnership, noting that bilateral trade has surpassed USD 7 billion. "Driving export growth, deepening economic ties! Pleased to meet the 31-member business delegation from the Federation of Indian Export Organisations (FIEO), visiting Sri Lanka from 8â€"10 July," Jha said in a post on X. PTI

Floods in Bangladesh kill 44, leave over a million stranded

Reuters
Dhaka, July 11

FLOODS AND landslides triggered by days of torrential monsoon rain have killed at least 44 people in southeastern Bangladesh and left over a million stranded as authorities raced on Saturday to deliver aid to devastated communities.

The disaster management ministry said on Saturday that flooding across seven districts — Chattogram, Cox's Bazar, Bandarban, Rangamati, Khagrachhari, Moulvibazar and Habiganj — has disrupted daily life, isolated thousands of families, and stranded 267,918 households.

Power outages, damaged

roads and broken communication links have slowed rescue and relief efforts. Many residents have been unable to cook for days as flood waters submerged their homes, while others are struggling after thick layers of mud covered kitchens and living spaces.

"There is still water inside our home and we have no way to cook. The dry food we had has run out, and we spend the nights in the dark with our children because there is no electricity," said Nurul Islam, a resident of a flood-hit area in Chattogram. Thousands of families are relying on dry food — flattened rice, puffed rice or biscuits that do not require cooking — and emergency relief.

• MANY YOUNG DANCERS DIED DURING THE DEADLY QUAKE IN THE LATIN AMERICAN NATION

Venezuela's teenage earthquake survivor mourns her 'young forever' friends

Sarah Kinosián
La Guaira, July 11

MARIA ALEJANDRA Sanz turned away when she heard rescue workers had pulled the lifeless body of one of her best friends from the rubble of a building leveled by twin earthquakes that struck La Guaira in northern Venezuela last month.

The 17-year-old high school student had lain in near-darkness for 17 hours after the June 24 quakes, trapped beneath the collapsed building in the coastal town where she had grown up, drinking her own urine to survive and assuming the other members of her dance troupe were dead.

Of the group of 10 friends preparing a routine for their high school graduation, four did not make it out alive.

"I'm fine," Sanz said unconvincedly nine days after the disaster, the Caribbean air still heavy with dust and grief. Earlier that day, rescuers had pulled the body of her friend, Gonzalo Marquez, from the rubble.

Then came unanswerable questions: Would her friends have survived if rescuers had arrived sooner? Would things be different if the troupe had practiced elsewhere? Why does she get to go to university, while he is laid to rest? Raised amid economic collapse, mass migration and authoritarian rule, Sanz and

her friends began 2026 believing the US ouster of Venezuelan President Nicolás Maduro might finally offer a different future. Then came the quakes, which the government says have killed over 4,000 and injured nearly 17,000.

The troupe had been practicing seven days a week, sometimes until 3 a.m. That evening, in the ground-floor party hall, they had been refining moves to Michael Jackson's "Dangerous." Graduation was three days away.

About 20 minutes before the quakes struck, Marquez asked Sanz for water. She went up to her third-floor apartment, petted her dog Bruna for the last time and was about to reach the



A drone view shows the remains of the apartment building where Maria Alejandra Sanz was trapped. REUTERS

water when the building started to shake at 6:04 p.m.

She moved to a door frame and seconds later was engulfed

in darkness as the floors below gave way. The frame fell diagonally across her midsection, shielding her from a collapsed

wall. Sanz saw a sliver of light across her fingers and freed her feet by slipping out of oversized sneakers. She drank her own urine to survive. The light faded and she prayed: "If I have to die, let it be while I'm asleep."

She woke to light again and clawed toward it, wedging her body between chunks of concrete and making a hole she could fit through. Emerging half free, she yelled to a neighbor. Her father sprinted up the debris. When she reached her mother, she learned five of her 10 friends had escaped unscathed.

"What about Gonzalo? Isa?" she asked. There was no news about Marquez, but rescuers had seen Isa Campos alive beneath

rubble. At the time it was true.

Her father Jeffry spent all night plunging into the wreckage. By 11 a.m., Caracas police joined, using bare hands. The equipment needed to pull Isa from between beams never arrived. She died some 24 hours later. "Help arrived late," her father said. "Rescue workers, firemen and the military did not arrive until two or three days later." After seeing a TikTok video about the trapped dancers, civil engineer Andres Ganscka set out from Colombia with tools and supplies. "I saw it and thought, 'That could be my daughter,'" he said. He coordinated volunteers at the site, scouring rubble for missing

dancers and 15 other children. Venezuelan authorities arrived three days after him. He spent around \$35,000 on the effort.

Sanz and Marquez both had places at universities in Caracas. He planned to study engineering; she focused on architecture. They talked about staying in Venezuela to build a better country. By senior year, they were inseparable friends. He teased her with sarcastic jokes. They were Mr. and Mrs. Claus at the school's Christmas performance. When not dancing, they practiced piano. "He was often the only boy, he didn't care what anyone thought, full of personality and the protector of the crew," Sanz said. REUTERS

Classifieds

PERSONAL

I, Ospal S/O Sarman Lal, R/O House-10, 20/285 Kalyan Puri Esat, Delhi-110017, Have Changed My Name To Ospal Singh Chouhan, For All Purposes

0040865570-7

I, Kuldeep S/o Nathi Ram R/o-686, Sector-7-B Faridabad, Haryana, have changed my name to kuldeep Saga

0040865449-1

I, Lakshya Sharma S/o Anil Kumar R/o 105, Basant Gaon, Vasant Vihar, New Delhi-110057, inform that in my school records my father's name has wrongly mentioned as Anil Kumar Sharma instead of Anil Kumar

0040865548-4

I, Mihita Kumari D/o Sanjay Kumar Chourasia R/o 17, Saini Enclave, Laxmi Nagar, Delhi-92, declare my father's name wrongly written as Sanjay Kumar in 10th marksheet. Correct name is Sanjay Kumar Chourasia in all other documents, to be used for all future purposes.

0130066695-1

I, MOHDAASH MOHAMMD, S/O-ALLAHA MEHAR, R/O-House no.15, Gali, no-1, Near-Road Wali Masjid, Pasoda, Paswada, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh-201005, Has changed my name to AAS MOHAMMAD, permanently, for all future purpose.

0040865526-7

I, NEERAJ GHANSHAM DASS MALHOTRA S/O Ghansham Dass Malhotra R/O 26D/DG-1, Vikas Puri, New Delhi-110018, have changed my name to NEERAJ MALHOTRA

0040865526-4

I, Ruchika W/o Rohan Massey, R/o S-2, Newzeland High-Commission, Nyaya Marg, Chanakya Puri, New Delhi-110021, have change my name, from Ruchika to Ruchika Massey, for all, future purpose

0040865567-2

I, TASEEM KOSSER Wo Army Number-9114821H HAV MOHD BISHARAT KHAN, S/O-Abdul Majeed Khan, Presently Posted At-2 Jak Li (Sherwani) Military Station Leimakhong, Manipur, Permanent Resident of Village Dharati, Post Office Dharglong, Tehsil Mendhar, District Poonch, J&K, do hereby declare that in my husband Army-Record, my name has been wrongly-written as TASIM KOUSAR, whereas my correct name is TASEEM KOSSER.

0040865570-9

I, NISHTHA, residing at B-50, Chardham Apartment, Sector 9, Rohini, Delhi - 110085, have added my family surname VATS to my name. Henceforth, I shall be known as NISHTHA VATS for all future purposes. I have changed my name via an affidavit dated 10.07.2026.

0040865458-1

I, Atul V Nayak, S/o-Rameshwar V R/o-H.No.1055, Pana Paposiyan, Narela, Delhi-110040, have changed my name, from Atul V Nayak, to Atul Vislavath Nayak, for all purposes.

0040865520-2

I, Sakva Khanam Sherwani, wife of, Mr.Sadiq Khan, resident of, C-53/9, Gali No. 06, Chauhau Bangar, New Seelampur, Delhi-53, have changed my name to Sakva Begam, for all, future purposes.

0040865559-2

I, Nitesh Bhati S/o Baleshwer Bhati R/o Bisirakh Jalalpur Bisirakh Jalalpur Bisirakh Gautam Buddha Nagar Uttar Pradesh-203207, has changed my name from NITESH BHATI to NITISH BHATI for all future Purposes.

0071047218-1

I, ISRAR S/O SAGEER AHMAD R/O-E-59/252, Kalander Colony, Dilshad Garden, Shahdara, Delhi-110095, has changed my name to MOHD ISRAR AHMAD permanently, for all, future purpose.

0040865526-9

I, Rajesh Jindal S/o Jagdish Prasad, R/o-Flat No. -120, Engineers Estate, I.P. Extension, Delhi-110092, have changed my name from Rajesh Jindal to Rajesh Kumar Agarwal, for all future purposes.

0040865570-2

I, SUBHASH CHAND TAWAR S/O LATE SH. SHISHPAL R/O VILLAGE ROHILAPUR SECTOR 132, NOIDA U.P. 201304, inform that in my service records my name has wrongly been mentioned as Subhash Chand instead SUBHASH CHAND TAWAR.

0040865570-2

I, Ravinder Kaur R/o C-483, DEFENCE COLONY, LAJPAT NAGAR, SOUTH DELHI, DELHI-110024, have changed my name after marriage and in future I may be known as RAVINDER KAUR BAWEJA for all purpose.

0040865431-1

I, hitherto known as MOHD JAMAL, S/o-MOHAMMAD FAROOQ, R/o-50-D, Sawmi Dayanand-Colony, Kishan Ganj, Delhi-110007, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as MOHAMMAD JAMAL.

0040865526-2

We are Sh.Piyush Goyal(Father)& Smt.Pooja Goyal(Mother), R/o-841, First Floor, Niti-Khand-1, Indrapuram, Ghaziabad, U.P.-201014, have changed our minor daughter name from ARADHYA GOEL to ARADHYA GOYAL, for all, future purposes.

0040865559-4

I, Varada V Lakshmi, D/o-Tirupathi Rao, W/o-Santhosh Kumar Varada, R/o-SMQ No.224/12, Air-Force Station Arjangarh, Aya-Nagar, New-Delhi-110047, have changed my name, from Varada V Lakshmi to Yannamsetti V Lakshmi, for all future, purposes vide-affidavit dated-27.06.2026, before the Natary-Public, Delhi

0040865570-4

I, Mrs Meena Sahni W/o Ashwani Sahni R/o B-15 Second Floor, Subhavana Niketan, Pitampura, Delhi, have changed my name to Meena Sahni permanently.

0040865424-1

I, IRRENDER OBEROI R/O RIPU DAMAN SINGH R/O KG-2142 Ground Floor, Vikaspuri, Delhi-110018, have changed my name to IRRENDER.

0040865548-1

I, Priyanka D/O Rajkumar Saini R/o A9 Ig Colony Kuwar Singh Nagar Nangloi Delhi 110041 have changed my name to Priyanka Saini.

0071047189-1

I, Ashish Kumar Mittal S/o Vinod Kumar Gupta R/o VIPP Homes, D-404, Tower D, Gaur City-2, Next to Gaur City-2, 14th Avenue, GC-3K, GH-3, Bishrakh, Gautam Buddha Nagar, Uttar Pradesh-201306 have changed my name from Ashish Kumar Mittal to Aashish Mittal for all future Purposes.

0071047119-1

I, Vipin Sharma, S/o Mahesh Kumar Sharma, R/o Post-Aulina, Aulina, Bulandshahr, U.P. have changed my name to Viraj Bhardwaj for all future purposes

0040865559-6

I, Prem Kumar Malik S/o Gordhan Dass Malik R/o 497, Dr Mukerjee Nagar, Delhi, have changed my name to Prem Malik permanently.

0040865424-3

I, ASHA CHAUHAN W/o Shri SATENDER SINGH R/O C-11, Development Enclave, Rao Tula Ram Marg, Behind Army Ho Camp, Delhi Cantt, Delhi-110010, inform that my name has been wrongly mentioned in my Husband's Service Record as ASHA instead of ASHA CHAUHAN.

0040865548-3

I, Ujjwal S/o Devender R/o T-52/60 East Mehram Nagar Delhi Cantt-110010 have changed my name to Ujjwal Jinghala.

0040865464-1

I, Mohammad Arsh, S/o Mr. Riazuddin, R/o C-21, Okhla Vihar, Jamia Nagar, Delhi-110025, have changed my name, from Mohammad Arsh to Mohd Arsh and declare that name of my mother has been wrongly written as Nazma in my passport, her actual and correct name is Nazma Bano, for all, future purposes.

0040865526-6

I, Vidhi Bharatkumar Godhani, W/o Bharat Malhotra, R/o-Flat-104, Plot-2/80, Sector-2, Rajender-Nagar, Sahibabad, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh-201005, have changed my name to Vidhi Malhotra.

0040865567-1

I, NEPURI DEVI, MOTHER OF, PRAVEEN KUMAR, ADDRESS-VILLAGE- DULARBIGHA, POST-RAMPURCHAY, THANA-DEOKUND, DIST-AURANGABAD, BIHAR-8044428, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME, FROM NEPURI DEVI TO NEPURAWA DEVI, VIA-AFFIDAVIT-11/07/2026

0040865570-8

I, Maya W/o Kuldeep Sagar, R/O-686 Sector-7-B, Faridabad, Haryana, have changed my name to Maya Sagar

0040865449-2

I, JAGBIR SINGH, S/O-SURAJ BHAN, R/O-116, VILL- IRADAT NAGAR ALIAS NAYA BANS, DELHI-110082, have changed my name to JAGBIR SINGH DHRUV.

0040865520-1

I, Guddo rani, D/O PRABHATI LAL RASTOGI, W/O SANJAY KUMAR RASTOGI, residing at, A-2, SURAJ APARTMENTS, TP SCHEME-9, REWARI, HARYANA-123401, have changed my name to PRIYANKA RASTOGI, for all future, purposes.

0040865559-1

I, ASHOK KUMAR S/O SHYAM SUNDER R/O HOUSE No. A-56, 100 FEET ROAD, CHAWLA COLONY, BALLABGARH, FARIDABAD, 121004 (H.R.) HAVE CHANGED MY NAME FROM ASHOK KUMAR TO ASHOK GUPTA FOR ALL FUTURE PURPOSES.

0071047186-1

I, Sheshman Yadav S/o Lallu R/o Makaan no 76/1, Hardoli Road, Bousadawa, Dondar, Rewa, Madhya Pradesh, 486556, have changed my minor son's name from Sonu Aged 16 Years to Rahul Yadav forever

0071047214-1

I, SALINA W/O AAS MOHAMMAD, R/O House no. 15, Gali no-1, Near-Road Wali Masjid, Pasoda, Paswada, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh-201005, Has changed my name to SARINA, for all, future purpose.

0040865526-8

I, INDERJEET KAUR, W/o-Late Inderjeet Singh R/o RL-21, Gangra Ram Vatika, Tilak Nagar, New Delhi-110018, have changed my name to HARPREET KAUR.

0040865570-1

I, Parveen Basra, S/o-Janak Singh, R/o U-28 A, U-block Vishwas-park Uttam-nagar, D.K Mohan-park, Delhi-110059, have change my name to Parveen Kumar, for all future, purchases.

0040865570-10

I, Kajal D/O Ospal Singh Chouhan, R/O 5/261, Trilok Puri Esat Delhi-110096, Have Changed My Name To Kajal Chouhan For All Purposes

0040865570-6

I, JYOTI W/o SH. MAYANK GAUTAM R/O A-130, MAJLIS PARK, ADARSH NAGAR, DELHI-110033, (UID No-908226943004) do solemnly and sincerely declare as follows: That I hitherto known as JYOTI have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as JYOTI GAUTAM.

0040865467-1

I, hitherto known as MOHD JAMAL, S/o-MOHAMMAD FAROOQ, R/o-50-D, Sawmi Dayanand-Colony, Kishan Ganj, Delhi-110007, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as MOHAMMAD JAMAL.

0040865526-11

I, MOHD SHARIQ AZAD, S/O, MOHAMMAD RASHID AZAD, R/O, 7938, Rajee Baba Road Azad Menshon, Bulandshahr, UTTAR PRADESH-203001, I have changed my name to MOHAMMAD SHARIQ AZAD.

0040865559-3

I, Neetu Jindal, W/o Rajesh Kumar Agarwal, R/o Flat No. -120, Engineers-Estate, I.P. Extension, Delhi-110092, have changed my name, from Neetu Jindal to Anita Jindal, for all, future purposes.

0040865570-3

I Sourabh S/O Inderpal R/O 17/32 Ground floor, Subhash Nager, Rajouri Garden, Delhi-110027 Have Changed My Name Sourabh To Sourabh Sahdev Permanently.

0040865468-1

I, Hunny, S/O Satendra Yadav, R/O-281/D-2, Ward No-2, Mehrauli, South, Delhi Mehrauli, Delhi-110030, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME AND SHALL HEREFTER BE KNOWN AS Hunny Yadav.

0040865526-10

I, PARTEEK S/O RAKESH ARORA, HOUSE No.-119, PHASE-2, VIRAT NAGAR, MODEL TOWN, PANIPAT-132013 (HARYANA) HAVE CHANGE MY NAME TO PARTEEK ARORA PERMANENTLY.

0040865570-11

I, AVINASHI KAUR R/O C-483, DEFENCE COLONY, LAJPAT NAGAR, SOUTH DELHI, DELHI-110024, have changed my name after marriage and In future I may be known as AVINASH KAUR BAWEJA for all purpose.

0040865431-3

I, Ashish Kishore, S/o Lt. Jugal Kishore Sonkar, R/o-99/1, Gali Dak Khana, Subzi Minadi, Delhi-110007, Changed my name to Ashish Kishore Sonkar.

0040865526-3

We are Sh. Piyush Goyal (Father) & Smt. Pooja Goyal (Mother), R/o-841, First Floor, Niti-Khand-1, Indrapuram, Ghaziabad, U.P.-201014, have changed our minor daughter name, from MANYATA GOEL to MANYATA GOYAL, for all, future purposes.

0040865559-5

I, Devinder Goel, S/o Laxmi Narayan, R/o RZ-21/222, J-Block Dayal Park Gali No.61, West Sagarpur, New Delhi-110046, have changed my name to Devender Kumar

0040865570-5

I, Sujet Kumar Verma s/o Late Sh. Girdhar Prasad R/O RZF-394/1, Guru Nanak Marg, Raj Nagar-II, Palam colony, New Delhi-110077 have changed my son's name from Shourya to Shourya Verma for all future purpose. Both names Shourya and Shourya Verma belongs to same person.

0040865548-2

I, Ruby Aggarwal, W/o Parveen Aggarwal, R/o E101, JM Arora, Ecocity, Sector-75, Noida-201301, have changed my name to RUBY JAIN for all future purposes.

0071047125-1

I, Payal Guglani w/o Sidharth Khandelwal, R/o D-174, 3 rd Floor, Rishi Nagar, Rani Bagh, Delhi-110034 have changed my name from Payal Guglani to Payal Khandelwal for all future purposes.

0040865462-1

I, MOHD SHANNAWAZ ALAM, S/O MD BASIR R/O-5525 GALI NO.5, NEW CHANDRAWAL MALKA GANJ DELHI-110007, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO MD SHANNAWAZ ALAM

0040865526-5

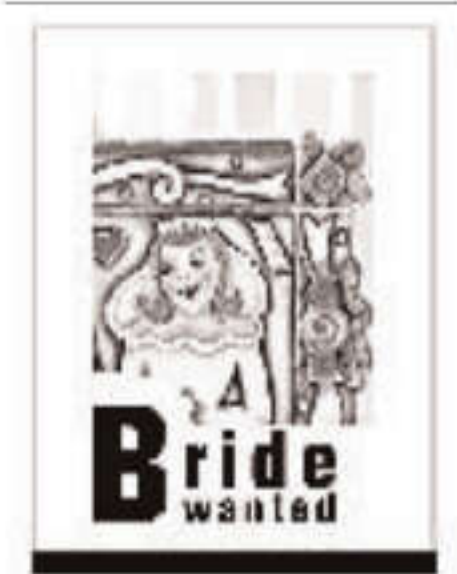
I, Varisha Javed, W/o-Mohammad Javed, R/O-WS-117, Gali No.7, Sudamapuri, Babarpur, Shahdara, Delhi-110032, have changed my minor daughter's name namely Alina to Aailma Javed.

0040865559-7

I, Kamla Kumari W/o Rishi Raj R/o H.NO-207, Tajpur Kalan, Delhi -110036, have changed my name to Kamla Devi permanently.

0040865424-2

MATRIMONIAL



BRAHMIN

A well educated God Brahmin girl /Lecturer /Assistant Professor required for a handsome well educated LLB, LL.M, well established boy, doing his own business, Aug 1991 born, GGN based, Contact no.9810600233 email rsvenus99@gmail.com

0040862974-3

GENERAL

Alliance for our son, 33 years, Ghaziabad, 5'-9", B.Tech, MBA, associate manager in Delhi, Hindu, Kayasth, Bride from a decent kayasth family, around 29 years. Contact 9318302530, shriaks61@gmail.com

0050292995-1

REQUIRE Vegetarian Girl in USA/ India ready to relocate to Sanjose for Bachelor Boy 1987 July 6'1", MS, on I-140. Contact: 9930020727.

0071047117-1

SIKH/PUNJABI

Suitable Match for Handsome Khatri Sikh Australian , Clean Shave Boy, Age- 37 Height- 6'2", Never married, Handsome salary, Health Professional in Australia, Only son, Cost no bar, Well-settled Family, Send Bio data with Photo on Whatsapp Number- 8264713990

0020516422-1

PUBLIC NOTICE

General public is hereby inform that my client Sh. Dinesh Khandelwal R/o 195A, Ekta Apartment, A2B Block, Puchon Vihar, Delhi, have served all their relations with their son Sh. Vishant Khandelwal and his wife Sh. Divisha Khandelwal for all future matters. My above named client have also disown/denied his said son and daughter in-law from all their movable immovable properties. Any person dealing with Sh. Vishant Khandelwal and Smt. Divisha Khandelwal will do so at his/her own risk and responsibility, and my client will not be responsible for any act/deed or dealing done by Sh. Vishant Khandelwal and his wife Smt. Divisha Khandelwal.

Sd/-

RICHIA RABBAR Advocate P-1 Post Office Lakh, Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi-110054

PUBLIC NOTICE

GENERAL PUBLIC IS HEREBY INFORMED THAT RENU SACHDEVIA W/O LATE SH. KUMAR SACHDEVIA R/O 7623-10, NEAR HARI MANDIR, AZAD PUR, DELHI-33, HERE BY REVOKE AND WITHDRAW THE DEBARMENT / DISOWNING NOTICE SUBMITTED AGAINST MY YOUNGEST SON PUNIT SACHDEVIA AND HIS WIFE ANCHAL KANWIA SACHDEVIA IN A NEWSPAPER JANSANKA IN HINDI AND IN INDIAN EXPRESS IN ENGLISH IN DATED 10/04/2025. THE SAID NOTICE AGAINST BOTH OF THEM STAND CANCELLED WITH IMMEDIATE EFFECT.

Sd/-

MANISH DHAWAN Advocate Enrol. No. DMBS/2019 OFFICE NO-41 FIRST FLOOR, CSC-9 DDA MARKET SECTOR 16, ROHINI, DELHI

To be known to all that I Ritikh Gupta S/o Sh. Rajeev Kumar R/o B-563, Gali No.1, Majlis Park, Delhi-33, hereby declare that I have lost two original documents i.e. 1. Sale Deed executed between Cheep Housing Co. and Sh. Lal Singh, Dt.06.04.1957, i.e. Power of Attorney executed between Smt. R. Purn Singh, Dt. 19.10.1959, in respect of Property No.B-230, Gali No.2, Majlis Park, Delhi-33. An FIR/NCR vide L.R No.406064/2026, on this effect has been lodged online. Any person (s) claiming any right, interest having any objection or found in possession of original documents, may right, contact with above named person, at above address/Mobile No.8586907317, within 04 days from the date of the publication of this notice.

DINESH JAIN (ADVOCATE)

Enroll. No.UPO4527/10 Office -B-294, Gali No.3, Majlis Park, Adarsh Nagar, Delhi-110033 Phone 971161584

COURT NOTICE

IN THE COURT OF THE SPL DIST JUDGE (MACT) KRISHNAGIRI M.C.O.P.NO. 10/2025 R.Aruna W/o Late Suresh D.No-199/1, Anekal Road, Near Samudaya Bavan, Jagga Jeevan Ram Nagar, Attibele Post, Anwar Taluk, Bangalore Dist, Karnataka and OthersPetitioners /Versus/ Jupiter Express Carrier Private Limited, Shop No-93, Sanjay Gandhi, Transport Nagar, Narela, North-West Delhi - 1100421st Respondent Please take Notice that the above petitioners have filed the above case against you for the death of their V.Suresh S/o Venkatesh by them in a RTA. You are the owner of the TATA Container Lorry Bearing Reg No. RJ-11-GC-4181. The above case is posted for your appearance on 11-09-2026 at about 10.30 AM in the above Court, you have to appear in person or through your Advocate, failing which the above matter will be decided ex parte. By Court Order G. Veeraraghavan, Bsc., B.L. Advocate-6th Cross, Rajaji Nagar, Opp. Mecca Masjid KRISHNAGIRI - 635 002Roll No: Ms: 689/1990, Cell: 9443236372

COURT NOTICE

IN THE COURT OF THE SPL DIST JUDGE (MACT) KRISHNAGIRI M.C.O.P.NO. 10/2025 R.Aruna W/o Late Suresh D.No-199/1, Anekal Road, Near Samudaya Bavan, Jagga Jeevan Ram Nagar, Attibele Post, Anwar Taluk, Bangalore Dist, Karnataka and OthersPetitioners /Versus/ Jupiter Express Carrier Private Limited, Shop No-93, Sanjay Gandhi, Transport Nagar, Narela, North-West Delhi - 1100421st Respondent Please take Notice that the above petitioners have filed the above case against you for the death of their V.Suresh S/o Venkatesh by them in a RTA. You are the owner of the TATA Container Lorry Bearing Reg No. RJ-11-GC-4181. The above case is posted for your appearance on 11-09-2026 at about 10.30 AM in the above Court, you have to appear in person or through your Advocate, failing which the above matter will be decided ex parte. By Court Order G. Veeraraghavan, Bsc., B.L. Advocate-6th Cross, Rajaji Nagar, Opp. Mecca Masjid KRISHNAGIRI - 635 002Roll No: Ms: 689/1990, Cell: 9443236372

NORTH WESTERN RAILWAY

E-TENDER NOTICE DR.M(S&T) NWR, Ajmer on behalf of The President of India invites E-Tender for the following work up to 15.00 Hrs. on the mentioned date. Tender No.: 1, DR.M-S&T-29-2026-27 2. DR.M-S&T-30-2026-27; Name of Work: 1. Ajmer Division: Provision of signalling Associated work in C/W Ajmer extension of platform no. 2/3 and 4/5 of Ajmer Division NWR. 2. Ajmer Division: - Shifting of S&T cables and utilities in c/w Extension of DFC Side pedestrian subway at Haripur, Sojat Road and Marwar Jn. railway station of Ajmer division NWR. Approximate cost of work: 1. Rs. 3008169.61, 2. Rs. 3574536.58; Bid security: 1. Rs. 60200.00, 2. Rs. 71500.00; Date & Time of opening E-Tender - 04.08.2026 at 15.30 Hrs. The details of above E-Tender are available on website www.irops.gov.in 984-PH/26

Follow us on NWR Railways NWR Railways

NORTH WESTERN RAILWAY

OPEN TENDER THROUGH E-TENDERING 2026-27 NIT No: 08-LWS-OPN-VTL-2026 Date: 08.07.2026

For and on behalf of The President of India, Dy. CME/Loco Ajmer invites e-tender with following details, interested firms/tenderer may participate through IREPS portal in this e-tender. Name of work: Work of One-Time repair and Comprehensive Annual Maintenance Contract (CA/MC) for CNC Vertical turn lathe machine (M&P No. - B3/05) (Make-HYT) at Diesel Loco and Wagon Workshop Ajmer for 02 years (As Per Scope of Work). Estimated cost of work: Rs. 38.82,200/- (Rs. Thirty-Eight Lakh Eighty-Two Thousand Two hundred only). Address of the NIT issuing office: Dy. Chief Mechanical Engineer (Loco) Diesel Loco & Wagon Workshop Lal Phatak, Ajmer (Raj.)-305001, Earnest money to be deposited: Rs.77,700/- (Only through net banking or payment gateway on IREPS portal). Last Date and time for submission and opening of E-tender: 30.07.2026 up to 15.00. E-Tender will be opened at 15.30 on same day. Due to indispensable reasons bid opening schedule may change. Website particular where complete details of e-tender can be seen and participated: www.irops.gov.in (Note- This is E-tender so tenderer can participate through e-tendering process only on mentioned website within bidding period). 989-PH/26

Follow us on NWR Railways NWR Railways

Call or WhatsApp 9717006820 to advertise on classified page

The Indian EXPRESS

NORTH WESTERN RAILWAY

E-TENDER NOTICE Dy.CEE(W), NWR, Ajmer on behalf of The President of India invites E-Tender for the following work up to 15.00Hrs. on the mention date. Tender No.: EL/50/09/2026-27, Name of work: Replacement of Transformers and balance LT Panels of Ajmer Group of Workshop on age-cum-condition basis. Approximate cost: Rs. 4284213.85/-, Earnest money: Rs.85700/-, Date & Time of closing of E-Tender: 29-07-2026 at 15-00 Hrs. Date & Time of opening of E-Tender: 29-07-2026 at 15-30 Hrs. The details of above E-Tender is available on website: www.irops.gov.in 990-PH/26

Follow us on NWR Railways NWR Railways

NORTHERN RAILWAY

RE-ENGAGEMENT NOTICE No. 844-E/Genl.Matter/Re-engagement/Retd. Officers/ EIA/32 Dt. 10.07.2026 Applications are invited from willing Retired Group '

BRIDGE

Dealer: South Vulnerable: None

NORTH		SOUTH	
♠ 52		♠ A K Q J 10 3	
♥ K 8 6 4		♥ A	
♦ 4 3 2		♦ A K 7 6 5	
♣ K Q 8 6		♣ A	
SOUTH	WEST	NORTH	EAST
2♣	pass	2NT	pass
3♣	pass	3NT	pass
4♦	pass	4♣	pass
6♣	pass	pass	pass

West leads the ten of clubs. Plan the play.

THE WEST HAND

♠ 7 6 4 ♥ 1 9 7 5 3 2 ♦ 10 ♣ 10 9 5

THE EAST HAND

♠ 9 8 ♥ Q 10 ♦ Q J 9 8 ♣ J 7 4 3 2

South should win the opening lead and play high trumps until there is exactly one trump outstanding. He should then cash the heart ace and play the ace-king of diamonds.

If a diamond honour is ruffed, the opponent who wins the trick will be end played and forced to give dummy three winners. If diamonds break 3-2, declarer draws the last trump, gives up a diamond, and takes the rest. If diamonds break 4-1 or 5-0 and no diamond honour is ruffed, South should lead his spade three, hoping that the opponent with the long trump has no more diamonds.

Dealer: North Vulnerable: East/West

NORTH		SOUTH	
♠ Q 5 3 2		♠ J 9	
♥ J		♥ A Q 8 2	
♦ A K J 9		♦ 7 4 3 2	
♣ A J 7 5		♣ K Q 3	
SOUTH	WEST	NORTH	EAST
-	-	1♦	pass
1♥	pass	1♣	pass
2NT	pass	3NT	pass
pass	pass		

West leads the seven of spades to East's ace. East returns the four of spades to West's king. West continues with the spade ten; East discards the three of hearts. Plan the play.

JUMBLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

_____ is the foundational key to all success. -Pablo Picasso (6)

IPTAO

DGHIIN

TUBIR

AIRVC

ANSWER: Action is the foundational key to all success. - Pablo Picasso

SALUTE THE SOLDIER



CENTRAL RESERVE POLICE FORCE

13 BN

Veer Balidani Constable

Swaran Singh

Veer Balidani Inspector Nand Ram, Veer Balidani Sub Inspector Sher Singh Bala, Veer Balidani Lance Naik Harkavir Rai (1-1-1937 To 12-7-1967), Veer Balidani Constable Jaman Singh (16-12-1943 To 12-7-1967), Veer Balidani Constable Nagar Chand (15-6-1944 To 12-7-1967), Veer Balidani Naik Surjan Singh, Veer Balidani Constable Sher Singh, Veer Balidani Constable Chhajju Ram (12-3-1944 To 12-7-1967),Veer Balidani Constable Kaka Singh (15-1-1945 To 12-7-1967), Veer Balidani Constable Bakshi Ram (16-12-1940 To 12-7-1967), Veer Balidani Constable Kabal Singh (6-3-1944 To 12-7-1967), Veer Balidani Constable Telu Ram,Veer Balidani Constable Arjun Singh, Veer Balidani Constable Bishamber Das, Veer Balidani Constable Prem Singh (12-11-1945 To 12-7-1967), Veer Balidani Constable/Washerman Mangal Singh, Veer Balidani Constable Chhavi Lal (16-12-1947 To 12-7-1967), Veer Balidani Constable J. Sunder Rajee (21-8-1943 To 12-7-1967)

DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to 19 valiant troopers of 13 BN, who made the supreme sacrifice while bravely combating insurgents during an ambush in Manipur on 12 July 1967. CRPF salutes the bravehearts and pledges never to let their sacrifice go in vain.



Veer Balidani Sub Inspector Hardayal Singh

1 Bn

12-8-1938 To 12-7-1967



Veer Balidani Head Constable/ Radio Mechanic Chhailbihari

1 Bn

11-1-1938 To 12-7-1967



Veer Balidani Head Constable/ Radio Fitter Som Nath

1 Bn

15-2-1934 To 12-7-1967

1 Battalion of CRPF was deployed in present-day Manipur (then part of Assam) to maintain law and order and counter the ongoing insurgency. On 12 July 1967, while out on duty, the troops were ambushed by the militants. They responded with valiant resistance. In the encounter, Sub Inspector Hardayal Singh, Head Constable (Radio Mechanic) Chhailbihari, and Head Constable (Radio Fitter) Som Nath made the supreme sacrifice in the line of duty.



Veer Balidani Head Constable Amir Hussain

124 Bn

2-2-1963 To 12-7-2001



Veer Balidani Constable/Driver Lakhbir Singh

124 Bn

7-7-1974 To 12-7-2001

DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to Head Constable Amir Hussain and Constable/Driver Lakhbir Singh of 124 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice while bravely combating insurgents during an ambush in Tirap district, Arunachal Pradesh on 12 July 2001. CRPF salutes the bravehearts and pledges never to let their sacrifice go in vain.



Veer Balidani Lance Naik Sada Ram

62 Bn

16-11-1953 To 12-7-1990

DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to Lance Naik Sada Ram of 62 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice in a cowardly attack by militants during naka duty in Firozpur district, Punjab on 12 July 1990. CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.



Veer Balidani Lance Naik Hamath Meena

53 Bn

15-9-1959 To 12-7-1992

DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to Lance Naik Hamath Meena of 53 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice after being grievously injured in a grenade attack by militants in Verinag, Anantnag, Jammu & Kashmir on 12 July 1992. CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.

SUNDAY CROSSWORD

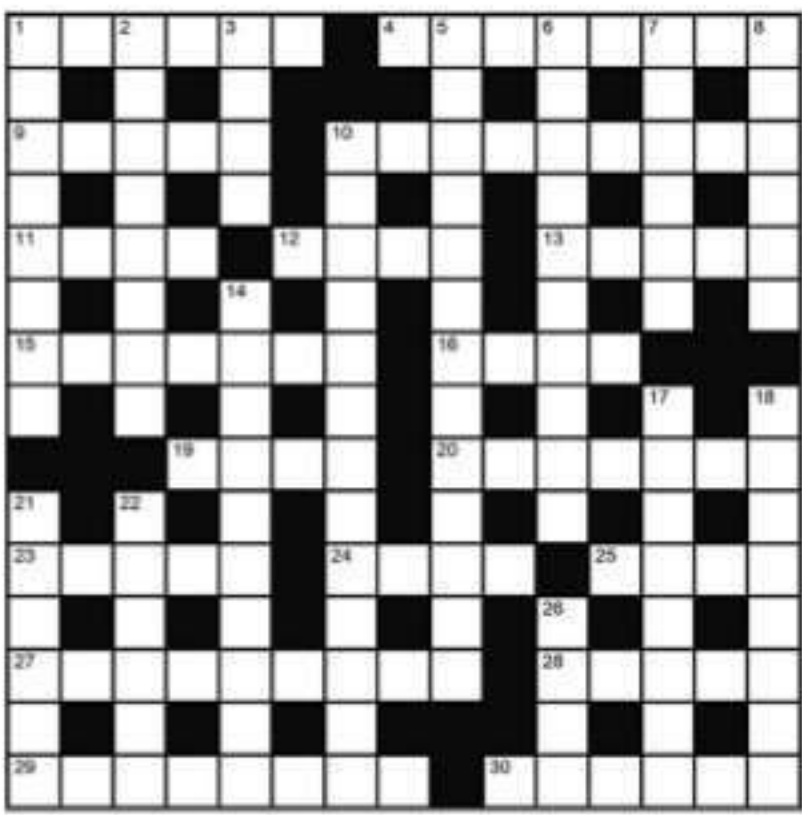
QUICK CLUES

ACROSS

- 1. Touching (6)
- 4. Resist change (5,3)
- 9. Himalayan country (5)
- 10. Seventy two hours ? (5,4)
- 11. Not often seen (4)
- 12. Parody (4)
- 13. Cricket stroke (5)
- 15. Executioner (7)
- 16. Urban area (4)
- 19. Untie (4)
- 20. Capital of Israel (3,4)
- 23. Military blockade (5)
- 24. Summit (4)
- 25. Skin blemish (4)
- 27. Study of sound (9)
- 28. Bhubaneswar lingo (5)
- 29. Accented (8)
- 30. Popular search engine (6)

DOWN

- 1. Kingship (8)
- 2. Venomous (8)
- 3. _____ and void ? (4)
- 5. Ripped into rags (4,2,7)
- 6. Good-for-nothing (4-2-4)
- 7. Peaceful (6)
- 8. Throws (6)
- 10. Duped or fooled; gyped (5,3,1,4)
- 14. Secretary (10)
- 17. Expelling from property (8)
- 18. Conquered (8)
- 21. Compositions (6)
- 22. Gobble up greedily (6)
- 26. Singer Perry (4)



CRYPTIC CLUES

ACROSS

- 1. The sort of fastener to wrap ? (6)
- 4. Bulky girdles (ick!) are glaringly obvious (5,3)
- 9. General's upsetting leer masks a trace of enigma (1,1,3)
- 10. For no reward, he drew young children (4,5)
- 11. Pushed back, not half banging nose! (4)
- 12. One wet place coming up in the desert (4)
- 13. Can, for example, turn up colour slightly (5)
- 15. Nothing's French in the identity of The

- Snow Goose author (7)
- 16. Have troubles in adjusting sail (4)
- 19. The man who got locked in the bank vault? (4)
- 20. Stops arrests ? (7)
- 23. Honour the Left and one looks daggers ! (5)
- 24. Its food has calcium and iron (4)
- 25. Thought to be not quite perfect (4)
- 27. Giant car rental company with a great deal of frequency on radio (9)
- 28. Pancake student found in receptacle number one (5)
- 29. Not a good excuse,

SOLUTIONS TO 2589 **QUICK CLUES ACROSS:** 1 Happen, 4 Editions, 10 Threatens, 11 Redid, 12 Ruins, 13 Thesaurus, 14 Chanced, 16 Tulu, 19 Imam, 21 Conceal, 24 Esperanto, 25 Berry, 26 Liked, 27 Checkmate, 28 Mastered, 29 Addons **DOWN:** 1 Hat-trick, 2 Partisan, 3 Exams, 5 Descent, 6 Tarpaulin, 7 Orders, 8 Sadism, 9 Bested, 15 Cambridge, 17 Years ago, 18 Playpens, 20 Monocle, 21 Cloned, 22 Vellum, 23 Spikes, 25 Baked **CRYPTIC CLUES ACROSS:** 1 Docile, 4 Barrages, 10 Garibaldi, 11 Inure, 12 Ellis, 13 Pied piper, 14 Discern, 16 Do ok, 19 It is, 21 De falla, 24 Moonlight, 25 Weald, 26 Stasi, 27 Obviating, 28 Shrugged, 29 Reread **DOWN:** 1 Dog leads, 2 Cordless, 3 Lobes, 5 Aniseed, 6 Rain proof, 7 Grumpy, 8 Shears, 9 Slip-on, 15 Extolling, 17 Flea-bite, 18 Bandaged, 20 Signore, 21 Dative, 22 Amuses, 23 Hot air, 25 Weave

SUDOKU 6377

DIFFICULTY LEVEL 55

INSTRUCTIONS

To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL

1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy; 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard; 5s = Very Hard; 6s = Genius

5					4
2	4			5	1
	3		1	6	
4	7	6		5	
1	8	2	6		
	7	2	3		
3	1		9	5	
6				2	

SOLUTION SUDOKU 6376

5	7	1	8	2	4	3	6	9
9	4	3	1	6	7	8	2	5
8	2	6	9	3	5	7	4	1
7	3	4	6	8	9	5	1	2
6	1	8	5	4	2	9	7	3
2	5	9	7	1	3	6	8	4
3	6	7	2	9	1	4	5	8
1	9	5	4	7	8	2	3	6
4	8	2	3	5	6	1	9	7

NORTH WESTERN RAILWAY

NOTICE FOR FRESH / RENEWAL OF REGISTRATIONS OF FIRMS FOR NON-MEDICINE ITEMS

(For supplying of Surgical Disposables, Consumables, Pathology Items, Ophthalmology Items, Hospital Furniture etc.

Interested Manufacturing/Marketing firms / authorized stockist or dealers/importers of non-Medicine medical stores (hereinafter called the firms) are invited to register/renew their registration with North Western Railway for supplying Surgical Instruments, Dental Instruments, Consumables, Disposables, Hospital Equipment, Ophthalmology instruments, Radiology items, Anesthesia items, Medical Cases, Sterile Surgical gloves, sutures & Meshes, Intra-Ocular Lens, Pathology Reagents & Chemicals, Tools & Plants items, Hospital furniture, Physiotherapy items, Glucometer & strips, Hospital Disinfectant & other miscellaneous items used in hospitals as per Indian Railway Medical drug procurement policy part-II.

Complete application with a self-attested documents in sealed envelope is to be sent to "Principal Chief Medical Director, Room No. 043, Ground Floor, North Western Railway HQ office, Jagatpura Road, Near Jawahar Circle, Jaipur-302017" so as to reach latest by 17.00 hrs. on 10.08.2026 through Speed Post, Registered Post or personally. The envelope should be marked with superscription "Application for supplying Surgical Disposables, Consumables, Pathology Items, Ophthalmology items, Hospital furniture etc. over North Central Railway."

Information in detail with terms and conditions and application form can be downloaded from website <http://www.nwr.indianrailways.gov.in> and the same can also be obtained from the office of Principal Chief Medical Director, Room No. 043, Ground Floor, North Western Railway HQ office, Jagatpur Road, Near Jawahar Circle, Jaipur-302017 during working hours. (Note: From this adv. Onward the process of registration/renewal will be on regular basis).

OFFICE OF THE PRINCIPAL, GOVT. COLLEGE FOR WOMEN, PALI

Dated: 09.07.2026

Canteen Tender Notice

Sealed bids are invited by the undersigned from experienced and Competent Contractors/firms/SHGs having valid licence and requisite credentials for providing Canteen Services and also having a minimum experience of 1 year in running the canteen service in Govt. Organisation/ academic institutions/ MNCs and etc., in sealed covers.

Time Schedule of Bidding Process

Date of publication of tender notice on official wesite	10.7.2026
Commencing date of tender	13.7.2026
Last date for receipt of filled in tender document	21.7.2026
Date and time of opening of technical bid	23.7.2026

Sd/-

Principal

Governemnt College for Women

Pali

No. 47091/HRY

SOUTH EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-TENDER NOTICE

Sr. Divisional Engineer (Co) / S.E.C.Railway, Nagpur acting for and on behalf of President of India invites E-Tender for execution of work mentioned below:-

Sl. No.	Name of the work	Tender Notice No.	Approx. Tender Value (₹)	Earnerst Money (₹)
1.	(1) Execution of Civil Zonal work (including white washing/Colour washing/Painting and repairs to road work) for the period ending upto 30.06.2027 in the section Gondia to Lamta (In), Balaghat to Katangi branch line under the jurisdiction of ADEN/Naipnur. & (2) Execution of Civil Zonal work (including white washing/Colour washing/ Painting and repairs to road work)/for the period ending upto 30.06.2027 in the section Lamta (Ex) to Kachhpura, Naipnur to Mandla Fort branch line under the jurisdiction of ADEN/Naipnur.	N-24-NAG-2026-2027	1,73,75,000/-	3,47,500/-
2.	(1) Miscellaneous P.Way work for maintenance of track under SSE(P.Way)/Sausar for the period of 12 months under the jurisdiction of ADEN/CWA.	N-25-NAG-2026-2027	1,32,93,246/-	2,65,900/-
3.	Miscellaneous P.Way work for maintenance of track under SSE(P.Way)/Balaghat in the section of ADEN/NIR for the period of 12 months.	N-26-NAG-2026-2027	1,09,16,496/-	2,18,300/-

For the above tenders the Bidders will be able to submit their original / revised bids up to 15.00 Hours on 31.07.2026 only. Manual offers are not allowed against these tenders and any such manual offers received shall be rejected. Details are available on our website : www.ireps.gov.in.

PAM/20/40 S. Divl. Engineer (North)/S.E.C.Railway/Nagpur f South East Central Railway @secrail

ARTIFICIAL LIMBS MANUFACTURING CORPORATION OF INDIA

(A Govt. of India Undertaking)
G.T. Road, Kanpur-209217
Visit us: www.alimco.in
Phone- 0512-2770176, Fax- 0512-2770617
TOLLFREE NO. 18001805129

OPEN TENDER NOTICE

Online Bids (Technical & Price Bid) are invited as per details indicated below:

Gem bid number	Category of Items	Approx. Value	Due Date of Opening
GEM/ 2026/B/ 7768139	"Work contract to manufacture Orthotic Items for a period of 5 years (3 years initially & extendable by 1 year + 1 year) including sourcing, procurement, QC/QA, inventory management, maintenance/ upkeep of plant & machineries, packaging etc. at ALIMCO Tikamgarh."	Rs. 39,23,00,000/- (including GST)	31.07.2026

Interested Tenderers may download the tender document from ALIMCO website www.alimco.in (for reference only) and GeM portal.

Tenderers are requested to submit their Offers/Bids through E- Tendering Process only on GeM portal. The Technical Bid will be Opened on as indicated above. ALIMCO reserves the right to reject any or all requests/Offer without assigning any reason.

Note: For any corrigendum in the tender, Tenderers may please visit GeM portal and ALIMCO web-site. For ALIMCO DGM (Projects)

ਪੰਜਾਬ ਨੈਸ਼ਨਲ ਬੈਂਕ

... बरोसे का प्रतीक

punjab national bank

...the name you can BANK upon!

KUMS, Majhola Moradabad

POSSESSION NOTICE [Under Rule 8(1) of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002]

Whereas, The undersigned being the Authorised officer of the PUNJAB NATIONAL BANK, under Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 (Act No. 54 of 2002) and in exercise of powers conferred under section 13(12) read with Rule-3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 issued demand notice on the date mentioned against account and stated herein calling upon them to repay the amount within 60 days from the date of receipt of said notice. The borrower having failed to repay the amount, notice is hereby given to the borrower/ guarantor and the public in general that the undersigned has taken possession of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on him/her under section 13(4) of the said Act read with rule 8 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002. The borrower/guarantor in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with the properties and any dealings with the property will be subject to the charge of the **PUNJAB NATIONAL BANK**, for the amounts and interest thereon. The borrowers attentions is invited to provisions of sub-section (8) of section 13 of the act, in respect of time available to redeem the secured asset, Details of properties where possession had been taken is as follows:

Sl. No.	Name of Borrower/Guarantor/ Mortgagor/ Name	Description of Securities	Demand notice Date		Outstanding Amount as per Demand Notice
			Possession Date		
1.	Borrower/Mortgagor: Neeraj Kumar S/o Shri Jagdish Singh, A/c No. 42900NC00003270.	All that Part & Parcel of Property situated at: Gata No. 2707, Mauza, Lakri Fazalpur, Tehsil & Distt. Moradabad (U.P.), Registered in Bahi No. 01, Zild No. 19280, Page No. 337 to 350, Si No. 2824, Dated- 16.02.2024, Registered at SRO Ist Moradabad, Total Area- 43.06 sq. mtr, Standing in the name of Neeraj Kumar S/o Shri Jagdish Singh. Bounded as:- East: House of Mahendra, West: Aarazi Jagdish, North: Rasta 9 ft Wide, South: House of Kalicharan.	15.04.2026	06.07.2026	Rs. 10,14,968.01 as on 31.03.2026 + with future interest and incidental plus other charges w.e.f. 01.04.2026

Date: 11.07.2026

Place: Moradabad

Authorised Officer, Punjab National Bank



Sandip G
New Jersey, July 11

EVERYTHING IS akin to a bullfight to Spain's manager Luis de la Fuente. He calls himself a taurino — a bullfighting tragic. Every year, he makes it to the annual bullfighting fare in Plaza de Toros de Las Ventas, the deathly sport's cathedral. When he was appointed as La Roja's manager three years ago, he thought, "well, this is a big bull."

Four years later, a European Championship, and an entry to the World Cup semifinal, Spain's first since its triumph in 2010, he has been akin to a seasoned matador that grabbed every bull by its horn.

Every victory of Spain in the knockout has been like a bullfight without bloodshed. Like the men in spangly suits move, Spain's men take their combatants around the ring, weaving and spinning away from their rage, tiring them out, weakening them with their aggressive pressing and mixing up of passes, before pinning them to submission.

If the 2010 winners were the manifestation of a profound but unsustainable philosophy, de la Fuente's group is a triumph of tactical flexibility, strategies he moulds like wax, hinging on the personnel at his disposal, their form, the fitness, their opponents, the strengths and weaknesses. He is not an ideologue, but more like a self-punishing philosopher who is unafraid to rebel against his own ideas, tweak, tinker and polish.

For the Belgium quarterfinal — the 2-1 victory was not a stroll, but not a trek either — he dropped Pedri, his midfield cornerstone and a highly technical operator.

He drafted Fabian Ruiz, an exquisite footballer himself, but brings more physical presence and a more direct goal-scoring threat. Belgium, he knew, were susceptible to heavy pressing and the buzzing Ruiz exploited it. Numerous times did Belgium lose their possession during transition because of Ruiz. He scored the opening goal, lashing onto a rebound. It's not the position that Pedri would naturally occupy, because he is schooled in the Barcelona tradition of conducting the game from deeper position and creating a midfield overload. Ruiz, sculpted in PSG's ideals, provided the positional fluidity that had Belgium midfielders running in sixes and sevens.

But after Belgium equalised and the midfield domination started to drift, with Ruiz himself looking ragged, he switched him with Pedri.

He immediately brought control. Spain's midfield narrowed, the wide-men began to knife inside, the backline drew a higher line, and the game clustered to an ovalish patch near Belgium's goalmouth. Spain unlocked their medley of one-touch passing, drawing triangles and squares, and not letting Belgium get a sniff of the ball. The rare Belgium advances hit the red wall and re-



La Roja engine chugging along beautifully

Coach Luis de la Fuente's tactical switches shone again in Spain's defeat of Belgium in the quarterfinals

Merino celebrates after scoring the winner in the 88th minute. (Below) Coach de la Fuente. AP

bounded. Spain were attacking, yet defending; Spain were defending yet attacking. It's this prolific balance that has been the essence of Spain's renaissance under de la Fuente. Dani Olmo described it in simple words: "All 11 attack; all 11 defend."

A defender, Pau Cubarsi attacked, his pile-driver from 30 yards forced the save from Semme Lammens that Mikel Merino latched on. Cubarsi brings the ball out, he filters passes, and is not shy to have a go at goal.

In some ways, his team resembles an incongruous hotchpotch of footballers from varied schools of Spanish football. Mikel Oyarzabal, the centre-forward-designate is neither a classical target-man nor a false nine.

He is not supersonic, modest in air, but has the tactical intelligence to sneak through defences and the ability to wander unnoticed. "Oyarzabal is a very intelligent person," De la Fuente said, when asked about the player's qualities. "You see that in his play, with his intelligence, and his interpretation of the game. He's one of the best players behind the lines."

The three behind him are as diverse as they could be. Dani Olmo is the playmaker, more in the neo-classical mode than the old-fashioned way. Alex Baena is more of an inside forward and Lamine Yamal the modern winger who could tear up the flanks as well as switch the wings. He relished arguably his best day in the tournament, but not yet scaled the nauseating pitches of the Euro. His form and Nico Williams's fitness forced the manager to shed the verticality and directness Spain showed in Euro. Williams had a cameo from the bench, and if both he and Yamal dust up the Euro touch, he could switch back to wider structures. To complement the Rolls Royce centre-backs, he has two bulldozers as full-backs.

It's the magnificent versatility of his sides. De la Fuente could base his team on midfield, in the fine Spanish tradition; he could make wingers his central plot device; he could pivot his team on his backline, and yet produce fascinating football. The key character he looks for in players is not only his technical ability, but their emotional intelligence.

"A footballer is not just a footballer because of his quality. Young players wouldn't be as good if they didn't have an emotional control of the situation; that's what truly makes the difference."

LUIS DE LA FUENTE, SPAIN COACH

E. EXPLAINED

Player fatigue is a factor in more late goals than before

Mikel Merino's winner against Belgium took the tally of goals scored from the 80th minute onwards at this World Cup to 69 — that is, 24.2% of the total goals. The corresponding figure at Qatar '22 — where fewer games were played — was 38 (22%). Moreover, 32 goals have already been scored in stoppage time — the highest total ever recorded at a single edition of the tournament. The reason: exhaustion. Footballers are playing more minutes than ever before. Before the tournament, FIFA announced rules aimed at clamping down on time-wasting. A five-second timer has been introduced for both goal kicks and throws. Once a goalkeeper has the ball in their control, they are obligated to release it within eight seconds, or else risk conceding a corner. But the increase in playing time extends beyond the World Cup. A European club would play a maximum of 13 matches in the Champions League before the 2024/25 season. The number now stands at 17. Throw in FIFA's Club World Cup to that, where Chelsea and Paris Saint-Germain had to play seven competitive games at a time they would have spent playing only friendlies. More matches, coupled with the heat in USA, have amplified fatigue.

SHUVADITYA BOSE

other elements too. Technically you can be very good but (young players) wouldn't be as good if they didn't have an emotional control of the situation; that's what truly makes the difference," he added.

It helps him, in identifying the virtues he looks in players as well as building a relationship, that he has coached most of them in the youth circuit.

Father figure

Rodri, Unai Simon and Merino featured in the eleven that lifted the U-19 Euros in 2015. Four years later, he guided a side featuring Fabian Ruiz, Olmo and Oyarzabal to claim the Under-21 Euros. Ferran Torres, Pedri and Marc Cucurella have all been managed by him at either the under-19 or under-21 rungs.

Rather than an autocratic, dogmatic manager, he is a genial fatherly figure who does not torture players with long power-point presentations. Players relax by playing chess and La Pocha, a Spanish card game, or cycle in the countryside, or play golf.

After every match, he texts the non-squad staff members like the groundsman, security worker or the kitchen staff. Sometimes, he gives them small gifts too.

He is landing big trophies to his country, and it is safe to say that he has tamed the "big bull" he had feared.

Yamal 2.0: Provider of passes for Spain, hard worker off the ball



Lamine Yamal's influence has extended beyond his one goal at this World Cup. AP

Sandip G
New Jersey, July 11

THE MAGIC came in the endgame. Around the 80th minute, not far from Belgium's box, Rodri's ball found Lamine Yamal. Three Belgium players converged on him.

He dropped his shoulder to his right, like hypnotised followers of a cult guru, they followed the sway of his deceitful shoulders; Yamal paused and twisted his body in the opposition direction, leaving the defenders off-balance. The reinforcements flew in. From the corner of the eye, he found Pedro Porro. He made a step forward, as though he was taking on the tussle with the Belgians, but conjured a gorgeous back-heel to Porro.

The inventive pass came to nothing. But the moment captured the devilishness of Yamal. The tournament has not been his yet, he has struggled to hit the Euro crescendo; he has scored just a goal and is yet to register an assist. But he is here, and in fits and flashes, slowly rediscovering the player he once was, and the player that the world wants to see.

The quarterfinal against Belgium was his best outing of the World Cup, where he discovered his blithe spirit, his slippery speed, the satin touches and the joie de vivre. He did not score a goal, but was the most captivating player in a circus spectacle of wits. That's the beauty of Yamal too. There would be days when he might not score a goal or produce an assist, but he would still offer joy to his beholders.

It took only two minutes into the game to break the Belgian press and slalom up-field. The panicked left-back Maxim De Cuyper copped a foul to stop him. But hope brimmed in the stands. It could be the afternoon Yamal unshackles. Thereafter, whenever de Cuyper and Yamal faced-off, Kevin de Bruyne and Jeremy Doku would hurry to assist

After the game, where he was announced as the player of the match, he fired France a warning: "If anyone should be afraid it should be them — we knocked them out of the Euros."

him. Doku is a bona fide trickster himself, but Yamal duped him into a back-heeled nutmeg that had the Belgian transfixed. To stop him from wreaking damage, Belgians had to obstruct or soft-foul him.

The Yamal wave began to rise in the arena; the chants rang like a chorus from a spiritual retreat centre. Belgium sensed fear — Leandro Trossard dragged him down, and luckily escaped without a card. It seemed as though his only objective was to humiliate his adversaries with his obscene trickery.

He made a turn on the touchline, a svelte, frictionless swivel like in salsa, that made de Bruyne, a sublime player himself, watch him admiringly. He even turns his rivals into fans.

After pulling off a trick, he would smile mischievously. He would smile when the goalkeeper saves his shots, or when it flies narrowly wide. He nearly pulled off a typical goal of his, dancing into the box and curling the ball into the post. But he didn't get the required whip into his shot. "Just a millimetre," he would gesture at his teammates. He would hit the target thrice, but bereft of the stinging wattage his left instep could produce.

Power missing

That power is perhaps the missing ingredient in his game. It would come, for he is so glittering a player to not keep shining forever. "We have to keep in mind he's

coming off the back of an injury. Now, heading into a crucial week, he's ready to perform at his best and is motivationally prepared," his manager Luis de la Fuente said in the press conference.

Lamal didn't wallow in his miserable goal-scoring run. He was unhurried, not trying too hard, held his composure and exhibited imagination. He put on defensive shifts, frequently provided through balls to his teammates, and worked hard off the ball to keep the shape. He had a hand in Fabian Ruiz's first goal.

Receiving the ball from Pedro Porro, he slipped it back to him with a gorgeously-weighted pass.

The left-back cut it back to Ruiz. De la Fuente called this Yamal 2.0.

"It's another, improved (version of) Lamine. As the youngsters would say, we are seeing version two-point-something," he reflected. "But it's (also) very simple, pure mathematics. If you're able to attract the attention of several opposition players, it means other (players) or areas of the pitch are left unprotected," he added.

As the game wore on, he became more assertive and transformed into Spain's leader on the attacking third. His confidence spilled onto his words.

After the game, where he was announced as the player of the match, he fired France a warning: "If anyone should be afraid it should be them — we knocked them out of the Euros."

Both France and Yamal would remember the goal. He ripped a curving devil from 25 yards out. The build-up was equally memorable. He swayed away and everyone followed him.

He paused, zipped away and wrapped his instep on the ball. The goal broke France and Spain completed a stirring turnaround. Maybe, he is preserving his best for the reunion.

FALLING SHORT OF GREATNESS

Belgium's golden generation leaves without trophies, but not without relevance

Shuvaditya Bose
New Delhi, July 11

IN BELGIUM'S red, you could not find any blues.

There was no reticence in Rudi Garcia's eloquence. "I reminded everyone to be proud of our World Cup run."

There was no pain behind Axel Witsel's prestige. "There is pride in the way we played." There was no confusion in captain Youri Tielemans' confidence. "We gave our everything. I am sure the country will be proud of us."

Kevin De Bruyne echoed: "I am proud of the World Cup I had."

The abundance of pride might lead an unsuspecting reader to believe these words were spoken after a Belgian victory. They were not. They came in the immediate aftermath of their 2-1 quarter-final defeat to Spain.

content with defeat in a sport that leaves so little room for nuance? Yes, Garcia's men were facing the reigning European champions, but they are also Belgium. Ranked eighth. A former semifinalist. They are no strangers to football's biggest stages.

But they once were. When Spain lifted the World Cup in 2010, Belgium had not even qualified. They had, in fact, been thrashed 5-0 by the same opponents during qualifying. Two years later, Spain won the Euros. Belgium, once again, could not qualify. They drew against Azerbaijan in the qualifiers on that occasion.

It was one of the reasons Marc Wilmots accepted the national team's managerial job. He had grown weary of pretending to be neutral while commenting on tournaments his country never reached. Vincent Kompany

watched every World Cup and Euros because he adored football, and yet, he hated every minute of it because Belgium were never there.

Kevin De Bruyne grew up idolising England's Michael Owen. Thibaut Courtois's favourite was Spain's Iker Casillas. No player captivated Axel Witsel quite like France's Zinedine Zidane, while Romelu Lukaku dreamt only of scoring goals like Brazil's Ronaldo. Belgium's would-be heroes had to look elsewhere because of the dearth of Belgian heroes.

On Friday, the most glorious chapter of Belgian football concluded. The curtain fell on a golden generation that lifted the country from 68th in the FIFA rankings after that 5-0 humiliation by Spain to No. 1 just nine years later. There were no pompous celebrations, no poetic justice, only a quiet acceptance that their



Kevin De Bruyne is one of the golden generation players. AP

time had passed.

The golden generation of Belgian hockey yielded an Olympic gold, a World Cup, a European Championship and two FIH Pro League titles. But not the De Bruynes and Luka-

kus. But they leave with something larger — the realisation that they belong.

Even when they won nothing, Belgium's golden generation won something Belgium have had teams

that punched above their weight, but they were never blessed with talent.

They were not meant to. A nation of just 11.8 million people — only a couple of million more than London, fewer than the population of Ile-de-France and barely a fifth of Spain's. Its professional pyramid comprises only 33 clubs; England has 92.

The reforms

Then came the reforms of 2006. Government-funded football schools emerged. The De Bruynes and Courtois were nurtured here. While Brazil debated how to stem the exodus of teenage talent to Europe's elite, Belgium embraced it. A small nation like theirs could ill-afford to keep the best talents at home and stagnate their growth. Only three players in Belgium's current squad represent domestic clubs. In 2002, there were 15.

The plan worked. At the 2018 World Cup, there was barely a team more intimidating than Belgium. History records only that France won the semi-final 1-0. Not that Belgium had 64 percent ball possession, or that they completed 539 passes to France's 287. It forgets that Thomas Meunier, who had shackled Neymar in the quarter-final, was suspended.

Like in Inglewood, context gave way to consequence. It did not matter that Youri Tielemans — Belgium's best player in this tournament, who had covered the most distance by any player — was injured during the warm-up. Or that his midfield partner, Amadou Onana, was nursing an ACL injury.

Or that number one goalkeeper Courtois was injured during the game, and his inexperienced deputy, Senne Lammens' error resulted in

Mikel Merino's winner.

Or that De Bruyne, too, had to be substituted because he was experiencing discomfort in his leg.

None of it mattered. Only that Spain were through.

Addressing questions after the game, Garcia whispered, perhaps more as a self-realisation than a statement to the journalists: "There is nothing to be ashamed about the defeat, because we looked Spain eye-to-eye. But I am disappointed for those who might not be called up again, for whom this was probably the last World Cup. They deserved more. This is harsh. Fate was not on our side."

Then again, football, like life, is seldom fair. And yet, both have a curious way of rewarding those who fall short.

Belgium's golden generation did not win a cup, but won relevance that the nation longed for.

Kranti takes ungaudy fifer as India dominate on Day 2 at Lord's



Kranti Gaud took five wickets. AP

Shuvaditya Bose
New Delhi, July 11

KRANTI GAUD became only the third Indian woman to take a Test five-for in England today, following Purnima Rau and Jhulan Goswami, as India bowled England out for 170 to seize a 115-run first-innings lead on day two at Lord's. Gaud struck in her first over, a wobble-seam delivery tailing in late to have Maia Bouchier caught behind. The celebration was muted, as if she knew there was more to follow. Three balls later, Sayali Satghare trapped Heather Knight lbw, and Gaud soon returned to shape one away and uproot Alice Capsey's stumps on debut. England slid to 47 for 4, still 45 shy of their lowest Test score on home soil, before captain Nat Sciver-Brunt and Amy Jones added 84 for the fifth wicket, scoring 44 and 52.

Sneh Rana broke the stand, finding Jones' inside edge through to short leg, and the pacers returned after the interval to replicate their earlier craft. Gaud trapped Sciver-Brunt lbw with another in-swinging, Satghare removed Sophie Ecclestone, and Rana topped one through bat and pad to bowl Mady Villiers.

Gaud's fifth wicket nearly slipped away. Lauren Bell edged towards the slips; Rana spilled the chance at second slip, but Shafali Verma, diving to her right at first, held a stunning one-handed catch. Deepti Sharma completed the innings soon after, trapping Lauren Filer lbw for her third duck in five Tests. Gaud finished with 5 for 37, the youngest Indian woman to take a Test fifer, surpassing a record that had stood in Goswami's name.

Strong position

India, who had made 285 all out on the first day, ended the second day at 154/1, with their lead being 269 runs. After scoring 83 in the first innings, Smriti Mandhana is currently unbeaten on 69, with her partner, Yastika Bhatia batting on 39. Shafali Verma departed after scoring 33.

After a wicketless T20 World Cup, Gaud returned to fundamentals: the same line and length, bowled with unrelenting consistency. There was nothing gaudy about it, only simplicity. It earned her a fifer, and a place on Lord's honours board, the first woman's name there belonging to a bowler from Chhindwara, Madhya Pradesh.

BRIEF SCORES: India 154/1 (Smriti Mandhana 69*, Sophie Ecclestone 1/46) & 285 (Smriti Mandhana 83; Sophie Ecclestone 3/68) vs England 170 (Amy Jones 52; Kranti Gaud 5/37), lead by 269 runs

INDIA LOSE T20I SERIES 4-0

Total surrender in England

India's new T20 era under Shreyas began with more questions than answers as World champs suffered a fourth defeat

Shankar Narayan
Mumbai, July 11

FOR INDIA'S T20 team, the start of a new era was supposed to bring fresh possibilities. Taking the captaincy from Surya-kumar Yadav, Shreyas Iyer was supposed to usher the team into a new direction after the T20 World Cup triumph. The regime change was supposed to be smooth. It has been anything but. Six completed games into Iyer's captaincy across Ireland and England, India remain without a win, slipping to another defeat, this time by 56 runs in Southampton. With this loss, they have also lost their No. 1 ranking to England.

Chasing 258 for a consolation win in the fifth T20I, India needed one of their best batting efforts of the series to avoid a 4-0 defeat. The drama began even before a ball was bowled. Sanju Samson was surprisingly recalled to the playing XI after missing the last three games. He showed his compatriots how to counter the short ball by pulling. Josh Tongue twice into the stands in the second over. India needed much more of the same, but a few overs later, he fell to Sam Curran for 27.

At 65/2 after six overs, India were a shade behind where they needed to be. England did not rely on the short ball as frequently as they had in the previous two matches, perhaps because of Samson's early onslaught, but their disciplined bowling ensured India were never allowed to break free.

Ishan Kishan provided the visitors the only significant resistance in the chase, scoring a brisk 56 off 35 balls. He showed the intent required to take on England's attack, pulling, Josh Tongue for a six and repeatedly using the pace on offer to find boundaries.

Kishan and Shreyas Iyer began to mount a takedown of the target, combining singles with timely boundaries despite the asking rate escalating almost every over. But Iyer's dismissal in the 11th over gave England the opening they needed.

The southpaw continued to keep India's hopes alive after his captain's departure, but eventually fell to Adil Rashid in the 13th over, slog-sweeping towards deep midwicket, where Phil Salt completed an excellent running catch. His dismissal ended India's fading hopes of mounting a serious challenge in the chase.

The rest of India's batting unit got starts, but none could convert them into the kind of explosive innings required in a chase of this magnitude. Despite late resistance from Tilak Varma, who scored a 25-ball 53, the world champions fell far short of the finish line.

India's bowlers endured another difficult outing, de-



Indian batting and bowling failed simultaneously as the team was outplayed by England in all departments. REUTERS

spite making the ideal start. When Prasidh Krishna dismissed Phil Salt in the second over, it briefly raised hopes of a much-improved display. Instead, it proved to be the visitors' solitary moment of joy, as the English batters' unchallenged dominance turned the innings into a one-sided assault.

Jos Buttler led the charge with a spectacular 131 off 64 balls after managing only 8, 36 and 0 in his previous three innings of the series. The former captain combined power with innovation, smashing 12 fours and eight sixes to bring up his century in 51 deliveries, before delivering the final push in the final overs. India had a chance to halt his charge when Suryansh Shedge dropped a straightforward catch at deep extra cover after Buttler had reached three figures.

Harry Brook matched Buttler's aggression, finishing unbeaten on 95 off 45 balls with four fours and eight sixes. He brought up his fifty in just 19 deliveries and, along with Buttler, dismantled India's attack with a 233-run partnership for the second wicket. What began as a recovery after Salt's early dismissal turned into complete domination of the bowling attack.

Axar Patel conceded 63 runs in four overs, while Prince Yadav leaked 60 without a wicket. Suryansh Shedge also went for 39 in three overs, while Prasidh Krishna's early breakthrough came at the cost of 38 runs.

The fielding only added to India's growing problems. Apart from Buttler's dropped catch, Brook also survived late in the innings, while several inaccurate throws towards the wicketkeeper reflected a lack of sharpness on the field.

BRIEF SCORES: England 257/3 in 20 overs (Jos Buttler 131, Harry Brook 95 not out) beat India 201/8 in 20 overs (Ishan Kishan 56, Tilak Varma 53; Sam Curran 2/29) by 56 runs.

Dropping Vaibhav exposes a lack of clarity from Gambhir and Iyer

Shankar Narayan
Mumbai, July 11

INDIA HAVE benched, for a single match, a player they have already picked ahead of the man replacing him for the Zimbabwe tour that follows it.

That is the contradiction sitting underneath Southampton, where the fifth T20I between India and England was played.

Teenager Vaibhav Sooryavanshi was left out of the playing XI, with Sanju Samson returning to the side. Samson, however, is not part of India's squad for the three-match T20I series in Zimbabwe later this month. Sooryavanshi is.

On the face of it, the decision to drop Sooryavanshi seems justifiable. He has recorded scores of 13, 14 and 15 in his first three T20Is. With the team struggling for form and down 3-0 in the series, young players are not guaranteed a longer rope, and the management may have felt experience was the safer option.

Recent tough decisions

But set against India's recent decisions, this latest change raises a larger question about the direction Gautam Gambhir and the team management are trying to take.

It was only a few days ago that Samson himself was dropped, after the second T20I in Manchester. In came Sooryavanshi, who became India's youngest international cricketer. The move signalled India were willing to look beyond immediate results and invest in a player they believe could become part of their future.

Southampton presented another opportunity for that investment to pay off, against a



Vaibhav Sooryavanshi scored 42 runs in three innings. CREIMAS

If the priority is finding "the best going forward," Sooryavanshi, not Samson, was the more logical choice, given he is the one still in the frame for Zimbabwe.

strong English attack, on conditions not conducive to batting. For a 15-year-old thrown into the deep end, three matches is not a large enough sample to draw conclusions either way. Instead, India have gone back to Samson.

Captain Shreyas Iyer offered an explanation at the toss. "I feel this is the time we need to try what's the best going forward for us as a team. So based on that, we decided this." If the priority is finding "the best going

forward," Sooryavanshi, not Samson, was the more logical choice, given he is the one still in the frame for Zimbabwe. This is not to suggest Sooryavanshi should never be dropped. Selection should always be based on performance, conditions and team balance. But there needs to be consistency in the message that accompanies those decisions. Constant chopping and changing risks a camp that is insecure, and always second-guessing its abilities.

Sooryavanshi may well have failed again in Southampton. Samson made 27 off 14 balls before he was caught behind off Sam Curran, brisk, but not the emphatic knock that would have settled the argument either way. Neither outcome answers the actual question: whether India's selections reflect a clear and consistent vision, or a team management still working it out in public, one match at a time.

Following in Kvitova's footsteps, Noskova wins Wimbledon title



Linda Noskova defeated Karolina Muchova 6-2, 5-7, 6-3 . REUTERS

Bhuvan Gupta
New Delhi, July 11

FIFTEEN YEARS ago, as Petra Kvitova tasted her first Grand Slam success, a six-year-old Linda Noskova sat watching in awe from afar. By 2014, when Kvitova emerged victorious again, the starry-eyed kid from Czech Republic's Vsetin had firmed up her desire to emulate the two-time Wimbledon champion. On Saturday, Noskova lived her dream. She became the youngest women's champion at SW19 since her idol Kvitova in 2011.

Noskova got the better of friend and Paris Olympics doubles partner Karolina Muchova in a sinusoidal thriller, turning the tide in the decider after squandering five championship points and a 5-2 lead in the second set. In a match befitting a final, the wisdom of Muchova's experience nearly prevailed before the fearlessness of Noskova's youth came up trumps.

Momentum swung wildly, and there was a phase when Noskova did not know where the next point would come from. But in the end, she was able to summon her evident big-serving, heavy-hitting powers to bail her out and won 6-2, 5-7, 6-3. Muchova struggled at the start amid the London heat, appearing uncomfortable and moving gingerly in the first set. Noskova capitalized, breaking Muchova's serve in the fourth game with an inch-perfect backhand winner. Muchova valiantly saved four set points, but the 21-year-old finally converted the fifth with a splendid lob which the 2023 French Open finalist could not reach in time.

The second set, too, seemed like going Noskova's way for the longest time. She banked on her big serve to save three break points in Game 3, and then converted her first break point in the sixth game to move to 5-2. But Muchova refused to give up. She staved off three Championship points on serve, and cracks began appearing in Noskova's game. The youngest stuttered when in touching distance of the trophy, double faulting to squander her fourth match point.

Opportunity knocks

Muchova saw the opportunity and pounced on it. She took a see-saw ninth game to bring the set back on serve, and then conjured a regal forehand down the line to claim her fifth straight game and the set along with it.

Noskova, paralyzed by nerves, desperately needed a break and stormed off the court. It worked like magic as she broke the shackles to finally

hold serve again, at the start of the third set. The touch that had deserted her was back; the booming serves were landing again and the long levers were aiding well-directed returns. She rode those attributes to dismantle Muchova's resolve, breaking in the second game.

The senior pro continued to fight, nevertheless. She never discounted a comeback like the second set, and when the scoreline read 2-5 again, perhaps hoped for an encore. But Noskova was not buckling under now. Well in control of her emotions and strokes, she did the basics right and ward off Muchova's threat. The fateful point arrived, and she sank to the ground in disbelief. The dream had come true, indeed.

Overwhelmed and in tears, she made her way up to her players' box. Her family was equally overcome with emotion, and her father got the first hug before she did the rounds with the rest of her team.

Muchova, meanwhile, was gracious in defeat and lauded the gumption of her "ex-friend". "You are so young, this is your first final at a grand slam, the way you handled it and the way you played is really unbelievable. Beyond this you are an especially very kind person, and human being, so congratulations to you and your team. You deserve it," she said in her runners' up speech.

As for Noskova, it was a bitersweet moment, as she remembered her late mother, who passed away two years back from cancer. "It feels incredible. It's been so tough, physically and mentally. It's never easy to get the last point and Karo, you made me work so hard for it. I'm so happy I could play my first Slam final with you, we made history today. I believe that all our Czech fans at home are proud of us, so no matter the result, I think it was a good day for both of us."

She added, "I want to thank my dad for coming here and my family members, I know you don't like flying, so I appreciate it." She then thanked her late mum. "I definitely wouldn't be standing here without her," she said, blowing a kiss into the sky.

It was the first SW19 final between players of the same country in 17 years, since Serena Williams beat elder sister Venus in 2009. Noskova is the latest to follow in Kvitova's grass-court footsteps from the nation; Marketa Vondrousova and Barbora Krejickova lifted the Venus Rosewater Dish in 2023 and 2024, respectively. Going by tonight's riveting duel, there's plenty more where that came from.

CHANGING TIMES FOR VETERAN

Djokovic finally has all the love; the wins are what's slipping away now

Sandeep Dwivedi
New Delhi, July 11

FOR MOST of his sparkling career, Novak Djokovic had the wins but not quite the love he thought he deserved. Now he has the love, but the wins have grown elusive. Is Djokovic at peace with life's either-or reality? Has he come to accept that longing never dies, it merely takes new forms? And why does the GOAT, who averaged two Grand Slams a year in his prime and is now without a Major for close to three years, stick around?

On the very courts he has dominated for years now, these days he gets frequently outclassed – like during Friday's Wimbledon semi-final where he lost 6-4, 6-4, 6-4 to the legend-in-making Jannik Sinner. The answer can't be found on the court. It is hidden in the

smiles on the faces of his two little children when they watch him win, and in the collective roar of an entire stadium when they cheer him. Trophies he has had many, but these days Djokovic is collecting something he missed for years.

Painted as the party-popping villain by countless Federer and Nadal fans through the Big Two era, he is now the clear crowd favourite at Slams. Djokovic may or may not get his 25th Slam, but he is gathering new memories, priceless enough to outweigh the bitterness of once feeling unloved.

One such moment came at the end of the five-hour, five-set epic in this Wimbledon's quarter-final. Djokovic mentioned that he had asked his children to go to sleep, since it was well past their normal bedtime, but they hadn't. In his heart of hearts, he would have

wanted them to stay.

Back in the day, whenever the Serb was asked about retirement, he would mention his kids: he wanted them to grow up and witness what Dad was good at. Now it was happening. He would later say, "I'm glad they stayed because it was honestly one of the best matches I was part of on this court in my career."

'My hero'

Some time back, his son Stefan was asked to write an essay on 'My Hero' at school. He picked his father instantly. A few years later, he was courtside at Wimbledon 2023, looking anxious, as the young Spaniard Carlos Alcaraz drew close to beating his father. Stefan looked tense; he couldn't bear to see his hero lose. He didn't have to. After the match, Djokovic teared up when he saw Stefan in the stands. The child



Novak Djokovic lost to Jannik Sinner in the semis of Wimbledon. AP

looked confused, mouth agape, a few front teeth missing, too young to fathom the occasion's weight for his father, or why grown-ups cried even when they were happy.

Something changed at Centre Court that day. The so-far partisan crowd flipped. Wimbledon had booed Djo-

kovic when he played Federer, clapped at his double faults, and celebrated his errors. They weren't ready to see their adopted royalty, the grass-court king, dethroned, least of all by an unfancied Serb rocking the boat. Djokovic's tears, the innocence on Stefan's face, that day many stiff English upper lips

Painted as the party-popping villain by countless Federer and Nadal fans through the Big Two era, he is now the clear crowd favourite at Slams.

quivered. Against Sinner, the Centre court regulars chanted 'Novak, Novak' in the third and final set even when the world knew a comeback was out of question.

For most of this fortnight, the Djokovic family has charmed the crowds. In the early rounds, Stefan sat in the box with a boy his own age, cousin or friend unclear.

Every time his father hit a winner, Stefan looked at the boy beside him with a smug

smile, half the audience himself.

Tara, two years younger than Stefan, isn't into tennis. She isn't seen on the training courts. She loves ballet and gymnastics and has her own way of having fun with her father. In one on-court interview, Djokovic revealed that his daughter had been teaching him the Pompa, loosely "pump it up" in English. He said he is yet to master it, since Tara hadn't given her approval.

He would ask Tara to demonstrate and the cameras would find the little girl with blonde pigtails in the stands. The crowd would let out a collective "awwww," the way they once did for the Federer twins.

It isn't that Djokovic was never loved. He was the crowd's darling in his Djoker years, mimicking other players, fooling around on court, the amusing

underdog who threatened no one's place in history. But as he began beating Federer and Nadal, threatening their legacies, the affection curdled. He didn't just have critics but toxic trolls and vicious haters.

That history still surfaces when he least expects it.

After equalling Federer's Wimbledon win record in the third round this year, he was told the number: 105, level with the Swiss champ. He looked almost bored by the question, before breaking into the line that drew laughter from Centre Court: "I propose a match-up between me and Roger for 106. Whoever wins gets it. Let's just stop it here and let's call Roger to come."

He quickly switched to Tara's dance training again and spoke at length about it. The Centre Court swooned once more.

EYE

JULY 12, 2026

Anatomy of a Riot

Joe Sacco's *The Once and Future Riot*, captures the aftermath of the 2013 Muzaffarnagar riots in Uttar Pradesh, with care, without closure

Parvathy Thiruvothu on being a realist



Nihal Koshie

NEERAJ CHOPRA'S arm throws a javelin ninety metres. On a tennis court, the same arm produces what his wife calls a speedy serve. Himani Mor should know. She represented India at the ITF World Juniors and was crowned All India University Champion, and when the two of them hit during his off season, she is the one standing on the other side of the net and by her own careful assessment, he comes across as a natural on court.

"We play tennis together during his off season. Last year, he could not because of injury," Himani says, matter of fact rather than starry eyed. "Because he has a fast arm, his serve is really good. I jokingly told him to take up tennis once he retires. He has a good ball sense and hand-eye coordination."

It is a small, private image, two elite athletes trading serves without trying to outdo each other. Whether it says anything about the marriage itself is not obvious yet. It gets clearer once you see how they run everything else.

...

Himani, 27, and Neeraj, 28, have been married for over a year-and-a-half. Himani is from Sonipat, Neeraj from Panipat, neighbouring districts in Haryana. Their families had known each other for years before the wedding and the friendship goes back further than the fame does.

"We have known each other since 2016, before he won the junior World Champion-

"We want to keep athletes and their priorities at the forefront. We want to create an ecosystem that works around athletes' schedules, allows them to balance their training and professional commitments"

HIMANI MOR

Managing Director, Vel Sports Management

ship," Himani says. "I used to train at the Sports Authority of India's centre in Sonipat and so did he. My family is into sports. My cousins are wrestlers, boxers, and my parents were kabaddi players. My father was the Indian team captain at the first circle kabaddi world cup in Pakistan in 1983. There was a common interest. You talk to each other, get to know each other, and that's how our relationship started. Our families were aware. That's how we got married."

She calls it a fusion of arranged and love. At a private ceremony in Solan in January last year, India's most decorated track and field athlete took his marriage vows with a woman who had watched his career long before he became India's Golden Boy.

...

In January this year, the partners in love became business partners too with a common interest. Neeraj founded Vel Sports Management. Himani became its managing director. Alongside it sits the Neeraj Chopra Foundation, another project close to the couple's heart, and mentoring the next generation of athletes is one of its stated ambitions, something the two of them talk about together rather than strictly as colleagues.

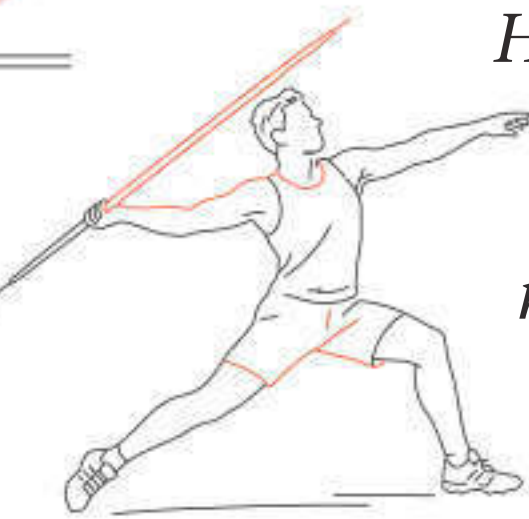
Though Neeraj is still an active athlete, his dream is for the agency and the foundation to become legacy projects that outlast his playing career. A small team of trusted hands, Himani among them, runs the day-to-day work.

Vel Sports did not open by signing athletes. It opened by deciding how to create an athlete-first approach.

"We want to keep athletes and their priorities at the forefront," Himani says. "We want to create an ecosystem that works around athletes' schedules, allows them to balance their training while also maintaining their professional commitments. Being athletes ourselves, we understand what it takes to perform at the highest levels and what approach is best for an athlete. Because one missed session can cost them a lot. The focus is to create a balance where both sides can mutually benefit and work together to create meaningful campaigns," Himani says.

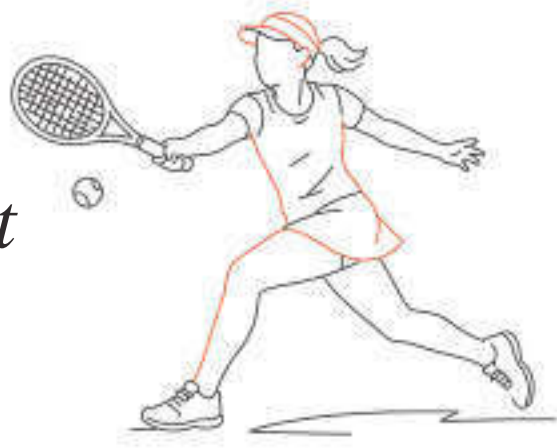
In a video shot when Vel Sports was launched, Neeraj talks about a similar creed. "Athletes can work with brands when they are not training or competing. This way there is a mutual understanding (between an athlete and brand). An athlete's career or performance should not be affected," says Neeraj.

After gaining insights from his own career, Neeraj wants the next generation of athletes to be better prepared, on and off the field. "At the start of my career, I didn't have



Himani Mor is a tennis champion in her own right.

But there's more to it. Being the wife of ace javelin thrower Neeraj Chopra also means rallying for athletes' causes, staying mindful that the business doesn't get in the way of the personal and building a legacy together



enough knowledge on how to compete, how to plan. And I didn't know enough on how to work with brands," he says.

Active athletes building their own management companies is common enough elsewhere. Floyd Mayweather, Oscar De La Hoya, LeBron James, Lewis Hamilton and Coco Gauff have all done it and, in India, Sunil Gavaskar was doing it in the mid '80s, co-founding Professional Management Group (PMG) during his playing days.

"Another reason for starting Vel Sports is because Neeraj wanted his own trusted team to take care of everything. He wants to focus on the sport," Himani says. "He might have another six years as an athlete. At this stage, throwing ninety metres is just a number. But he wants to create a legacy. He is now looking at breaking records and not just about winning a gold. He wants the next generation to have the mindset that they can win at the highest levels of sport and stay at the top. Through his achievements, he wants to set an example for our next generation of champions... where they know that if our fellow athlete did it, we can do it too."

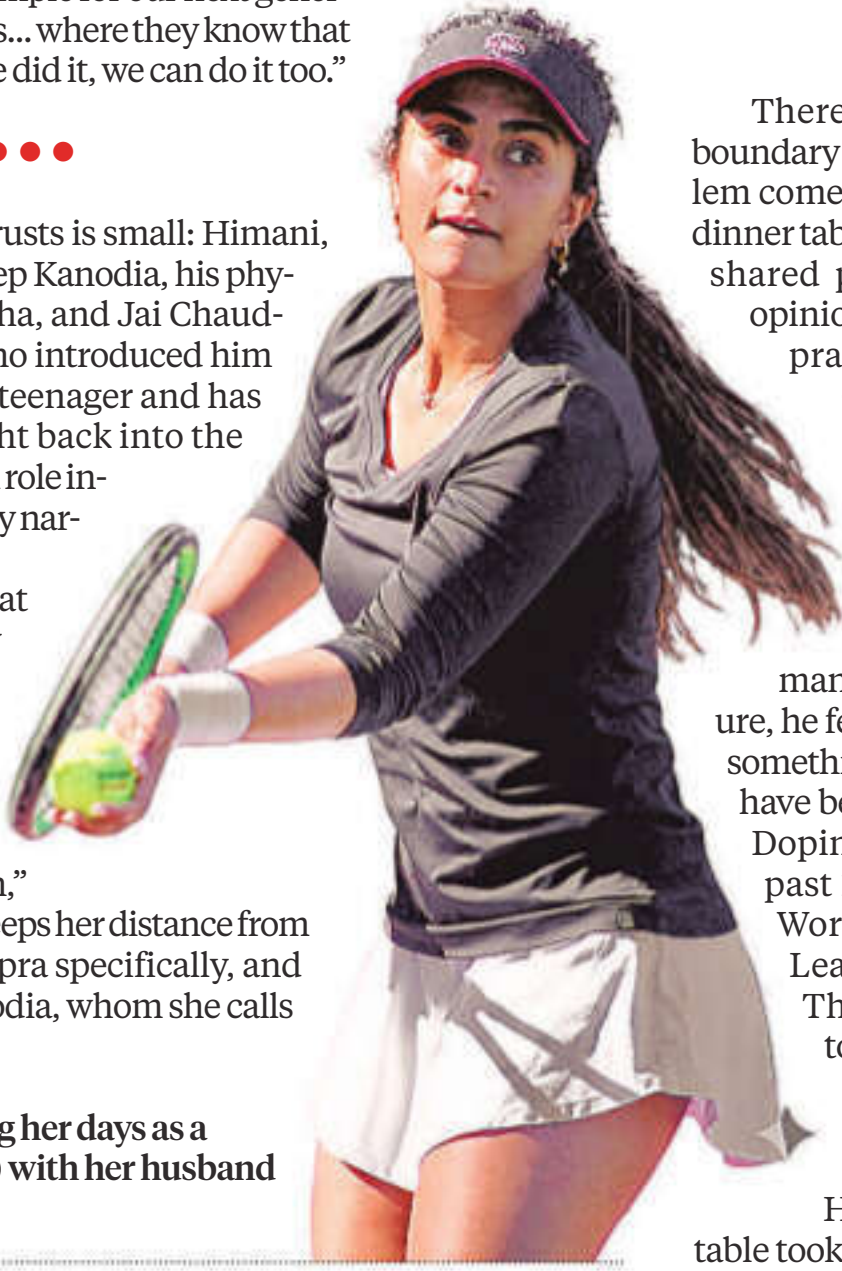
...

The team he trusts is small: Himani, his manager Sudeep Kanodia, his physio Ishaan Marwaha, and Jai Chaudhary, the coach who introduced him to the javelin as a teenager and has since been brought back into the fold. Himani's own role inside it is deliberately narrow but focused.

"It is crucial that he gets to know only the really important stuff on the athlete management side of things. I give direction to his vision," she says. But she keeps her distance from Brand Neeraj Chopra specifically, and leaves that to Kanodia, whom she calls

MATCH POINT

Himani Mor during her days as a tennis player; (top) with her husband Neeraj Chopra



Sudeep. "If there is something we have to ask him, Sudeep is the one who does that. I don't interfere in anything because I don't really look at myself as his manager. We decided to keep it this way because we have the other relationship of husband and wife. We don't want the business to get into our personal lives."

The same principle holds inside team meetings, where business etiquette is followed just as strictly. "If something has to come through him, his manager is the one who asks him, or his international manager Lukas Wieland, even though I am right next to him at meetings or living with him," says Himani.

The boundary is a decision, not an accident, and Himani states it plainly, with no interest in whether it sounds unusual. It is also close to a description of the marriage itself: two people who know what the other is capable of, working out how well they actually play together.

...

There is one subject on which the boundary disappears. India's doping problem comes up often enough at their own dinner table that it has become, in effect, a shared project rather than a private opinion. Last month, the Neeraj Chopra Foundation and the Indian Olympic Association signed a memorandum to launch Clean Sport, a national anti-doping awareness campaign, and Neeraj will speak at its events.

"When we hear about the news (doping), we feel bad," Himani says. "Because of Neeraj's stature, he feels he has a responsibility to do something. Like telling fellow athletes, 'I have been in the NADA (National Anti Doping Agency) testing pool for the past 10 years. I won the Olympics, World Championships, Diamond League, and I am a clean athlete.' That's the message he wants to give."

...

Himani's own path to that dinner table took longer, and cost more, than her

impressed by how many matches she was winning, had two clay courts built for her.

"During my career in India, I never had a coach," she says. "I wanted a sponsor for hiring a coach and fitness trainer. I wrote emails to academies abroad when I was 16-17 years old. Coaches were willing to train me, but I never got a response from a sponsor."

A full scholarship offer arrived from Louisiana State University, US. She assumed it was fake and didn't reply. A similar offer came later from Southeastern Louisiana University, US, and this time, she went. "I had never lived alone and always had my mother with me. But I moved because I would get a coach."

A wrist injury ended any hope of turning professional. What was left was the degrees, an MBA in sports management and human resources, finished while playing and studying at once, and an MS in sports management from UMass Amherst, US, after her NCAA eligibility ran out.

"I went to the US in 2018 as a transfer student. In the US, undergrad is four years, in India, it is three. I did my undergrad from Miranda House in Delhi, but there, I had to complete the extra year. So I took seven courses to be done in one year. Usually you have five courses in one semester. I am used to managing multiple things."

Days after the wedding, she flew back to New York to finish that degree. Neeraj went along and they spent 10 days together before he left for training and she returned to her books. They didn't see each other again for six months. Now, based in Panipat, Himani is the one who travels to be with Neeraj rather than the other way round. The

"Athletes can work with brands when they are not training or competing. This way there is a mutual understanding... An athlete's career or performance should not be affected"

NEERAJ CHOPRA

Champion javelin thrower; Founder, Vel Sports

first time she watched him compete live as his wife was the Paris Diamond League in 2025, followed by Ostrava and the NC Classic in Bengaluru, three stadiums standing in for the six months they had just spent apart.

...

What she describes of him off the field reads like a different person from the one who competes. "He looks very aggressive on the field but he is completely opposite otherwise," she says. "If we go somewhere and there is a kid, he will play with the kid. He has a pure soul, and that is why I admire him. He is not fake. I can't stand fakeness. He is also fun loving. He opens up to very few people, so it is hard to get that side of him."

» CONTINUED ON PAGE 4

Here's the Tree Tea

T R Shankar Raman's *The Trees of My Country* is a comprehensive document of 50 trees found across India

Ranjit Lal

IN THIS book, T R Shankar Raman, who describes himself as a writer-turned-wildlife scientist-turned-writer, profiles 50 native Indian trees to be found through the length and breadth of the Indian sub-continent and beyond (the Andamans and Nicobar and Lakshadweep Islands). There is a personal connect with each of the species, which he has seen and admired during his scientific surveys and studies, in the varied landscapes of the country.

Each tree is accorded its taxonomic profile, its name in various Indian languages, the environmental conditions it grows in (grassland, desert, tropical rainforest), a detailed description of its physical attributes — size, shape of leaves, type of flowers and seeds, methods of seed dispersal et al, and the myriad uses we may have put to them to — felling for timber and firewood, harvesting of leaves, fruit and resin for fashioning brooms, thatching, furniture and even toothpicks, and the many medicinal properties they may or may not have.

In addition, there are the cultural and religious aspects that are mentioned too: Why some trees are worshipped. What their historical connections are. Every tree is a storyteller, whether it has lived for 1,000 years or just 10. It is a witness to history that is told through its appearance, in the rings it develops on its trunks, the wild-life it provides sanctuary, food and drink to, its girth and height. While the trees are astonishingly varied in their character, one theme runs strongly through the book, applicable to possibly every species: The mindless, brainless, greed-driven, grasping, utterly destructive attitude we have towards our natural environment and every living thing that depends on it, and that may be seriously endangering many species. We are also radically short-changing the coming generations.

Trees are often on the frontline of this treatment — lush rainforests felled, in what can only be called genocide, for the building of dubious (but money-making for a few) colossal dams, and substituting with money-spinning plantation species such as oil palm, which suck up all the life from the earth. We say we will cut down a million trees in the Nicobar islands — many of them endemic — but, not to worry, we will make good by planting 10 million in dusty, arid Haryana. It is this foolish, ultimately self-destructive, mindset that needs a radical reboot.

Some of the qualities possessed by these trees are truly mind-boggling and we haven't even got anywhere near to the bottom of it. The bael is a virtual pharmacy in its own right — a complete anti-all-illness (from cancer to heart to kidney to viral to ulcer ad infinitum) cure, besides making a refreshing summer drink and is naturally worshipped and revered.

Raman makes you wonder if the minister, possibly of environment, forests and climate change, sitting behind his magnificent teakwood desk in a deodar-panelled office ever pauses to think about the magnificent trees that may have given their lives for this privilege. The nature-loving Brits, of course, had no love lost for these grand trees and the forests they made, as they hacked them down *en masse* for the making of railway sleepers.

Of course, all of us are not manic tree-hackers. There are many individuals and communities who will protect them with their lives, if necessary. An example is the Chipko movement (a landmark forest preservation movement led by women in the 1970s), which governments disapproved of instead of celebrating and encouraging.

Manali Patil's beautiful water colour illustrations bring this book to life. Like its author, the book also needs a multi-hyphenate reader: a reader-turned-wild-life scientist-turned reader. Yes, a background in botany would be helpful but there's enough prose to keep the average reader engrossed till the very end.

Lal is an author, environmentalist and birdwatcher

Making Word's Worth Count

A polyphonic narrative history of *Khabar Lahariya*, The Good Reporter celebrates resilient journalism through intimate vignettes

Srikar Raghavan

THE COVER is a real screamer — we see women writing, striding, listening, clicking photos, carrying loads, while the men (appropriately enough) are either policing or loafing. The book is authored by Disha Mullick, but its full writership is (rightfully) shared by multiple women journalists from across the social spectrum. An unusual biography of a feminist organisation, written with disarming candidness and style, *The Good Reporter* is a polyphonic narrative history of *Khabar Lahariya* (KL) — a maverick media space that has been championing hyper-local, women-led journalism in the patriarchal boondocks of Bundelkhand. Having begun as a door-to-door newspaper in the early 2000s, KL has now transformed into a video-centred digital



THE GOOD REPORTER
BY DISHA MULLICK
Simon & Schuster
699 pages
₹238

platform that reaches millions of viewers every month. At its core, it has always been a tight-knit web of female reporters, predominantly from underprivileged backgrounds, reporting from several districts of Uttar Pradesh and Madhya Pradesh.

Khabar Lahariya remains a fiercely mutinous and embattled community. We learn that “in the past two decades, we have had long-time team members confront or succumb to acid attacks, long illnesses, accidents, suicide. This is in addition to the intense violence we have witnessed in our work, and still do, on a daily basis.” The grim old cliff of adversity emerges constantly in the narrative but the writer(s) also emphasise just how personally liberating this adventure of journalism has proved to be — “a buffer, a protective aura, a role we could forget ourselves in for a brief

Anatomy of a Riot

Joe Sacco's *The Once and Future Riot*, which has been withdrawn in India by its publishers, captures the aftermath of the 2013 Muzaffarnagar riots in Uttar Pradesh, with care, without closure

EP Unny

EVEN A prolific cartoonist like Rajinder Puri, not known to shy away from anything political, was wary of commenting on communal riots. The topical news cartoon has no space to reflect on the collective violent outburst. Pithy punchlines made under the day's deadline could, in the middle of conflict, be grabbed by either side to further polarisation.

It took Joe Sacco to break this self-imposed cartooning reticence. Now we see how a riot in India could be talked about in book-length cartooning with precision, empathy and, most of all, perspective. Like every chronicler of Hindu-Muslim strife, Sacco goes back to the birth pangs of the two nations — the trauma of millions displaced like the Karachi-born Puri. Sacco does it early on, on page 7, in a masterly stroke that sums up the 1947 Partition of the subcontinent in one page. He doesn't dwell on it, urges you to read on.

This urge to narrate without a pause marks Sacco's graphic reporting that has come to stay as 'Comics Journalism'. The whole book is one straight flow. One chapter ends and the next begins without much ceremony on the same page. The page itself is packed. Sacco seems to share the familiar *horror vacui* (the fear of vacant space) seen in masters such as R Crumb. His basic page spread is too crowded to accommodate text. He finds space for commentary and conversation by packing words into little rectangles and shrunk speech balloons, strewn like pinned up notes on a bulletin board. The enhanced page looks breathtakingly detailed with lined faces, clenched fists and every strand of dried wild grass woven into basket chairs inked in rigorously. Too many props, too few words, no horizon line, no plumb line and no neat panelling. The stories Sacco tells bleed across panels and layers.

You learn to handle disorder, if you have done most of your work in zones of conflict, some chronic enough to have spilled over from the last century to this. Sacco has travelled, sketched and reported major global conflicts for over three decades — from Israeli-occupied Palestine in the 1990s, Bosnia in 2000 and Gaza in 2009. When he turned to India, he was already a veteran graphic reporter. He came first in 2010 to Mayawati's Uttar Pradesh to report “not just abject poverty but real hunger” among Dalits in Kushinagar. Higher caste groups kept chasing him out. His contingent had to make multiple short duration forays into villages to do what he calls hit-and-run journalism.



GAJENDRA YADAV

ON THE MOVE
Muzaffarnagar riots victims evicted from Loi village relief camp; (below) Joe Sacco

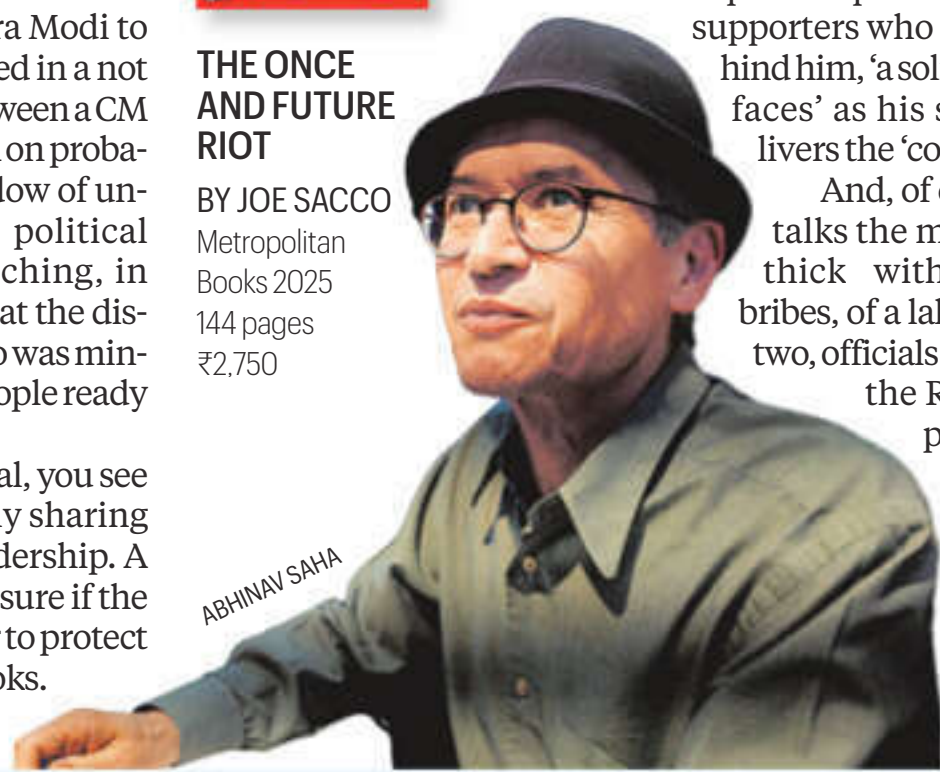
When Sacco came again, this time to Muzaffarnagar in 2014 to research a communal riot, the stint was less eventful. The riot itself had happened a year back in 2013 and the dust had somewhat settled. Sacco couldn't have chosen a better time to come. UP was under Samajwadi party's Akhilesh Yadav. The rival BJP had swept the parliamentary elections with 71 out of 80 seats in UP, propelling Narendra Modi to power in New Delhi. Sacco landed in a not so polarised no man's land — between a CM unsure of another term and a PM on probation. This was a refreshing window of uncertainty when officials and political groups were waiting and watching, in no hurry to take sides. More so, at the district level and lower, where Sacco was mining memories and there were people ready to talk.

Rather than targeting the rival, you see insiders from both camps freely sharing scepticism about their own leadership. A local Muslim group is no longer sure if the Mulayam (Singh) party is keener to protect them or keep them on tenterhooks.



THE ONCE AND FUTURE RIOT

BY JOE SACCO
Metropolitan
Books 2025
144 pages
₹2,750



ABHINAV SAHA

A Hindu hardline leader is far from enthusiastic about the new BJP PM, Madan, a local journalist, talks about “lots of liberal people in the middle, with the extremes on each end. But if something happens, you will find no one left in the middle.” Organised groups arrive with visible authority. A five-time village chief accused in the riot turns up accompanied by a group of supporters who sit silently behind him, ‘a solid wall of blank faces’ as his solo voice delivers the ‘collective truth.’

And, of course, money talks the most. The air is thick with charges of bribes, of a lakh of rupees or two, officials demand out of the Rs 5 lakh compensation sanctioned to riot victims. Meanwhile, the displaced cling to re-settlement

camps braving the hissing slithering snakes, more fearful of returning to their home villages. The camp itself vanishes when the authorities want to. Towards the close of the book, there is a half-page picture of what remains of one such relief shelter — a large road-side tract of land with nothing on it except the telltale tyre tracks of a bulldozer, the state-run vehicle that has since burned up more of the nation's fuel than rockets.

There isn't anything like a closure to the story. You know the gripping narration is over when Sacco signs off at page 135. Cartoonists hate to say goodbye. They don't necessarily leave you with a sign of hope or despair. But they seem to say what they want to in the dedication. Sacco dedicates this book “to the hardworking rural journalists of India.” Rajinder Puri dedicated many of his books “to the young people of India, Pakistan and Bangladesh.” The young love comics, and have no qualms about picking up their history from a cartoonist. A pity Joe Sacco wasn't published with conviction here.

SHELF LIFE

An adventure called History



DHRUV-TARA & THE GREAT INDIAN HISTORY QUIZ
BY AMISH TRIPATHI
Westland
200 pages
₹350

AMISH TRIPATHI has written about Shiva, Ram, ancient kingdoms and forgotten gods. But the hardest part about his new book wasn't digging deep into India's history but how to present it. *Dhruv-Tara & The Great Indian History Quiz* is a children's book. “Historical research was

not a problem since I have always read a lot of historical non-fiction. The research went into how to write children's books, because when you are writing in a genre you haven't read in 45 years, you need to revisit some old books, just to get your mind into that genre,” says Tripathi.

The book, which will hit the stands on July 27, is the first of a seven-book middle-grade adventure series. It follows Dhruv Trivedi and Tara Dhoba, two rival students at a Mumbai school, who are forced to team up for India's biggest contest: “The Great Indian History Quiz.”

There are two things that have nagged Tripathi for years: History is boring, and that it is often presented, especially to children, from a “colonial gaze.” The book

was an attempt to address both. “Our historians not only did not decolonise our history but also made it so boring that most students simply don't want to explore the subject,” says the author of *The Immortals of Meluha*. He cites Bhāskara Chārya, the mathematician who taught maths through Sanskrit poetry, as proof that it doesn't have to be that way. “Can we not make history interesting in the garb of an adventure?” To that end, he has made the chapters fast-paced and used Gen Z slang. Tripathi is also convinced that curiosity in itself needs defending. He says, “If there's a skill our kids need today in the age of AI, it's curiosity. Phone, social media, free data — that is numbing the brain.” It's a big part of why Dhruv and

Tara keep asking questions.

Tripathi was also certain that he wanted to frame India's history of invasions not through a religious but an economic lens. “British rule is not called the Christian invasion, but Turkish rule is called the Islamic invasion — this was a colonial interpretation,” he says, adding that the book leans more into discovery than simply challenging the stories.

Writing the book was rewarding for Tripathi also because it let him “discover the child within him.” Recalling a scene where Dhruv is fidgeting in a swivel chair, while waiting for a teacher, he says, “That's the kind of thing I would have done as a boy.”

ANUSREE KC



TRIUMPHS AND TRAVAILS
The Khabar Lahariya team

time” — especially in these violently conservative portions of rural India. The spectre of male incompetence (and not just domestic violence) keeps surfacing too. One of the reporters spends a lakh to buy her unemployed husband a sound system plus vehicle so he can play a DJ business. “And then he ran someone over with it, and I had to bail him out with my savings.”

The prose is generously replete with Hindi phraseology, which gives it a distinct and flavourful *tadka*. But how does the book accommodate its 10 authors, this grand profusion of voices? “Our primary languages are different, our castes are different, our histories — ranging from bonded labour to foreign education — are vastly different.” To create this book, the writers came together at multiple workshops to pool their thoughts and recollections. Lots of back-and-forth translations between Hindi and English en-

sued. Long direct quotations extracted from these group discussions, either italicised or indented, are at the heart of the narrative. These are intimate, experiential, visceral and moving vignettes that continually push the reader into the narrators' shoes. They put the ‘journal’ into journalism, a personal day-to-day diary of observations and feelings, revealing details that their own families might not be privy to, sometimes also exposing grievances and conflicts with fellow Khabar Lahariyites. Indeed, the book's biggest strength is how it consciously evokes the messy arena of turbulent co-existence — fierce, radical honesty is really what makes these deep relationships sustainable and meaningful. “It was never complete, and always imperfect, this fashioning of the feminist workplace.”

In 2017, KL transitioned from print journalism to a purely digital space, a necessary

move to stay in vogue, which brought new challenges to the fore. Faces once hidden under a collective byline would now be firmly visible in the new audio-visual landscape. Mirrors and lipsticks become as necessary as diaries and pens. The ambit of their stories expands into wider, more politically significant terrains, and the “editorial prerogative became a thornier, riskier affair.” New roles and urban-rural hierarchies grapple with the instantaneous reach and excitement of social media, which is a double-edged sword, for falsehoods can now be amplified irrevocably. “An untruth by a powerful man — a Rajput *pradhan*'s son — about a woman reporter taking a bribe could spread across the new digital world and damage the credibility we had built.”

Across six chapters (and refreshing notes) that fuse the personal and the professional, we are offered a ringside view of KL's hard-fought triumphs and travails. In parallel, one takes away an immersive portrait of Bundelkhandi society — a land of *daakus*, *kaands* and *samjhautas*. Inspiring and humbling to read, the book is a song of solidarity, sisterhood and resilience. But it is equally a book that celebrates the *maza* of irreverence, laughter, hard work and self-criticism. One might compare KL to the People's Archive of Rural India (PARI), another exemplar of ground reportage but its unique praxis of feminist exclusivity makes it stand out still. So go read *The Good Reporter* or, better yet, follow *Khabar Lahariya*'s work on Instagram and other platforms — it is unlikely you'll catch a glimpse of these worlds anywhere else.

Raghavan is an author and a New India Foundation fellow

‘Across industries, representation for women is something to be fought for’

Actor Parvathy Thiruvothu on changing portrayals of women in Indian cinema, her tight filmography and her directorial debut. She was in conversation with Pooja Pillai, Senior Assistant Editor, The Indian Express

You have completed 20 years as an actor. There have been highs and lows. How has your perspective changed as an actor and as an activist?

When I started off, I was told that a female actor will have a maximum shelf life of seven years so make as much money as possible. As you get old, you won't be as desirable. Desirability and likeability were apparently more important than talent or skill. What has shifted is that I feel more courageous to begin again. That's a privilege I have earned over 20 years.

I have proven myself in acting but I'm still open to being auditioned and new roles, be it as an actor, producer or director. I'm not thinking about who I am for others. It doesn't matter anymore. As an activist, I seem to have made dialogues happen. So I am grateful I got the opportunity.

So it feels like I'm starting from scratch, again to not create a personality or an identity in the industry but to find out who I am for myself. Partly because of my determination, I have stuck on. I always like saying that they couldn't get rid of me, no matter how much they tried. I hope I continue to do that.

You have a new film, *I, Nobody*, with Prithviraj Sukumaran. It is a heist film, which is a new genre for you.

Yes. The title speaks of the identity space for the ordinary people who make up society. We tend to take it for granted. This movie is, for me, less of an actual heist and more a reflection on the current power structures, how the nobodies are actually not nobodies.

It's a reminder for the so-called nobodies to lean into their power and remember who they are. I also play one of those nobodies. But Prithvi is headlining the project.

Malayalam films are known to be down-to-earth and realistic in their portrayal but director Nissam Basheer has brought a fast-paced heist-like nature to it, which is great because everyone is thinking it's a heist film. But you will go in and realise it's a lot more.

You are one of the rare actors who has never repeated a role. What is your process for selecting a project?

I have been given roles in the drama genre over and over and I am not complaining. But I have always wanted to break open and just go into, let's say, comedy, action or play a psychopath. It would be lovely to understand different kinds of people in different settings. There is this 'bold feminist woman' role that always comes to me. As an actor, you do feel you might be repeating certain elements.

In a screenplay or a role, the first thing I look for is the intention of the director. If they don't come to you with clarity, then I don't know how to be of service to them.

You have been pretty selective in your filmography.

Yes. I have not had to fire anyone. I have had managers fire me, because I don't say 'yes' to movies enough. But I would rather sit at home than do a film half-heartedly because I'm a terrible actor in real life and am scared the cameras will capture that. So I do films where the director, writer and I can see eye to eye about what we are making.

What aspects of women's lives are we missing in cinema? Has anything changed in the last, say, 10 years?

This is one of those questions where I always come across as a cynic. The breadcrumbing of the progress does not bode well with me. There is a tokenistic approach to hiring women. But I would take that over nothing. It, however, doesn't have to be women writing women. It can be any gender wanting to write about any gender if they know the story well. Women are flawed too, beauti-



LEADING BY EXAMPLE

Actor Parvathy Thiruvothu (left) with Pooja Pillai, Senior Assistant Editor, The Indian Express

But where are these women in cinema? The assumption is people don't want to watch that. People want to watch what will titillate and entertain. But we get to choose whether we want to entertain you, yet making a caricature out of us continues in the biggest of industries. So no, I'm not happy with the speed at which its changing. It's slow.

You have another project later this year, the Amazon series *Storm*, which focuses on five women. In the trailer, no one seemed to perform desirability. Tell us how the women are different in the show.

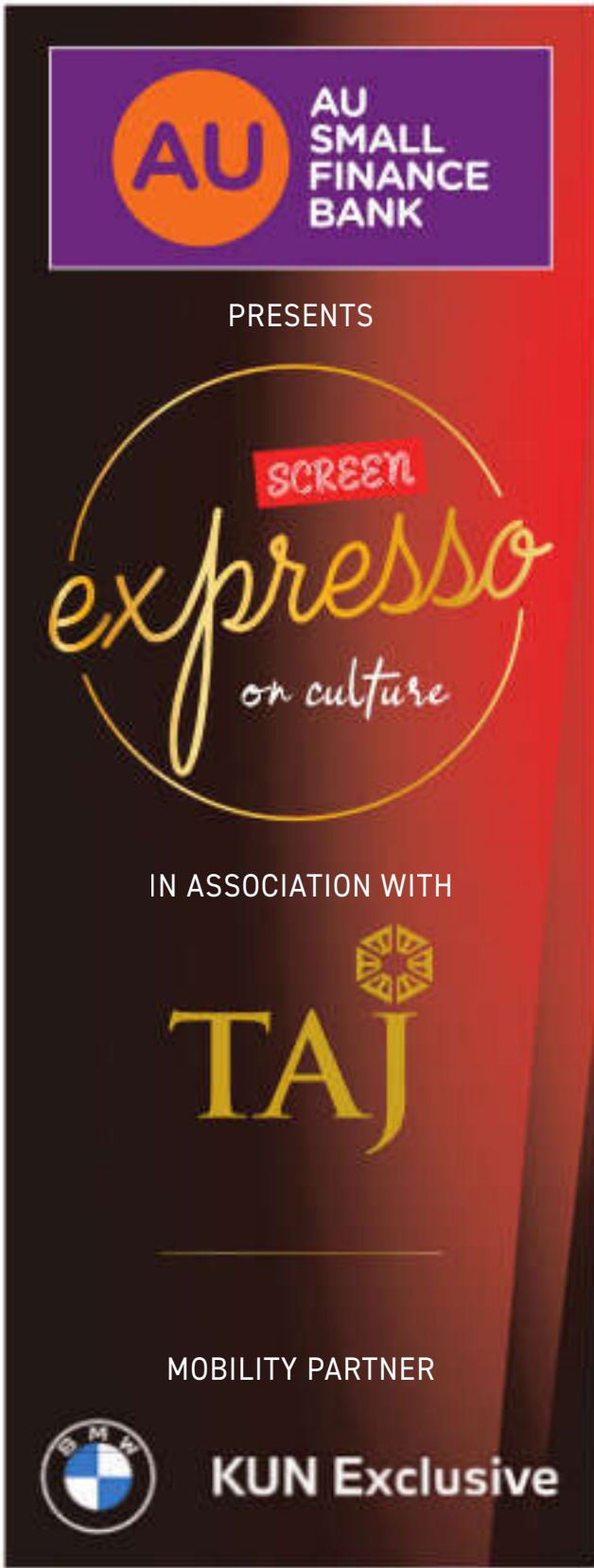
Storm is a brilliant series. It's directed by Ajitpal Singh, who has made *Tabbar* (2021) and *Fire in the Mountains* (2021). I'm proud to say I auditioned for this role. I realised that Ajit's first lens of looking at people is not gender. Those are my favourite kind of people — who see you as an individual first.

The issues and flaws of the women in the show are not made to look like they have these issues because they are women but because of systemic injustice in the country we are living in. That approach makes it more powerful. The reason you couldn't make out if anyone was performing likability is because it has been made by creators and men who view the women in their life that way.

In *Storm*, all the women have been given roles that could have been played by men. I love it when a story is interchangeable. That is why I agreed to do it.

You have worked extensively in the Malayalam industry but also in the Hindi, Kannada, Telugu and Tamil industries. How different is working in each of them?

All of them have taught me one common thing: Representation for women is something to be fought for. It's at different levels



fully so. But the moment we say she has a gray shade, she is villainised. This generalisation is belittling.

For instance, not all women are best friends. But that is not because we are women. It is because we have a certain kind of personality and value systems we don't agree on.

There is a tokenistic approach to hiring women. But I would take that over nothing



but it's not to be taken for granted. It always feels at risk; that it can be taken away. But the difference in terms of creative approach is also that it gets led with how much money an industry has.

Keeping the business part of it aside, the relationship with the audience changes quite a bit. In Tamil and Telugu cinema, I can still hope for better. The kind of characters that women get is a little more catered to the likeability part. In the Malayalam industry, the more realistic a woman is, the more accepted she is. During the making of *Take Off*, the producer told Mahesh Narayanan, the director, that he was afraid that Sameera (Parvathy's character) wouldn't be liked because she didn't smile much. Thankfully, Mahesh and I were aligned. Sameera can't smile. She is neck deep in debt. Her son has been taken away. She has enough problems. That movie was one of the biggest hits in Malayalam. In the Malayalam film industry, I can always rely on relationships. I can't always do that when it comes to other industries. That said, the loophole is OTT.

Do you see OTT purely as an opportunity or do you see it disrupting the entertainment industry in a negative way?

Disruptions are welcome and important if we sit and listen to what it is doing, and commit to learning from it. OTT opened up a space for actors who didn't have the so-called market value to get enough roles. That is brilliant. But what is OTT taking away is attention span. I don't want to tell people how to watch their stuff but this storytelling requires your attention. It might change you for the better or for worse, or at least help you self-reflect.

Do you still go to the theatres to watch films?

Yes. I watched *Obsession*, *Disclosure* Day and

Balan: The Boy twice.

Another thing is single screen supremacy — the collective experience of sitting in a dark room and watching something and being moved by it. If that is not a great opportunity for us to perform community, I don't know what is.

You said disruption is necessary for filmmaking. But there's another kind of disruption that's important in terms of working conditions. You are one of the founding members of the Women in Cinema Collective (WCC) in the Malayalam film industry. Is there any way the current churn in the industry can push for reforms as well?

To view cinema as a workplace in itself has been an uphill battle for us. We live in a space where newcomers are told, 'We are like family. Just do it. You are getting an opportunity.' That a newcomer is providing a service that can be monetised by a producer is exploiting a person's ambition. The culture has been one of deification of superstars. We tend to lose the idea of what is just and unjust.

There has been quite a bit of change in the last eight to nine years but it's a fear-based change. They are afraid of being called out, written about and the cancel culture but I'll still take it.

February 2027 will mark 10 years since the crime that led to the formation of the WCC. Have there been deeper changes in attitude towards crimes against women specifically, not just within the industry but in society at large within Kerala?

Not really. I'm someone who is keenly watching the discourse when there's a crime, especially against a woman, and have realised that around elections, there are enough conversations about the honour of a woman.

The idea that feminism itself has been reduced to a certain performativeness shows there is a rise in people who lean into what-aboutery, instead of focusing on the issue at hand. I'm too much of a realist to be happy with one or two things shifting. We are really far away from seeing something that is fundamentally shifting our attitude towards women as human beings who deserve dignity to exist.



SCAN THE QR CODE TO WATCH THE VIDEO

Last month, you were on the jury for the Kashish Film Festival. Tell us about that.

I watched 26 films from across the globe. I was with Shonali Bose and Rajshri Deshpande in that jury and we were unable to understand how an entire human life is spent suppressed. I am not afraid of someone not liking my performance because I'm not entitled for them to like me but I am entitled to my way of expressing myself as a person, my way of dressing, my way of loving. I cannot imagine not being allowed that.

One of the ways you want to put your weight behind these kinds of stories, not just queer stories, is as a writer and director. Tell us a little bit about where that is at.

My first directorial is going to be a Tamil film, which is not something I planned. If I could, I would have made a Malayalam film and that's what I was writing. This is in 2020.

My writers, who are from Chennai, reached out to me with the story. I asked about the character they wanted me to play but they wanted me to direct. I said I hadn't even proved myself by making a short film, but they were certain the story would resonate with me. I can't wait to make this film.

What stage is it at right now?

I am shooting in January next year.

When silence becomes a weapon

Nachiket Samant on mixing pulp, noir and Bollywood masala, and making his protagonist deaf and mute in *Baby Do Die Do*

Alaka Sahani

AFTER BEING fascinated by Hindi cinema's classic 'Angry Young Man' archetype for years, director Nachiket Samant wanted Huma Qureshi's revenge-seeking assassin in *Baby Do Die Do* to embody a similar kind of simmering rage. A rage that's expressed through silence and dispassion. He suggested making her character, avenging her sister's murder, a person with a hearing and speech disability. "Silence can be incredibly powerful. If someone is capable of killing or overpowering another person, that's a strong statement. She doesn't need to announce it," the director says.

Qureshi, whose dialogue delivery has long been considered one of her strengths, was initially not convinced. "From Huma's perspective, I was taking away one of her biggest strengths. Once we started shooting, she discovered another side of herself," recalls Samant, who particularly admires the way the actor expresses through her eyes.

After the film's release last week, Qureshi is being praised for her restrained perform-

ance as a hitwoman haunted by a traumatic past, while the crime drama has earned appreciation for its noir-infused atmosphere. For Samant, who previously collaborated with Qureshi on *Single Salma* (2025), this creative choice went beyond dramatic effect. It was also an opportunity to push the *Maharani* actor into unfamiliar territory. "I wanted Huma to communicate almost entirely through her eyes. That eventually made the character exciting for both of us," says Samant, who also co-wrote the screenplay.

It is during *Single Salma* that Qureshi sought the director's take on a script, titled *Sejal Supari* by Jasmeet K Reen and Parveen Shaikh, that she had already acquired. Its titular protagonist was a Gujarati. But having already played a Gujarati character in *Tarla* (2023), the actor-turned-producer had reservations about playing another. Samant suggested they make the protagonist Marathi. "That's how I came on board, along with writer Gaurav Sharma. I rewrote the screenplay and dialogues, shaping the film in my own way," adds Samant, the director of *Habbadi* (2022) and *Comedy Couple* (2020).



DARK AMBITIONS
A still from *Baby Do Die Do*; (left) director Nachiket Samant

"What we retained from the original screenplay was the core story — an entertaining, masala Bollywood narrative — which excited me because I had been wanting to make something dark and edgy. Around that story, Gaurav and I built the world of *Baby KarMarKar*, a contract killer operating in present-day Mumbai," Samant recalls. The name 'Baby' was a subconscious influence from the infamous drug dealer

Baby Patankar, and 'Karmarkar' fit the rhythm of the story. "Karmarkar has this old Marathi humour attached to it. In my father's generation, there were these light-hearted jokes about the surname, which loosely translates to 'do die do'," he shares.

Huma, known for performances in *Gangs of Wasypur* and *II* (2012) and *Monica, O My Darling* (2022) among others, and her brother, actor Saqib Saleem, together founded the production house Saleem Siblings, which bankrolled the film. "They knew I wanted to take greater creative ownership

and bring my imagination to the screen. They encouraged that," says Samant. That allowed him to build "this slightly eccentric and futuristic-looking world" against the backdrop of Mumbai's cut-throat real estate business. "The world-building grew organically. The question 'what would be Baby's modus operandi' led to an umbrella becoming her weapon," says Samant, adding that the film's "pulpy, retro-glam aesthetic" is a tribute to the Bollywood films, mainly those written by Salim Khan and Javed Akhtar.

It was crucial for the film to represent Mumbai. "It is such a hybrid city. Even its food is hybrid. Vada pav and frankie are all uniquely Mumbai creations. So, I wanted the film, which is a hybrid of genres, to reflect that as it encompasses romance, comedy, action, noir and masala," says Samant.

Finding the right locations was a challenge and he repeatedly visited places. "Shooting in the gullies was important because the story deals with high-rises and towering buildings. The contrast between the two worlds had to feel authentic. That gives the film its scale and makes Mumbai an important character," says the director, who also wanted "rain to become a dynamic element". "Rain adds urgency and movement to the city. Mumbai has been portrayed in many ways over the years but this felt like our way of capturing its energy."

What lends *Baby Do Die Do* its pulsating energy is the soundtrack. Creating it was challenging because original music is expensive but Samant is happy to have found composer Arjun Iyer. "Every time I brought him a new situation in the script, he would return with a song that surprised me. Creating the music became one of the most enjoyable parts of the filmmaking process," the director recalls. The songs helped shape the film's quirky tone. In a serious sequence, the music introduced irony or playfulness.

The film's world may be loud — with rain-soaked streets, soaring buildings and an energetic soundtrack — but its emotional centre belongs to a woman who barely utters a word. For Samant, that's where *Baby Do Die Do* derives its greatest power from.

FROM HUMA'S PERSPECTIVE, I WAS TAKING AWAY ONE OF HER BIGGEST STRENGTHS BY MAKING HER CHARACTER DEAF AND MUTE

CHEF AT HOME

CREAM OF THE CROP

Meet Harsh Dixit who caters to the country's elite, from actors and cricketers to industrialist families and fitness-conscious clients

Heena Khandelwal

WHERE DOES the professional end and personal begin when a home doubles up as a training studio, a prep kitchen, a supper club and an office? At chef Harsh Dixit's Bandra apartment, the boundaries barely exist.

When we arrive one evening, Dixit and two members of the Private Chefs Club are in the middle of preparing Brie Bao for a two-day pop-up at Pooja Dhingra's cafe Pardon Our French. The bao has become one of his signature dishes. A filling of caramelised onions, leeks and hoisin sauce is tucked into soft, pillowy dough. Each ball weighing precisely 25 gm and each portion of filling is exactly 15 gm. Nothing here is left to *andaaz* (estimation). Precision, organisation and cleanliness aren't just part of Dixit's cooking style, they are part of who he is.

Dixit, 37, rose to fame as Ranbir Kapoor's private chef and now caters to the country's cream of the crop, curating private dining at their homes. In his fifteenth year as a professional chef, he runs a Private Chefs Club that trains young chefs to cook for actors, sportsmen and industrialists. His premium chef services work on referral only.

What does the job entail? "You're the head chef, the commis doing the veg prep, the butcher, the purchase manager and sometimes the dishwasher," he says, seated at the dinner table where he also hosts a supper club for eight.

Dixit was six when he decided this was the life for him—hooked by watching his mother

and grandmother. His *nanì*'s *reshmi* kebab, made in an old oven with a boiler at the bottom, remains an early memory. Cooking shows by Sanjeev Kapoor and Gordon Ramsay fanned the fire further.

In 2008, he got into IHM, Goa and by his final year, he realised his pull was toward Asian food. "Dumplings and momos were my entry point," he says. "I realised there are two cuisines Indians are perfectly happy eating every day, Indian and Chinese. You can ask me to eat fried rice or noodles seven days a week and I will happily do it."

By 2011, he was kitchen operations trainee at Yauatcha, the Michelin-starred restaurant franchise, in Mumbai's BKC (Bandra Kurla Complex). Over the next three years, he helped open the brand's outposts in Bengaluru and Delhi. When growth stalled, he moved on.

The next chapter began almost accidentally. He prepared a roast chicken for a bodybuilder friend, cooked in its own fat without extra oil or butter. The friend's comment on how he would have achieved his fitness goals had he had access to such healthy and tasty food, led Dixit to co-found Six Pack Meals, a premium subscription meal service for the fitness conscious.

A chef batchmate from college, his bodybuilder friend, his girlfriend (a Swedish pro bodybuilder) and he came together, to do

Chef Harish Dixit's foray into personal cheffing was almost accidental. It all began when he first prepared a roast chicken for a bodybuilder friend, cooked in its own fat without extra oil or butter



AMIT CHAKRAVARTY

PREPARING A BANQUET
Chef Harsh Dixit measuring every spoonful of filling for his signature baos

about 150 meals a day, for about 30 clients, from 9 pm to 7 am, after which they send out food for delivery.

Their business grew through word of mouth and Instagram, attracting actors and athletes, encouraged by an organic endorsement from Hrithik Roshan. Clients included Ranbir Kapoor, Shahid Kapoor and Sidharth Malhotra. But the founders reached the end of the road in 2017 when the four separated ways. A second attempt to resurrect the idea folded within a year.

Then the call came that led him to private cheffing. It was from Ranbir Kapoor, an old Six Pack Meals client. "Technically, Shahid Kapoor was our first client," he says.

By 2022, Dixit turned that solitary practice into something structured. His chefs now cook for cricketers on tour, actors between shoots and families wanting restaurant-calibre food at home. Today, their repertoire includes between 300 and 400 dishes, shaped not around cuisines but around the people eating them.

BRIE BAO
Ingredients

For the onion and leek jam
Onions (finely sliced) - 500 gm; Leeks (finely sliced) - 150 gm; Fresh bay leaf - 1; Butter - 30 gm; Hoisin sauce - 20 gm; Chinkiang vinegar - 2.5 gm; Potato starch - 2.5 gm; Spring onion greens (finely chopped) - 5 gm; Salt - 7.5 gm; Sugar - 7.5 gm

For bao dough
Red Lotus flour or refined flour - 200 gm; Sugar - 42 gm; Baking powder - 6 gm; Yeast - 4 gm; Milk - 95 ml; about 20 ml water

Method

- On medium flame, heat oil in a flat bottomed pan and add the onions; sweat them down. Add leeks, sugar and half the salt. Keep stirring
- Halfway through, add butter and other half of the salt, continue until the mixture has caramelised. Once the onions have

caramelised, add the starch, Chinkiang vinegar and hoisin sauce and let it cook until the starch gelatinises. Add the chopped spring onions

- Line a perforated tray/ dim sum basket with oiled



butter paper squares for individual baos

- For bao dough, place the flour, yeast, sugar and baking powder in a mixing bowl. Pour in milk and water and start the stand mixer. If the dough feels dry and stiff, add a bit more

water, one teaspoon at a time. Continue to knead at low for 12-15 minutes or until the dough is smooth and elastic. Knead the dough by hand for a couple minutes until smooth. The dough does not need to rest at this point

- Immediately weigh and portion out dough balls. Roll each dough ball out and stuff with onion & leek jam

- Place the bao in the perforated tray that you will steam it in. Cover it with a damp cloth to proof until it's risen (30-45 mins). Spray it with water mid-way through resting. Steam for 6-8 mins

- Cut a brie (cheese) wheel. Heat butter in a pan and sear the flat side of the steamed baos until golden brown. Put a slice of brie across the seared bao and torch it with a blow torch until the cheese gratinates.

- Drizzle hot honey on the cheese and serve



Neil Patil
Founder, COO & CTO, Veena World
neil@veenaworld.com

If you are a regular reader of this column, you also know that I have been to Tokyo more than five times now. And I can tell you with absolute certainty that the first time, I didn't really see it. I saw the highlights, sure. I did Shibuya Crossing, I ate ramen in Shinjuku, I stood in front of the Senso-ji temple and took the photo everyone takes. I rode the shinkansen. I came home and told everyone it was incredible, and it was. But when I went back the second time, I wasn't following a list anymore. I was just... there. And that's when Tokyo actually opened up.

The second time, I found a tiny yakitori place under the train tracks in Yurakucho where the smoke from the grill mixed with the rumble of the trains overhead. I spent an entire afternoon in Yanaka, a neighbourhood that feels like Tokyo forgot to modernise it: narrow lanes, old wooden houses, cats on every wall, and a cemetery that locals walk through like it's a park. I noticed things I had walked right past the first time: the way convenience store staff bow even when you are buying a single onigiri snack at midnight, the fact that Tokyo is almost eerily quiet for a city of 14 million people.

None of that was on any itinerary. It couldn't have been. Because you only find those things when you stop trying to do a city and start just being in it. And you can only do that the second time around. I have started calling this the Two-Trip Rule, and the more I travel, the more I believe it's true: you don't actually know a place until you have been there twice.

The First Trip Is the Trailer

Think about it this way. Your first trip to any destination is essentially a trailer for the real film. You are orienting yourself. You are ticking off the landmarks you have seen in photos. You are spending mental energy on logistics like where is the metro, which

The Two Trip Rule

exit do I take, is this the right restaurant or the tourist trap next door with the same name. You are managing expectations, adjusting to the timezone, figuring out the currency, and trying to fit seventeen things into a day that realistically holds about four.

There is nothing wrong with that. First trips are exciting precisely because everything is new. But "everything is new" also means you are processing at surface level. You see a lot, but you absorb very little. You come home with photos and memories, but if someone asks you what a place felt like, the pace of it, the rhythm of it, the personality of it, you would struggle to answer with anything beyond the guidebook version. The second trip is where the feeling starts.

Melbourne Taught Me This

I lived in Melbourne for four years, so this might be cheating slightly. But even before I moved there, I had visited twice, and the difference between those two trips taught me something I have carried ever since.

The first time I did the Great Ocean Road, I walked around Federation Square, I went to the Queen Victoria Market, and I had brunch in a café that a blog recommended. Standard Melbourne checklist. Beautiful city, great coffee, done.

The second time, I had no checklist. And that's when Melbourne became Melbourne for me. I wandered into a laneway I hadn't noticed before and found street art that was better than most galleries I had been to. I sat in a café in Fitzroy for two hours and watched the neighbourhood move, dog walkers, cyclists, people reading actual newspapers. I took the tram to St Kilda not because it was on a list but because someone at the hotel said "you look like you would like St Kilda", and they were right.

The difference wasn't the city. Melbourne hadn't changed between trip one and trip two. I had. On the first trip, I was a tourist collecting experiences. On the second, I was a person just living in a place for a few days. And the place responded differently because of it.

What Changes on the Second Trip

Here is what I have noticed happens when you return to a destination. And I think any frequent traveller will recognise this.

You skip the queue: Not literally, although sometimes that too. But you



stop feeling the pressure to see everything. You have already seen the Sagrada Familia, so this time in Barcelona, you spend the morning in the Boqueria market without rushing. You have done Times Square in New York, so this time you walk through the Upper West Side and discover it's a completely different city up there; quieter, leafier, full of people who look like they have never been to Times Square in their lives.

You eat better: On your first trip, you eat where the internet tells you to. But on second trips, you eat where the street takes you. Some of my best meals have been on second visits: a pho stall in Hanoi, a wine bar in Barcelona's Gràcia neighbourhood that had no signboard and four tables. You trust your instincts on the second trip because you have already made the safe choices. Now you are ready for the interesting ones.

You notice the ordinary: This is the big one. First trips are about the extraordinary. The monument, the view, the once-in-a-lifetime moment. Second

trips are about the ordinary. How people commute, what they eat for breakfast, how the city sounds at 7 AM before the tourists wake up. And the ordinary is almost always more interesting than the extraordinary, because the ordinary is what the place actually is. The Eiffel Tower tells you about Paris in 1889. The way a Parisian orders coffee tells you about Paris right now.

You have a relationship with the place: This may sound abstract, but it's real. When you return somewhere, the city isn't a stranger anymore. You remember the layout. You recognise a street corner. You know which side of the station the exit is on. That familiarity frees up mental bandwidth, and into that space flows everything you missed the first time. The details. The textures. The things that make a place feel like a place rather than a postcard.

The Argument Against Somewhere New

I know what some of you are thinking. Life is short, the world is big, there are 195 countries, and you want

to see as many as possible. Why go back to Barcelona when you haven't been to Portugal? Why return to Vietnam when you could try Cambodia? It's a fair question. And I'm not saying you should never go somewhere new; of course you should. But I am saying that the race to add new pins to the map sometimes comes at the cost of actually understanding the pins you have already got.

I have met travellers who have been to 40 countries and can't tell you much about any of them beyond which hotel they stayed at and which monument they photographed. I have met others who have been to five countries, three of them more than once, and they can tell you stories that make you feel like you were there. The second group travels slower but sees more. That's the paradox.

Where to Apply the Rule

Not every destination needs a second trip. Some places are genuinely one-visit experiences, and that's fine. But certain cities and countries reveal so much more the second time that I'd argue the first trip is just the setup.

Tokyo is at the top of that list, for me. So is Barcelona, a city with so many layers that one trip barely scratches the surface. Vietnam rewards a return visit enormously, especially if your first trip was the classic Hanoi-Hà Long Bay-Ho Chi Minh City route and you missed the Central Coast entirely. New York is a different city every time you go, depending on which borough you stay in. And honestly, even within India, go back to Rajasthan after your first trip. Go back to Kerala. I promise you will see a different place.

The Two-Trip Rule isn't really about the number two. It's about the shift that happens when you stop being a first-time visitor and start being someone who's returning. That shift changes what you notice, what you seek out, and what you take home with you.

Full Circle

So here is what I have come to believe. Every destination you have visited only once is an unfinished conversation. You showed up, you introduced yourself, you exchanged pleasantries. But you left before anything real was said.

The places that have shaped the way I think about travel, Tokyo, Melbourne, Barcelona, Hanoi, aren't places I saw once and admired. They are places I

For the love of sport

» CONTINUED FROM PAGE 1

She watched him hold that same evenness through the low point of the last year, an eighth-place finish at the World Championships he competed in while injured, followed by an extended break. "I won't say he was frustrated. He reflects. He decided to participate because he wanted to win a medal for the country. But after that he realised he should not repeat the mistake, competing despite injuries. I never saw him frustrated, but sometimes he gets a little upset."

His comeback came at the Doha Diamond League in June, a fourth-place finish after starting to throw again only in May, with the Commonwealth Games and Asian Games looming on the calendar. Himani has years of knowing him up close, and it shows in how she reads the result. "He is my husband, we have known each other for so many years. We are friends more than just partners. I am an athlete and I can feel what he feels," she says. "He was not like, 'Why am I fourth?' He is a smart athlete. He was feeling like he could push more, but he was throwing after a long break. After Doha he was like, 'I need to increase my training for the Commonwealth Games.'"

Outside of all of it, what they share is smaller and less strategic. Coffee, mostly. "We love coffee. When we go to a new city, we try to explore a new cafe, have a nice breakfast," Himani says. "Another thing we do together is nature walks. Whenever we are free, we try to go to the mountains. Or we cook something and go to a beautiful spot and eat there. We cook whatever is available and try to spend some quality time together."

There's a bigger story here too, sponsorship deals, a foundation, a Commonwealth Games record still to chase and more Olympic medals. But on the tennis court neither of them takes it too seriously. One of the fastest arms in Indian sport does something almost childlike: serving to his wife, and waiting to see if she gets there in time.

No prizes for guessing who has the better return of serve.

ADVERTORIAL

went back to, got a little lost in, and came home from with something I didn't have before. Not a photo. Not a souvenir. A point of view. That's what the second trip gives you. Not more of the same place. A different version of yourself in it. See you next week...

Know the Unknown

Ever since we launched flight bookings on Veena World, I have been disappearing down rabbit holes I didn't know existed. Flight routes, airport layouts, runway engineering. The kind of stuff that has no business being this interesting but absolutely is. And this week, I found one that stopped me cold. Gibraltar. A tiny British territory bolted onto the bottom of Spain, so small they had nowhere to build a runway except straight across the only road connecting it to the mainland. So that's what they did. During World War Two, they built the runway right over the road. Cars eventually got a tunnel. But pedestrians? They still walk across the active runway today. Barriers come down, a plane lands, barriers go up, people cross. It's an airport and a pedestrian crossing at the same time.

And then you take off. One end of the runway drops into the Mediterranean. The other end drops into the Atlantic. Spain is on your left, Morocco is fourteen kilometres ahead of you, and the Rock of Gibraltar, four hundred and twenty-six metres of solid limestone, towers over the whole thing. You take off between two continents, over the gap where Europe ends and Africa begins. There is no airport on earth with a more dramatic exit

Email: travel@veenaworld.com
Toll-Free: 1800 313 5555
veenaworld.com

Where to Next?

Disappeared Places



Stories that'll make you pack tonight!

Watch Now on Veena World's YouTube channel



VEENA WORLD
Travel. Explore. Celebrate Life.